Rocket Scientists' Guide to Religion

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Sky Woman – Haudenosaunee Creation Myth

In the beginning, there was a woman, Aataentsic, and she is the one who made the earth and the people. Above the world she lived, where a great tree grew that fed those in the sky country. Her husband fell sick, and dreamed that the tree must be cut. Aataentsic took the axe and struck — the tree split under her feet and fell through to the world below. Astonished, she returned to tell her husband, then threw herself after it.

Below was only water. The Turtle raised her head and saw a woman falling from the sky; she gathered the water animals — beaver, otter, loon — and asked what should be done. Beaver gave the judgment to Turtle, and Turtle ruled that they should dive and bring up soil and lay it on her back. They did, and the woman fell very gently onto the new island, and the island grew.

She was with child, and bore a daughter; the daughter bore two sons, Iouskeha and Tawiscaron. The brothers quarreled. Tawiscaron, armed with rose-hip fruits, struck Iouskeha, who was armed with stag's horns; Iouskeha struck him in the side and his blood spilled upon the land, and from his blood sprang the flint stone. Iouskeha pursued him and finished him. Iouskeha is the Sun; Aataentsic is the Moon.

In the beginning the world was dry, and all waters were gathered under the armpit of a great frog. Iouskeha cut the frog's armpit and the waters ran out and became the rivers, lakes, and seas. The animals were kept in a great cave, and Iouskeha released them one by one, wounding each in the foot with an arrow as it left; only the Wolf escaped unwounded, and that is why he is hard to catch. Iouskeha learned fire from the Turtle. It is Iouskeha who makes the maize grow.

Introduction

> Since writing the book, I have been gradually led to believe that the old stories must be taken literally if at all possible, that deep secrets and a deeper awareness of the complexity of our universe was experienced by our ancestors, and that something of their belief, and experiences can be ours once again. Vine Deloria, *God is Red: A Native View of Religion.*

This is a book about religion, but not really. As you read it, you'll come to see that "religion" is a false category, an attempt to draw a boundary around, and establish control over, specific domains of human experience. By the end of it, you will know that the boundary established by the word "religion" is completely artificial. Before Europeans came around, the things associated with religion weren't separated from daily life at all. They were integrated, like eating and sleeping were integrated. As Indigenous Scholar Vine Deloria points out, it made for a much different life.

What exactly is this boundary that the word "religion" is attempting to draw? The answer to that is not rocket science. *The word "religion" constructs a conceptualization that includes a boundary between science* (conceived of as an empirically and logically rooted search for truth) *and religion* (conceived of as a system of truth based on irrational, non-empirical views). Most Western scholars will argue that the stuff associated with religions, i.e., belief in God or gods, angels, demons, mystical experience, transcendence and all that, is part of an unenlightened past and that science is better than religion at understanding everything. Science has the answer, or will have—eventually. Religion is just a bunch of [insert pejorative adjective] stories. However, this conceptualization and the boundary that emerges is a problem. Why? Because when you examine science alongside with religion you find that science is a lot like religion in many ways, and I'm not the first scholar to say that. Science has its own creation stories, for example. In her book *Evolution as Religion*, Mary Midgley notes that "Evolution... is the creation story of our age. By telling us our origins it shapes our views of what we are. It influences not just our thought, but our feelings and actions too, in a way which goes far beyond its official function as a biological theory."[1] And science has more than just creation stories. It has religious sentiment and teleology too. Sociologist David Noble, rest his soul, wrote a book entitled *The Religion of Technology* wherein he demonstrated quite convincingly

1 Mary Midgley, *Evolution as a Religion: Strange Hopes and Strange Fears* (London: Methuen, 1985), 30.

the strong , Catholic religious undercurrents of modern science and technology.[2] In addition, Robin Horton does a great job of illustrating the intelligent, theoretically sophisticated nature of traditional African thought.

In his landmark essay "African Traditional Thought and Western Science," anthropologist Robin Horton shows that the "primitive" thinking behind African religions works exactly like scientific thinking. Traditional peoples use gods and spirits the same way scientists use atoms and molecules — as hidden forces that bring order out of chaos and explain why certain things, things not explainable by common sense, happen. They follow the same logical structure. They get invoked for the same reasons. They use the same analogical thinking patterns and impose the same limitations. [3] There is nothing irrational about these thinking systems. They are so similar to science in fact that Horton was accused by critics of trying to "blur the undeniable distinction between traditional and scientific thinking" and trying to "presents traditional thinking as a species of science."[4] He did definitely blur that distinction in a frightening way for some. But, not to worry. In Part II of his article he assures his scientist buddies that there is a difference and that it "is a very simple one. Horton characterizes it as the different between a "closed" culture and an "open" culture. Traditional cultures are closed, theoretically speaking, because there is "no developed awareness of alternatives to the established body of theoretical tenets; whereas in scientifically oriented cultures, such an awareness is highly developed."[5] Scientists, in other words, change their minds easily. People in traditional culture, on the other hand, are stuck in the traditional theoretical frameworks.

That's not true, of course. As any "initiate" (undergrad student) beyond the third grade (year three) who has read Thomas Kuhn's *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*"[6] will tell you, scientists don't change their theoretical minds easily, if at all. Kuhn showed that science doesn't progress by coolly tossing out theories the moment the data turn against them. Quite the opposite. Scientists work within "paradigms" — established theoretical frameworks that define what counts as a legitimate question and even what counts as evidence. When anomalies (observations that don't fit the paradigm) pile up, scientists don't

2 David Noble, *The Religion of Technology: The Divinity of Man and the Spirit of Invention* (New York: Penguin, 1999).

3 Robin Horton, "African Traditional Thought and Western Science: Part I. From Tradition to Science," *Africa* 37, no. 1 (1967): 50–71, doi:10.2307/1158253.

4 Ibid., 50.

5 Robin Horton, "African Traditional Thought and Western Science: Part II. The 'Closed' and 'Open" Predicaments," *Africa* 37, no. 2 (1967): 155, doi:10.2307/1158253.

6 Thomas Samuel Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1962).

abandon ship. They dig in. They assume the instruments were faulty, the observations sloppy, the calculations wrong. They invent "auxiliary hypotheses" to explain away the inconvenient results, and they carry on as before, sometimes for decades, sometimes for generations. Only when the anomalies become overwhelming does the discipline enter a state of "crisis," and even then, the old guard typically goes to their graves defending the old paradigm. The new theory doesn't win because scientists rationally compare the evidence; it wins because the old scientists die off and the young ones convert. As Max Planck, one of the founders of quantum physics, put it, "a new scientific truth does not triumph by convincing its opponents and making them see the light, but rather because its opponents eventually die, and a new generation grows up that is familiar with it."[7]

That sounds awfully like a religion to me, and that is in fact where this book begins. As I will demonstrate in this book, science has *all* the features and functions of traditional religious institutions, including a focus on what Parsons considered to be the hallmark of religion, the transcendent.[8] It has a group of faithful which dutifully attend its sermons (students in weekly congregation). It has priests, like me, who embody the values and behaviours and teach acceptable canon. It even has sacred (sports events, graduation ceremonies) and even shaming rituals. Just ask Rupert Sheldrake. In 1981, Sheldrake was a well-respected plant physiologist at Cambridge(!) with an excellent reputation. He published a book called *A New Science of Life*, which proposed a hypothesis he called "formative causation." The idea was that nature is shaped not only by physical genes and chemicals but by invisible "morphogenetic fields" that carry memory and habit across time and space. A week before the book even hit the shelves, the editors of *Nature, arguably* the most prestigious scientific journal in the world, published an editorial about it. The headline? **"A book for burning?"** Think about that. The editor of *Nature*, John Maddox, didn't rebut Sheldrake's ideas with logic or experiments. He was not "open" to other theory at all, as Horton said he should be, because that's what made him different than an African tribes person. Instead, he reached for the language of the Inquisition and used his authority to shame Sheldrake out of the academy. Years later, when asked about it on the BBC, Maddox positioned himself as science's pope by invoking the real Pope's condemnation of Galileo's "heresy" (i.e., violation of church dogma) as justification.

Pope.

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7 Max Planck, *Scientific Autobiography and Other Papers*, Translated by Frank Gaynor (New York: Philosophical Library, 1949), 33–34.

8 Talcott Parsons, *Action Theory and the Human Condition* (New York: Free Press, 1978), 240.

Galileo.

Heresy.

This is not the language of open inquiry; this is is the language of orthodoxy defending the faith. The furore destroyed Sheldrake's academic career. Over twenty years later, journals were still risking ostracism simply by publishing his work. As Freeman notes in his account of the affair, the only difference between a heretic in religion and a heretic in science is which establishment is doing the glaring. In both cases, as the heretic hunter says, "error has no rights."[9]

Which brings us to back again to this book. As I will argue in this book, any reasonably analytical and logical definition of religion can contain science comfortably within. There's really no difference and I don't care if you blow your top over this. As American sociological giant Talcott Parsons said of some of the proposed boundaries between tradition and science, the "dichotomy between sacred and profane... transcendentally meaningful and worldly, becomes untenable. A particular human society... is both sacred and profane, both an embodiment of the transcendent and part of the secular world."[10] Really the only reason to draw a boundary is so that one can exclude certain topics associated, by European theorists, with religion, like the possibility of a soul, or the transcendent nature of consciousness, or the possibility of what Keith Williams calls "More-Than-Human," beings,[11] from scientific study. That is all. The point of the boundary is to close science off from certain lines of inquiry.

Science and religion are the same.

Now, the point here is not to dismiss science as just another religion. To do that is to preserve the very category of thought I wish to dismiss. The point is to dismiss the category of religion altogether. I want to do that because, as I hope you will understand by the end of this book, the science/religion dichotomy is a limiting category. It reduces what we can think about and what we can examine in damaging ways. It limits our understanding and, more to the point, it limits our potential as individuals and as a species. Any category that does that is not a good category, "scientifically speaking," especially now as the world around us spirals into chaos and debacle. If we are going to save ourselves, we need to

9 Anthony. Freeman, "The Sense of Being Glared At: What Is It Like to Be a Heretic?," *Journal of Consciousness Studies* 12, no. 6 (2005): 7.

10 Parsons, *Action Theory and the Human Condition*, 242.

11 Keith Williams et al., "Indigenous Philosophies and the 'Psychedelic Renaissance,'" *Anthropology of Consciousness* 33, no. 2 (September 1, 2022): 506–27, doi:10.1111/anoc.12161.

think with categories that nurture, empower, and expand, not atrophy and contract. If we continue on our present course with our present thinking we are, as the young folks like tosay, cooked.

This, then, is an invitation, not to replace science or shove it into a useless category, but to transcend that categorisation altogether, to think about how to transform ourselves and institutions so that they can help us do what I would argue any *authentic and uncorrupted* institution should always try to do, nurture full human potential. We need to move beyond the eviscerated and commodified version of ourselves currently on display and allow our true potential to flower and emerge. The only way we are going to do that is to pursue, in the lyrics of the 5th Dimension Song "Age of Aquarius," "the mind's true liberation." We can only do that by breaking out of our limited mental structures and exploring who we are in totality. I know it might sound like a lot, but it's not rocket science. It's a lot easier than you think and, really, our only true hope of salvation.

Age of Aquarius

Harmony and understanding
Sympathy and trust abounding
No more falsehoods or derision
Golden living dreams of visions
Mystical Crystal Revelation
And the Mind's True Liberation

1. Our Journey Begins

As noted, this is a book about religion, and science. It is a book written to help you understand exactly what religion is and, just as important, what it isn't. Here we are going to ask the questions "What is religion?" and "Is it different from science?" These questions matter because, whether you like it or not, religion, whatever that might be, has been and continues to be a central part of human society. It has been that way since its inception, and probably before. My favourite theorist on the subject of religion, Ninian Smart, concurs. He says that "throughout history and beyond in the dark recesses of the human race's earliest cultures, religion has been a vital and pervasive feature of human life."[12] He's right, although I might change the word "feature" to "force" because religion is definitely a powerful force, for great good and terrible evil—a Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde sort of affair.

As a powerful force for good, it motivates people to extraordinary acts of generosity and morality. Arthur Brooks, in his large-scale study of charitable behaviour in America, found that "religious people are far more charitable than nonreligious people."[13] They are also more altruistic than their secular counterparts. He concluded that "in years of research, I have never found a measurable way in which secularists are more charitable than religious people."[14] He isn't alone in this finding. Many studies find that religious participation is the single strongest predictor of charitable giving and volunteering.[15] Sikhs have the *langar,* a free community kitchen that is part of every Sikh gurdwara (temple). These kitchens serve anyone regardless of religion, caste, or status. Major gurdwaras serve tens of thousands of meals daily and are run entirely by volunteers (*sevadars*). The largest langar in the world, at the Golden Temple in Amritsar, feeds between 50,000 and 100,000 people per day.[16] Hindu organisations have built and run charitable healthcare for well over a century. The infrastructure of care we now take for granted, the

12 Ninian Smart, *The Religious Experience*, 5th ed. (Upper Saddle River, NJ: Prentice Hall, 1996).

13 Arthur C Brookes, *Who Really Cares : The Surprising Truth about Compassionate Conservatism : America's Charity Divide--Who Gives, Who Doesn't, and Why It Matters* (New York: Basic Books, 2006), 34.

14 Brookes, *Who Really Cares : The Surprising Truth about Compassionate Conservatism : America's Charity Divide--Who Gives, Who Doesn't, and Why It Matters*, n.d., 34.

15 Robert D. Putnam and David E. Campbell, *American Grace: How Religion Divides and Unites Us* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 2010).

16 "About Golden Temple Langar: World's Largest Free Kitchen Feeds over 50,000 People Everyday Here!" (Times of India, 2023), https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/travel/destinations/about-golden-temple-langar-worlds-largest-free-kitchen-feeds-over-50000-people-everyday-here/articleshow/105558743.cms.

hospital itself, has its origins in religious institutions.[17] Today the Catholic Church alone manages, by its own (likely inflated) estimates,[18] roughly a quarter of the world's healthcare facilities — around 117,000 hospitals, clinics, and homes for the sick.[19] The Uganda Muslim Medical Bureau runs 63 rural facilities.[20] At the highest level, religion has been the driving force behind some of humanity's most important moral advances. The abolition of the slave trade in Britain was spearheaded by the evangelical William Wilberforce. The American civil rights movement was led by the Reverend Martin Luther King Jr.[21]

Of course, "not all religious leaders in America were abolitionists. On the contrary, many were staunch supporters of slavery,"[22] and worse. To borrow a phrase from *Star Wars*, religion also has a dark side.[23] You can use it to send people off on violent crusades, as the Catholic Church did throughout the 11th–13th centuries.[24] You can use it to justify torture, as Catholics and Protestants did in the 16th and 17th centuries when they tortured and burned one another across Europe.[25] In colonial New England, Puritans hanged nineteen of their neighbours as witches in 1692, using religious justification to ease their troubled souls.[26] Buddhist monks blessed Sri Lankan soldiers in the civil war and, in Myanmar, Buddhist nationalism fuelled the expulsion of the Rohingya.[27] In India, religious nationalism has precipitated waves of communal violence from 1947 to the present.[28] And at Jonestown in 1978, a single charismatic preacher, Jim Jones of the Peoples Temple, persuaded (and forced) over 900 people to drink what many of

17 Guenter B. Risse, *Mending Bodies, Saving Souls: A History of Hospitals* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999).
18 Jill Olivier and Quentin Wodon, "Faith-Inspired Health Care Provision in Ghana: Market Share, Reach to the Poor, and Performance," *Review of Faith & International Affairs* 12, no. 1 (2014): 84–96.
19 C. Schumann and T. Ziegler, "The Contribution of Faith-Based Health Organisations to Public Health," *British Journal of General Practice* 61, no. 590 (2011): 534–35.
20 Bernard Appiah, "Handle with (Faith-Based) Care," *CMAJ: Canadian Medical Association Journal* 185, no. 5 (March 19, 2013): E219–20, doi:10.1503/cmaj.109-4393.
21 David J. Garrow, *Bearing the Cross: Martin Luther King, Jr., and the Southern Christian Leadership Conference* (New York: William Morrow, 1986).
22 Putnam and Campbell, *American Grace: How Religion Divides and Unites Us*, 250.
23 Mark Juergensmeyer, *Terror in the Mind of God: The Global Rise of Religious Violence*, ed. 4 (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2017).
24 Thomas Asbridge, *The Crusades: The War for the Holy Land* (New York: Ecco, 2010).
25 Cullen Murphy, *God's Jury: The Inquisition of The Modern World* (Houghton Miflfing Harcout, 2012); Toby Green, *Inquisition: The Reign of Fear* (Pan Books, 2008).
26 Mary Beth Norton, *In the Devil's Snare: The Salem Witchcraft Crisis of 1692* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 2002).
27 Stanley J. Tambiah, *Buddhism Betrayed? Religion, Politics, and Violence in Sri Lanka* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1992).
28 Ashutosh Varshney, *Ethnic Conflict and Civic Life: Hindus and Muslims in India* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2002).

them knew was poison, some of them killing their own children in the process.[29] You can reject religion if you want. You can pretend it is a dumb relic of a more primitive past, as too many scholars have done. But its powerful influence remains.

So, we ask the question, "What is religion?"

Unfortunately, this is not an easy question to answer. Many people have tried to pin it down; the vast majority have failed. It is a major problem openly acknowledged by scholars in the field.[30] Belzen, for example, states plainly that "generations of scholars have failed to achieve a consensus on how to define it."[31] As Molendijk notes, already by 1901 scholars could identify 48 definitions of religion![32] "In the social sciences, there is no consensus..."[33]

In the legal context, "no consensus...."[34]

In religious studies, no consensus.[35]

All we have is "no consensus." It is a major problem. I am using AI (Kimi AI) to do a rough collation of all definitions that exist. We are currently at 68 and counting.[36]

I will address some of the reasons for the definitional difficulty in the next chapter. For now, I'd like to strip religion down to its essential core and state a basic fact about religion upon which I am sure we will all agree, and that is this: religion is an institution created by human beings. Synthesizing the definitions

29 Rebecca Moore, *Understanding Jonestown and Peoples Temple* (Santa Barbara: Praeger, 2009).

30 J. G. Platvoet and A. L. Molendijk, eds., *The Pragmatics of Defining Religion: Contexts, Concepts and Contests* (Leiden: Brill, 1999).

31 Jacob A. Belzen, "Paradoxes: An Essay on the Object of the Psychology of Religion," in *The Pragmatics of Defining Religion: Contexts, Concepts, and Contests*, ed. J. G. Platvoet and A. L. Molendijk (Leiden: Brill, 1999), 93.

32 Arie L. Molendijk, "In Defence of Pragmatism," in *The Pragmatics of Defining Religion: Contexts, Concepts and Contests*, ed. Jan G. Platvoet and Arie L. Molendijk, vol. 84, Studies in the History of Religions (Leiden: Brill, 1999), 3–19.

33 Ahmet Erdi Öztürk, "Politics in Religion, Religion in Politics," *International Journal of Religion* 4, no. 1 (2023): 1, doi:10.33182/ijor.v4i1.2837.

34 Alex Deagon, "Towards a Constitutional Definition of Religion: Challenges and Prospects," in *Research Handbook on Law and Religion* (Edward Elgar Publishing, 2023), 17–33, doi:10.4337/9781788977807.00011.

35 Ezra Chitando, "A Curse of the Western Heritage? Imagining Religion in an African Context," *Journal for the Study of Religion* 10, no. 2 (2022): 75–98.

36 Mike Sosteric, "Definitions of Religion," 2026, https://repo.lightningpath.org/resources/definitions-of-religion.pdf.

of several other theorists,[37] I will say that an institution is a set of norms, rules, roles, expectations, incentives, and sanctions that systematically organize human behaviour towards some specific end.

Norms are the unwritten social standards: arrive on time, raise your hand, wait your turn, don't interrupt, respect personal space, do neat work, use an indoor voice, etc. **Rules** are the explicit, often written prescriptions and prohibitions: don't plagiarize, don't cheat, no phones, no bullying, meet deadlines, attend daily, dress appropriately, and so on. **Roles** are the distinct social positions or "parts" that people play: teacher, student, principal, janitor, etc. **Expectations** are broader role-based or predictive beliefs about what people should do or what will likely happen. We expect teachers to prepare lessons and grade fairly. We expect students to study and participate. We expect parents to support attendance. We expect that if we study, we pass and if we graduate, that we will get a good job. **Incentives** are the rewards or deterrents that motivate compliance. These include grades, stars, praise, awards, scholarships, graduation, college admission, and also fear of detention and parental disappointment. **Sanctions** are the actual consequences for violations of norms and rules. These include detention, suspension, expulsion, failing grades, loss of credit, and informal consequences like shame, gossip, ostracism, and exclusion. Together, these norms, rules, roles, expectations, incentives, and sanctions systematically organize how people behave in schools towards some future goal.

As we can clearly see in Table One below, religion is an institution in the same basic sense. Like all institutions, it has norms, rules, expectations, incentives, and sanctions. Like all institutions, religion is designed to organize (you might say control) human behaviour and aim it at some specific end.

37 Douglass C. North, *Institutions, Institutional Change and Economic Performance* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990); W. Richard Scott, *Institutions and Organizations* (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications, 2001); Elinor Ostrom, *Understanding Institutional Diversity* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2005); Geoffrey M. Hodgson, "What Are Institutions?," *Journal of Economic Issues* 40, no. 1 (2006): 1–25, doi:10.1080/00213624.2006.11506879.

Table One: School and Religion as Institutions

Term	What it is	School examples	Religion examples
Norms	Informal, shared standards of behaviour	Arrive on time; raise your hand; wait your turn; don't interrupt; respect personal space; use an indoor voice.	Dress modestly; fast on certain days; remove shoes in sacred space; show deference to elders or clergy.
Rules	Formal, explicit, often written prescriptions or prohibitions.	Don't plagiarize; no cheating; no phones; attendance is mandatory; dress code; no bullying; assignment deadlines.	Dietary laws; Sabbath restrictions; membership requirements; baptism or confession rules; prohibitions on certain marriages or practices.
Roles	The parts that people play	Students, teachers, principal, maintenance staff.	Priests, deacons, the faithful, guru, granthi, etc.
Expectations	Role-based or predictive beliefs about what someone should do or what will happen.	Teachers should prepare lessons and grade fairly; students should study and participate; parents should support attendance. "If you study, you'll pass."	Clergy should teach and model virtue; parents should raise children in the faith; believers should attend services. "If you sin, you'll be separated from God."
Incentives	Rewards or deterrents that motivate compliance before the fact. Can be formal or informal, positive or negative.	Grades, stars, praise, awards, scholarships, graduation, college admission; fear of detention or parental disappointment.	Salvation, enlightenment, eternal reward, community belonging, status, peace; fear of hell, excommunication, or shame.
Punishments / Sanctions	Actual consequences imposed for violation. Formal or informal.	Detention, suspension, expulsion, failing grade, loss of credit; informal: ostracism, shaming, gossip, exclusion.	Penance, excommunication, shunning, loss of membership, divine or cosmic punishment (purgatory, hell, karma), social exclusion.

We will consider what the goals of religion might be later. For now, let's stay focused on the definition. At this point we can define religion as an institution. As an institution, it is designed to organize human behaviour towards some specific end. This is *prima facie* true. You don't do alll the work of building an institution for random reasons. You do it to organize human behaviour towards some specific end. Whatever else it might be, religion is at least this—an institution.

Of course, knowing that religion is an institution is important, but it is not the whole story. In biological terms, this tells us religion's *genus.* A genus is a taxonomic rank that groups closely related species together based on certain shared traits. Here the genus is institution and the closely related

elements are norms, expectations, goals, roles, etc. Religion's genus, that it is an institution, tells us that religion is not a private feeling, not a mood, and not a delusion. It also tells us religion is an organized, human-built thing, like a school or a government. This is worth knowing. But knowing religion's *genus* doesn't tell us what religion *is*, exactly, because it doesn't tell us how religion differs from all the other institutions out there. That is the part we actually care about.

To see the problem clearly, consider how biologists define things. Imagine a biologist who defines "bird" as "an animal." Is the statement true? Yes, absolutely. A bird is an animal. A religion is an institution. But is it a definition of bird? Not even close, because worms are animals, whales are animals, and so are you. The statement places the bird in its broad biological class, its *genus,* but it gives us none of the special features that make a bird a bird and not a beetle: feathers, wings, a beak, eggs, hollow bones. A proper definition needs two parts. It needs the genus, the nearest broad class the thing belongs to, and it needs the *differentia*, the specific feature or features that distinguish the thing from everything else in its genus. A bird is a **feathered** animal. Now you can separate a bird from every other animal on Earth with a single question: does it have feathers?

Our definition of religion so far gives us the genus, institution, but not the differentia. It tells us that religion belongs to the same broad class as schools, banks, families, courts, and hockey, but not what makes it different from a school, a bank, or a hockey franchise. It tells us that it is an institution, but it does not tell us what type of institution. On that question, the definition is silent. And notice there is a second gap: the definition says institutions organize behaviour "towards some specific end," but it doesn't tell us what religion's end *is*. For education, the end is learning. For banks, the end is profit and the movement of money. For religion… the definition doesn't say. Whatever the end (or ends) of religion turns out to be, identifying it is part of the differentia we are missing.

So the definitional work is only partially done. We have the genus. We need the differentia. This, I would argue, is exactly where the centuries of confusion come from. The 48 definitions Molendijk found by 1901, the 68 and counting in my own files, all of them are rival attempts to supply the differentia. Everyone is mostly agreed on the genus. The fight is over what distinguishes religion from other institutions, particularly science, that humans have built. We turn our attention to the *differentia* next.

A note on sources: This book cites two kinds of material. Scholarly citations—books, journal articles, and primary documents—support factual and theoretical claims. You will also see occasional references to SpiritWiki, an open online encyclopedia associated with this text. These links are grounded in scholarly citations, but they are not offered as evidence for claims (though you might find evidence in the citations they include). They perform a pedagogical and theoretical function. They provide me with a tool that I can use to structure and explore theoretical frames. They provide you with signposts and pathways of exploration, included so interested readers can explore a concept, example, or debate in more depth.

When a SpiritWiki page appears in a citation, read it as an invitation to dig further, to reflect and even theorize, not as the basis for a claim.

2. What is Religion?

So, what is religion? At this point I am sure we can all agree that religion is, like science, like education, like a bank, an institution. The question now is, what makes religion different than, say, science, education, and a bank? If we want a better understanding of religion, we need to see what makes it different. We need, in other words, its *differentia*.

Before you started this book, you might have thought that answering this question would be easy. You might have even felt thought that you had a basic answer. After all, religion has been around for thousands of years and scholars have been studying it for just as long. Unfortunately, answering this seemingly simple question has proven quite difficult. This definitional problem is so challenging in fact that sociological giant Max Weber declined to provide a definition of religion at all,[38] instead arguing we should simply observe and study it to see what is there.

Why is it so problematic? There are several reasons

For one, the problem has been exacerbated in recent decades as notions of what counts as religion have expanded beyond the boundaries of traditional institutions like the Catholic Church or the Buddhist temple to include a "bewilderingly fuzzy" array of spiritual phenomena like the "New Age movement, flying saucer cults, radical environmentalism, eco-feminism, human potential groups, [and] holistic therapies... Even sport, fitness and dietary practices have been claimed by some as essentially religious in nature or at least forms of spirituality very akin to religion."[39]

Another reason for the difficulty is that religion, whatever it actually is, a "doubly rich and complex phenomenon."[40] I would argue it is one of the most complicated and difficult human phenomena to wrap your head around. Despite the fact that some scholars dismiss religion as just a bunch of dumb people engaged in some collective/infantile delusion,[41] it is very far from that. As we will see when we discuss substantive and functional definitions of religion, religion is a

38 Max Weber, *The Sociology of Religion* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1963), 1.
39 Malcolm Hamilton, *The Sociology of Religion: Theoretical and Comparative Perspectives* (London: Routledge, 2001), 13.
40 Smart, *The Religious Experience*, 3.
41 Sigmund Freud, *The Future of an Illusion* (New York: Anchor Books, 1961), https://amzn.to/2EZqqgZ; Richard Dawkins, *The God Delusion*, Feb. 12 (New York: Mariner Books, 2006).

culturally, politically, psychologically, economically, and spiritually complex institution with an authentic core and a breathtaking depth. As Weber realised, even under the best of conditions, it is not so easy to wrap your head around this complexity.

A third reason we struggle to define religion is because we have this Occam-led desire to simplify things down to a single sound bite, a simple, single "enlightening" statement that we can deploy. For reasons that have nothing to do with the actual institution, we want our definition to be in a neat, razor-trimmed package. There are lots of examples of this sound-byte like simplification and reduction throughout the scholarly corpus. Marx reduced religion to an "opiate."[42] Freud reduced it to an "infantile delusion." Jung felt religion was the manifestation of the collective unconscious.[43] Durkheim called religion a projection of society.[44] Most anthropologists who approach it reduce it to a belief in spirits of some sort.[45] Even psychological luminary William James reduced it to a single thing, a connection to something divine.[46] These narrow definitions are simplifications. They focus on a single aspect of religion. Simplification is fine when appropriate, or for pragmatic reasons.[47] Some things are amenable to such simplification. But this does not work for religion. Religion is too complex to reduce to a simple little sound bite. If you try, your understanding will be caricatured and confused.

A fourth reason for the difficulty understanding and defining religion is simply that we are biased, the lay public as well as the white, European scholars that publish in the dominant scholarly journals. We have been ethnocentric, Eurocentric, and, as we shall see, sometimes even racist. On the question of bias, few, if any, scholars take an appropriately *neutral* position on religion. Most people, materialists, atheists, and the faithful included, have blinders permanently attached, seeing only what they want to see about religion. The absolute worst offender here is

42 Karl Marx, *A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1970).
43 Carl G. Jung, *Psychology & Religion* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1938).
44 Emile Durkheim, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (New York: Free Press, 1995).
45 Bronislaw Malinowski, *Magic, Science, and Religion* (New York: Double Day, 1925).
46 William James, *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study of Human Nature* (New York: Penguin, 1903), https://archive.org/details/varietiesreligi03jamegoog/page/n6/mode/2up.
47 Platvoet and Molendijk, *The Pragmatics of Defining Religion: Contexts, Concepts and Contests*.

Richard Dawkins, whose simplistic and polemical take on religion[48] should be an embarrassment to serious scholars the world over. But Dawkins does not stand alone. Faithful or not, we have all been guilty of this bias. A Catholic may only consider the positive aspects of their religion and will ignore and justify certain uncomfortable aspects (pervasive paedophilia in the church, for example) that otherwise might challenge their faithful adherence. An atheist or materialist will see only stupidity and will not consider the possibility of non-material realities or the existence and benefits of spiritual experience. A Marxist will see only an opiate. A sociologist will see only the ecclesiastical component of religion and will largely ignore religious experience. There are exceptions, of course. Some scholars, like medical doctor Larry Dossey,[49] do consider the possibility of non-material realities, and some psychologists, like Abraham Maslow, Ervin Laszlo, Peter Russell, Stanislav Grof, William Miller, and Janet C'de Baca[50] do accept the reality and benefits of spiritual experience, but these are exceptions. By and large, the faithful resist critical inquiry and the materialists strictly enforce the academy's materialist boundaries. Because of these blinders, neither group is capable of grasping the big picture.

We might call all the bias noted above ontological bias. The word "ontology" refers to what you believe is real. Ontology refers to your theory of reality, your worldview. Do you believe only in what you can see? Then you have a materialist ontology. Do you believe in the possibility of things existing without a material component? Then you have an idealist ontology.

Ontological Bias[51] is a bias that emerges from rigid adherence to your ontology. Are you a die-hard materialist who won't even listen to those with an opposing view? You may be ontologically biased. Are you a Christian who believes some God created the universe in seven days and do you refuse to consider scientific evidence to the contrary? Ontological bias!

48 Dawkins, *The God Delusion*.

49 "Nonlocal Mind: A (Fairly) Brief History of the Term," *Explore: The Journal of Science and Healing* 11, no. 2 (2015): 89–101, doi:http://dx.doi.org/10.1016/j.explore.2014.12.001.

50 William R Miller and Janet C'de Baca, *Quantum Change: When Epiphanies and Sudden Insights Transform Ordinary Lives* (New York: The Guilford Press, 2001), https://amzn.to/2D1gYZo; Abraham H. Maslow, *Religions, Values, and Peak Experiences* (Columbus: Ohio State University Press, 1964); Ervin Laszlo, Stanislav Grof, and Peter Russell, *The Consciousness Revolution* (Las Vegas: Elf Rock Productions, 1999).

51 "Ontological Bias," *The SpiritWiki* (Avatar.GLOBAL, 2026), https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/Ontological_Bias.

Ontological bias closes our mind to alternative explanations and the logic and evidence that might support them. A person who sees God as a white male patriarch will have a hard time listening to a Hindu who brings forward a more pantheistic vision. A die-hard materialist will dismiss out of hand evidence for spiritual realities and accounts of spiritual experience. If you are not listening to other people and not accepting available evidence, you will struggle to capture the essence of religion.

There are lots of reasons why we might be ontologically biased. For scholars, ontological bias may emerge from what anthropologist Jana Bacevic calls epistemic attachment.[52] **Epistemic Attachment** is the emotional, professional, and identity-level investment we make in the *objects* of our knowledge, like theories, institutions, disciplines, and worldviews. Basically, we attach our identities to these objects. I am an atheist. I am a theist. I am a Marxist atheist. When our sense of self, our career, our publications, and our standing in a community depends on the continued existence of some object, we become unable to imagine that object of knowledge might be false, misleading, or incomplete. A scholar who has built a forty-year career arguing that religion is nothing more than a projection cannot easily entertain evidence that complicates that view, because doing so would not just require revising a theory—it would require dismantling the scholarly self they have constructed. The same is true of the theologian who has staked their identity on the literal truth of scripture, or the cognitive scientist of religion whose entire research program assumes religious experience reduces to brain states. In each case, ontology functions less like a hypothesis to be tested and more like a membership card in an intellectual community, complete with its own gatekeepers, rewards, and punishments. This is why debates about religion so often feel personal: to challenge someone's ontology is, in effect, to challenge their identity. This is precisely why Weber's advice to simply observe and study religion is so hard to follow—because genuine observation requires a kind of epistemic detachment that our identities, by their very nature, work to prevent.

52 Jana Bacevic, "Between Legitimation and Imagination: Epistemic Attachment, Ontological Bias, and Thinking about the Future," *Jana Bacevic*, December 18, 2017, https://janabacevic.net/2017/12/18/between-legitimation-and-imagination-epistemic-attachment-ontological-bias-and-thinking-about-the-future/.

Seen this way, ontological bias is what epistemic attachment looks like when it hardens into a worldview. The faithful priest, the atheist, the Marxist, and the materialist sociologist described above are not simply holding different opinions about the nature of reality; they are defending sources of identity and legitimation; their minds are, accordingly, closed. This is why the blindness is so resistant to evidence. A scholar confronting evidence against a mere opinion can update the opinion; a scholar confronting evidence against an identity must either surrender the identity or dismiss the evidence, and identities do not surrender easily.

Ontological bias in the academy is compounded by other forms of bias, by ethnocentrism, Euro-centrism, and flat-out racist attempts to dismiss anything that does not originate in white, European thought as savage, puerile nonsense. To be perfectly clear, scholars have struggled to define what religion is not only because it is complex, not only because they try to simplify too much, and not only because of basic ontological bias, but because they have been trying to distinguish and elevate their own "adult, civilized white man" European institutions (e.g., monotheistic religion and science) as superior to the "savage," primitive, pre-logical, narcissistic, and infantile character of the knowledge systems of the "undeveloped people" of the so-called "inferior races."[53] In other words, scientists have struggled because of the sometimes overt, sometimes covert, desire to establish superiority between their white, European systems of belief (i.e., Catholicism and Science), non-Western (Buddhism), and Indigenous systems. They have what I call a **Boundary Fetish**.[54] A fetish is an obsessional interest in something.

A boundary fetish is an obsessional interest in boundaries between things. A boundary fetish is often accompanied by a magical form of **Boundary Work,** which is the often difficult work of establishing boundaries between things. Deciding what counts as "art" versus "craft" versus "junk" is boundary work. Imagine a gallery curator selecting pieces for an exhibition. Before any judgment about quality happens, she must first answer a more basic question: *is this an artwork at all?* She might exclude a handwoven basket as "craft," include a urinal signed by Duchamp as

53 Lucien Levy-Bruhl, *How Natives Think* (New York: Washington Square Press, 1966), 3.
54 "Boundary Fetish," *The SpiritWiki* (Avatar.GLOBAL, 2026), https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/Boundary_Fetish.

"art," and pass over a child's drawing as "not yet art." None of these classifications are written in nature; they're conventions she enacts through labeling, categorizing, framing, and exclusion. That activity, drawing and policing the line between "art" and "not art," *is* boundary work.

Generational labeling, Boomers, Gen X, Millennials, Gen Z, Gen Alpha, is another example. Boundary lines here are not drawn by biology, history, or any meaningful break in human experience. They are completely arbitrary. They are drawn by individuals working in marketing firms or as influencers commissioned or algorithmically rewarded to sort people into categories. A person born in 1980 and one born in 1982 are assigned different "generations," while a 25-year-old cashier and a 55-year-old cashier, who share nearly identical material conditions (i.e., they're both poor and members of the working class) are told they belong to warring cohorts. This is boundary work: the obsessive drawing and policing of lines that have no existence outside the work itself.

Like all successful boundary work, this serves someone. Generational classification converts structural problems into cohort personality traits. Unaffordable housing becomes Millennial immaturity. Stagnant wages become Gen Z entitlement. This redirects resentment *horizontally*, across age lines, rather than upwards toward the owners of land and capital. *These boundaries fracture solidarity that would otherwise be natural*. A young renter and an old renter are allies on every question that matters, but once they have been taught to see each other as the enemy, they won't even talk to each other, which is the point. Every minute spent on generational warfare is a minute not spent on class analysis.

When scholars work hard to establish sharp, hierarchical boundaries between objects of knowledge, like religion, they are doing boundary work. When they position Western science at the top, Western monotheism in the middle, Eastern religions below that, and Indigenous spirituality at the bottom, they are establishing boundaries. The process of boundary work typically starts by brutally oversimplifying Indigenous knowledge systems as all about primitive magic while glorifying Western scientific practice as the culmination of some form of evolutionary advance, as did Bronislaw Malinowski when he suggested that science is logical, open,

objective, and empirical, while magic (what the "savages" did) was occult, hidden, mystical, subjective, and driven by an irrational "play of emotions upon the human organism."[55]

> Science is guided by reason and corrected by observation, magic, impervious to both, it lives in an atmosphere of mysticism. Science is open to all, a common good of the whole community, magic is occult, taught through mysterious initiations, handed on in a hereditary or at least in very exclusive filiation. While science is based on the conception of natural forces, magic springs from the idea of a certain mystic, impersonal power, which is believed in by most *primitive* peoples.[56]

As comfortable and common-sense as Malinowski's view might appear to some, Malinowski was incorrect even on his own terms. In the ancient world, "magic" was not confined to secretive priests, it was not occult, and it was not irrational. It was rational and practised by many.[57] As Sir James Frazer, famous author of the still influential *The Golden Bough*, notes, people who used magic were very much concerned with control over nature, the natural laws of the universe, doing empirical testing, and forming "legitimate hypotheses,"[58] so much so that he suggests that *the fundamental epistemic conceptions of magic are pretty much identical to those of modern science*, that is, of natural and regularized causation with a view towards practical control over nature in order to help reduce uncertainty, to increase food supply, and to increase survival. Frazer casts magicians as the "direct predecessors" of our physicians, surgeons, and scientists.

Now, you might think from Frazer's criticism that he is attempting to erase the boundary between "advanced" Western science and "primitive" magic systems that Malinowski worked to inscribe, but that is not the case. Frazer isn't erasing boundaries, he is simply inscribing his own. You may not be able to distinguish magic from science by its unreasoned, anti-empirical, occult character, but you can still find ways to distinguish it. According to Frazer, and here we see yet another European attempt to assert a boundary, the difference is a mistaken ontology. Remember,

55 Bronislaw Malinowski, *Magic, Science, and Religion and Other Essays* (Glencoe, Illinois: The Free Press, 1948), 67.
56 Ibid., 3: emphasis added.
57 Sir James George Frazer, *The Golden Bough: A Study in Magic and Religion* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 1990).
58 Ibid., 62.

ontology is your view of reality. Primitive folk have a mistaken ontology. They understand cause and effect just fine. The problem is that they believe that you can cause things with magic. "The fatal flaw of magic lies not in its general assumption of a sequence of events determined by law, but in its presumed misconception of the nature of the particular laws which govern that sequence."[59]

Like Malinowski, Frazer also assumes a hierarchy of knowledge with magical beliefs at the bottom, Western monotheism in the middle, and Western science at the top. He has a tough time though. If the problem with Indigenous systems is that they believe in magical causation, where does that put Western monotheism? There is nothing more magical than the belief in demons and angels, as Western monotheisms have that in spades.

No problem. Frazer has a solution. Western monotheisms are superior to magical systems of thought because monotheisms represent submission to a higher power and to divine will, both of which signal, according to Frazer, an evolution of cognitive function that occurs only in those of "higher" intelligence. As he notes,

> this deepening sense of religion, this more perfect submission to the divine will in all things, affects only those higher intelligences who have breadth of view enough to comprehend the vastness of the universe and the littleness of man. Small minds cannot grasp great ideas; to their narrow comprehension, their purblind vision, nothing seems really great and important but themselves. Such minds hardly rise into religion at all.[60]

Frazer's classic work *The Golden Bough: A Study in Comparative Religion* continues to be cited in the scholarly corpus. However, his bizarre take on the superiority of Western monotheisms should be enough to call into question his objectivity and should contribute to a more careful use of his work.

Note that it is not only anthropologists who make biased and ethnocentric claims. Sociologists imprint ethnocentric views onto religious and spiritual domains as well. Auguste Comte, founding father of sociology, set out the "law of three stages," which cast the cognitive development of humans as a

59 Ibid., 49.
60 Ibid., 59.

movement from primitive **theological** systems where "free play is given to spontaneous fictions admitting of no proof," through "superior" Western **metaphysical** systems which are "characterised by the prevalence of personified abstractions or entities" to **positive** scientific systems which are "based upon an exact view of the real facts of the case."[61] According to Comte, the Theological stage is further broken down into three sub-phases, the **fetishistic**, **polytheistic**, and **monotheistic** stages. Here again is a hierarchy with monotheism being "superior to polytheism and Judaism," and polytheism (Vedic belief systems, for example) being superior to "fetishistic" Indigenous systems[62] which for Comte are the puerile beliefs of an "infant species."[63]

These definitions are clearly ethnocentric, even racist. The characterization of Indigenous beliefs as lacking in reason and immune from empirical verification, the use of the words "simpler," "primitive," "infant," or "brute" to describe them, and the suggestion that Western organised religion and, after that, science are superior are sweeping statements concerning the superiority of Western religion and science over Indigenous culture and knowledge systems.

These examples illustrate a fundamental problem with early definitions of religion. At best they represent an unexamined ontological bias. At worst, they are motivated by a Western, ethnocentric, racist, colonialist desire to assert the superiority of Western belief systems and practices. This is obviously a big problem. This motivation may have led to a certain selective attention, to an ignoring of facts that has enabled Western thinkers to continually position Western systems as "obviously" superior. As Hamilton notes:

> ...the possibility that there might be a lot more to such beliefs and practices than the view which sees them as mere mistakes is suggested by the fact that magic is not relied upon by tribal peoples to produce desired results. If it were, they would never have survived. For the most part they use ordinary everyday empirical techniques. They do not expect crops to grow by magical means without planting seeds, watering, weeding, protecting from parasites, and so on. They do not, in short, mistake connections which exist in the mind for real causal connections all the time or in the course of everyday activity. Magic is either reserved for

61 August Comte, *A General View of Positivism* (George Routledge and Sons, 1908; Standard Ebooks, 2026), 35, https://standardebooks.org/ebooks/auguste-comte/a-general-view-of-positivism/j-h-bridges.
62 Ibid., 64.
63 Ibid., chap. 3.

> special circumstances or is an adjunct to ordinary techniques. Finally, the ethnographic evidence does not support Tylor or Frazer (or others like Marett). The simplest societies, the hunter–gatherers, are not especially animistic, as Tylor's theories would lead us to expect. If anything, they are less animistic than many horticultural and agricultural societies. Nor do they manifest a preponderance of magic over religion as Frazer's theories would suggest.[64]

It is tempting to dismiss early attempts to draw boundaries around magic, religion, and science as part of a dated Eurocentric zeitgeist. However, as Hamilton notes, early characterizations have made a lasting impression and continue to be influential.[65] Modern social scientists continue to be driven by the need to establish boundaries, borders, and hierarchies. For example, sociologists admit that religions generally have "transcendental" aims, whatever that might mean. They will even admit that "primitive" religion have "transcendental aims," but then go on to point how modern western transcendentalisms are superior.

The most famous, in sociology, is the "secularization thesis." the "secularization thesis," articulated most forcefully in the mid-twentieth century by sociologists like Peter Berger and Bryan Wilson,[66] suggests that religion and all its inherent irrationalities and superstitions will eventually disappear, dispelled by the advancing light of science. This thesis posits a unilinear trajectory: ancient religions occupy the primitive starting point, liberal religion the awkward middle stage, and secular modernity the advanced endpoint. Religious societies are coded as cognitively immature and developmentally arrested, while secular Western societies are positioned at the telos of human advancement because the are rational, autonomous, and free from the childish need for supernatural consolation.[67]

By framing secular modernity as the natural, advanced stage of social evolution, the thesis positions non-Western, non-secular societies as backward holdovers that will inevitably be swept aside. It provides a developmental justification for Western economic and cultural dominance, delegitimizing Indigenous and traditional spiritual systems which emphasise connection to the land not through intellectual engagement but through temporal condescension. They belong to an obsolete past that the advanced world has

64 Hamilton, *The Sociology of Religion: Theoretical and Comparative Perspectives*, 31.
65 Hamilton, *The Sociology of Religion: Theoretical and Comparative Perspectives*.
66 Peter Berger, *The Sacred Canopy: Elements of a Sociological Theory of Religion* (New York: Anchor Books, 1969).
67 This developmental subtext is examined in Tomoko Masuzawa, *The Invention of World Religions* (Chicago: University Of Chicago Press, 2005).

outgrown. This is not scholarship. This is an ideological operation. To dismiss land-based spirituality as primitive superstition is to render the land spiritually vacant, and vacant land is the precondition for enclosure, extraction, and sale. The secularization thesis thus does double duty: it erases the spiritual narratives that might contest capitalist authority. In erasing them, it clears the land for commodification. Dressed in the neutral language of sociological prediction, the thesis functions as the boundary fetish's most refined modern expression, a hierarchy that privileges capitalist modernity by systematically stripping the land of every narrative except the economic one.

Like every other boundary we have examined thus far, this hierarchy collapses under sustained empirical attention. The predicted global withering of religion simply failed to occur. Instead, the late twentieth and twenty-first centuries witnessed explosive religious growth across Latin America, Africa, and Asia, the global resurgence of Pentecostalism, the vitality of Islam, the emergence of new religious movements in the West, and the widespread "spiritual but not religious" phenomenon in supposedly secular nations. The evidence became so overwhelming that Berger himself, one of the thesis's principle architects, eventually recanted, conceding that the world was not secularizing as predicted but was rather undergoing a "desecularization."[68] Still, he asserts the boundary. Using the word "desecularizatrion" preserves the boundary, not because it is a logically or empirically sound concept (which should be questioned), but because it serves an ideological function.

The Emergence of "World Religions"

As Masuzawa[69] notes, the confident assertion that European societies and their institutions were morally and intellectually superior to everyone else, science over monotheism, monotheism over polytheism, polytheism over primitive magic, took a serious hit after World War I. It became rather difficult to claim civilizational superiority while watching European nations use their emerging industrial might to slaughter millions of their own citizens. Older hierarchical taxonomies had always put Christianity and modern European science at the apex. But after the Great War, then the next world war (and now Trump's "religious" America), this overt triumphalism became, and remains, politically embarrassing and intellectually untenable.

68 Peter Berger, *The Desecularization of the World: Resurgent Religion and World Politics* (Grand Rapids MI: Eerdmans, 1999).

69 Masuzawa, *The Invention of World Religions*.

The solution to maintaining the boundary, according to Masuzawa, was not to abandon Eurocentrism but to *repackage* it in a way that obscured but preserved the hierarchy. In the early decades of the twentieth century, a new categorization suddenly appeared, one that is so familiar to us today that we rarely question it. Instead of obviously biased categories, scholars and educators began presenting a list of roughly ten to twelve "world religions": Christianity, Buddhism, Islam, Hinduism, Judaism, Confucianism, Taoism, Shinto, Zoroastrianism, Jainism, and Sikhism, usually accompanied by a residual category of "primitive" or "primal" religions.[70] This new framework appeared to be descriptive, neutral, and pluralistic. It seemed to say: here are the major religious traditions of the world. See? They all have a history, scriptures, and practices. We should study these because they are the major religions.

Masuzawa argues, however, that this was largely a cover. Beneath the pluralist language, the same hierarchical logic was preserved. In this new schema, World religions were "real" religions. These were those with written scriptures, historical founders (or founder figures), and institutional hierarchies. Religions that didn't fit this model, traditions with orally transmitted cosmologies, traditions that had local spirit practices, were shunted into the residual category of "primal" or "tribal" religions, implicitly positioned as less developed.[71]

It wasn't just that "primitive" religions were here shunted into the dunce corner. World religions themselves were ranked. Weber, for example, created a comparative framework that set world religions above "primitive" religions and Western world religions above all others. Weber's framework runs on two main axes: rationalization and transcendence. Rationalization is the displacement of magic, the movement from a chaos of spirits and taboos toward unified worldviews, coherent ethics, and fixed goals of salvation. Transcendence is the separation of a supramundane realm from the mundane world. In "primitive" religions, says Weber, gods and humans occupy a single cosmos, while the world religions open a chasm between them. Weber uses these two axes to sort the traditions. How far has rationalization gone? How transcendent is the divine? How universal the message? The answers come out predictably graded, with world religions over primitive ones, and Western world religions above all others.

Or, consider Robert Bellah's enormously influential 1964 essay "Religious Evolution," which organised all of religious history into five stages, primitive, archaic, historic, early modern, and modern,

70 Ibid.
71 Ibid., 43–44.

with each stage more "differentiated" than the last.[72] Bellah was careful to insist that a more differentiated religion was not a *better* one, but look at the path he walked. His "early modern" stage, the second highest stage, derives from a single case, the Protestant Reformation, an exclusively Western phenomenon. Buddhism regressed, Taoist and Confucian attempts were weighed down by what he calls "mortgages" from the past. The final, "modern" stage is defined by Kant, liberal Protestant theology, and a self capable of endless self-transformation.

More recent scholarship is no different. Stephen Sharot's *A Comparative Sociology of World Religions*[73] shows the same pattern. Sharot builds his boundaries around Weber's axes—rationalization, transcendence, universalism—and Bellah's primitive/archaic/historic distinction. He treats the axial age as the great break in human religious history, and lets transcendence and rationalization do the sorting. The "historic" religions get in because they are transcendent, but are ranked by how transcendent they are. Western monotheisms are at the top, China and India below, and the "primitive" world left outside the door entirely. There are some qualifications. Sharot notes that the Tao and Brahman are "no less transcendent" than the personal God, that karma is perhaps the most consistent theodicy ever devised, that Western Christianity spent centuries re-magifying itself, but they arrive on schedule and soften nothing. This is boundary work in its modern form: the hierarchy is never asserted, so it can never be refuted; it simply comes embedded in the instruments of measurement.

When you examine this field carefully you can see a lot of effort is put into establishing and maintaining boundaries. The categorization of world religions seems progressive and inclusive, but not really. In this scheme, European Christianity became one among many but, as Masuzawa notes, "first among unequals." Christianity remained the implicit standard against which all other traditions were measured, and lively debates ensued. Buddhism could be called a world religion because it was, like Christianity, allegedly universalistic and Aryan in origin.[74] Islam's status as a world religion was, on the

72 Robert N Bellah, "Religious Evolution," *Americal Sociological Review* 358–274 (3).

73 Stephen Sharot, *A Comparative Sociology of World Religions* (New York University, 2001).

74 On "Aryan": The term derives from the Sanskrit *ārya* ("noble"), which nineteenth-century comparative philologists adopted as a synonym for the Indo-European language family following its identification by William Jones and the development of comparative grammar by Franz Bopp and others. What began as a linguistic classification was quickly racialized: scholars such as Ernest Renan treated the Aryan/Semitic divide as a division between human essences, crediting the Aryan with reason, inflection, and philosophical capacity, and the Semite with rigidity, sensuality, and historical stasis. Racism. On this see Léon Poliakov, *The Aryan Myth: A History of Racist and Nationalist Ideas in Europe* (New York: Basic Books, 1974); Maurice Olender, *The Languages of Paradise: Race, Religion, and Philology in the Nineteenth Century* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press,

other hand, hotly debated. Some, following Abraham Kuenen, argued that Islam was not a universal faith but the national religion of the Arabs, a product of Semitic particularism that disqualified it from "world religion" status.[75] Others, like Otto Pfleiderer, tried to rescue its candidacy by relocating its universal essence in Sufism, an allegedly Aryan, mystical Islam, while dismissing the religion as actually practiced as an ethnic artifact.[76] The debate is the tell: Christianity's membership was never questioned, but Islam had to be litigated and selectively purified before it could be admitted, thus revealing that "world religion" was never a neutral description but a European boundary mechanism.[77]

This also preserved the West's claim to represent universal history. The West (Europe and its colonial offshoots) was positioned not as the sole possessor of truth, but as the *neutral observer* capable of surveying and classifying all the world's religions. The scholar of religion, almost always a Westerner trained in European universities, became the arbiter of what counted as a religion, which texts were "sacred," and which traditions were "major." This epistemic authority, the power to name, categorise, and rank, was itself a form of hegemony. As Masuzawa puts it, "the new discourse of pluralism and diversity of religions neither displaced nor disabled the logic of European hegemony…but, in a way, gave it a new lease."[78]

In short, the invention of "world religions" allowed European thought to have its pluralist cake and eat it too. In the face of challenges to its own moral authority, it acknowledged the existence of other traditions. On its surface, this new framework seemed generous. A dozen great traditions, each with its sacred texts, its founder figures, its noble teachings. Christianity was just one among many. What could be more fair? But as Masuzawa has shown, this was a sleight of hand. Western civilization and systems (religion/science) remained the vantage point from which all human history was to be understood. The world religions framework preserved the old hierarchy by other means. Most importantly, it positioned the Western scholar as the neutral arbiter, the one who surveys, classifies, and judges. In this way, Westerners could not only claim to have the only true religions (the universal ones), they could also claim something more subtle, that it was the only true *vantage point*. Here, the hierarchy was no longer written on the surface; it was woven into the very structure of the classification system.

1992); Stefan Arvidsson, *Aryan Idols: Indo-European Mythology as Ideology and Science* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2006).

75 Masuzawa, *The Invention of World Religions*.

76 Masuzawa, *The Invention of World Religions*.

77 Richard King, "Taking on the Guild: Tomoko Masuzawa and The Invention of World Religions," *Method & Theory in the Study of Religion* 20, no. 2 (2008): 125–33.

78 Masuzawa, *The Invention of World Religions*, xi.

Conceptive Ideologists

Let us return to where we began. Why have scholars struggled for centuries to define religion? Not, I have argued, because religion is simply too complex or because we have an unfortunate tendency toward oversimplification, though both are true. The deeper reason is that many scholars have never really wanted a neutral definition. What they have wanted, consciously or not, is a *boundary,* a sharp line between superior us and inferior them. From Tylor and Frazer to Comte and Malinowski, from the secularization theorists of the mid-twentieth century to the architects of the "world religions" syllabus, the project has remained remarkably consistent.

The boundary fetish, then, is not an accident or a relic of a less enlightened age. It is structural. It is what the academic study of religion has repeatedly been mobilised to produce. Every time we teach a world religions course that lists a dozen "major" traditions and relegates everything else to a chapter called "primal religions" or "Indigenous traditions," we are drawing a boundary. Every time we accept the secularization thesis's prediction that religion will fade away in modern societies, a prediction that has failed in spectacular fashion, we are drawing a boundary. We are, in essence, performing an identity ritual. We are saying: *this is what we are, and this is what they are, and never the twain shall meet.*

A final caution is in order, because none of this is as innocent as we might assume. When we say that high-level scholars like Tylor, Frazer, Comte, and Malinowski drew boundaries, it is tempting to picture them as merely men of their time, blinded by the Ontological Bias and Epistemic Attachment of the age, stumbling along in good faith. That may not be the case, however. Karl Marx called such men **Conceptive Ideologists**.[79] In his "The German Ideology," Marx observed that the ruling class of any epoch rules not only as the ruling material force of society but as its "ruling intellectual force" as well. This is because it controls the **Means of Mental Production**, the universities, printing presses, churches, film studios, and journals (and now social media platforms) in which a society's ideas are manufactured and distributed.

This control can be direct, as in the case of direct ownership (Elon Musk owns and controls Twitter), or indirect, as in the case of early scholars who display class alignment, echoing ideas that, whatever their empirical adequacy, happened to serve the interests of the class whose patronage, prestige, and

79 Karl Marx, *The German Ideology* (New York: Norton, 1978), https://www.marxists.org/archive/marx/works/1845/german-ideology/ch01b.htm.

institutional support they depended upon.[80] Few early scientists or social scientists were themselves capitalists. They were gentlemen, clergymen, professors, and courtiers.[81] But the hierarchy of knowledge systems they manufactured, Western science rational, universal, and progressive at the top; monotheism submissive and "advanced" in the middle, Indigenous knowledge emotional, occult, and primitive at the bottom, was functionally identical to the self-image of the emerging bourgeois order: rational mastery over nature, the progressive displacement of tradition, the dismissal of communal, land-based lifeworlds as childish anachronisms standing in the way of extraction and accumulation.[82] One did not need to be a member of the accumulating class to do its intellectual work; one needed only to work inside its institutions, accept its patronage, and absorb its common sense[83] to do the sometimes nasty work of purging non-compliant concepts and ideas.

This might sound a bit extreme to some, but it is not really; several examples illustrate this influence and control and the existence of conceptive ideologists. Consider Sinclair Broadcasting. Sinclair is the largest owner of *local* television stations in the United States. Every day its stations air corporate-written "must-run" scripts that local anchors are *required* to read, *word for word*, presenting them as if they were local journalism. In 2018 somebody strung a few dozen of these readings together into a single video, and the result is one of the creepier things you will ever watch: dozens of different anchors, in dozens of different cities, all reciting the identical script in unison, right down to the line "this is extremely dangerous to our democracy."[84] If you want to see what Marx meant by the regulation of the production and distribution of ideas, watch that video. The ideas faithfully repeated verbatim by Sinclair "reports" were written in a corporate office with a capitalist agenda in mind. The writers writing the script and journalists reading the scripts are conceptive ideologists. They produce and distribute ideas that the owners want them to produce and distribute.

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80 J. D. Bernal, *The Social Function of Science* (London: Routledge & Sons, 1939).

81 Michael Hunter, *Establishing the New Science: The Experience of the Early Royal Society* (Woodbridge: Boydell Press, 1989); Steven Shapin, *A Social History of Truth: Civility and Science in Seventeenth-Century England* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1994).

82 Boris Hessen, "The Social and Economic Roots of Newton's Principia," in *Science at the Cross Roads*, ed. P. G. Werskey (London: Frank Cass, 1971), 149–212; Carolyn Merchant, *The Death of Nature: Women, Ecology, and the Scientific Revolution* (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1980); Robert K. Merton, *Science, Technology and Society in Seventeenth Century England* (New York: Howard Fertig, 1970).

83 Antonio Gramsci, *Antonio Gramsci: Prison Notebooks*, ed. Lawrence D. Kritzman, vol. Volume ONe (New York: Columbia University Press, 1975).

84 Deadspin, *Sinclair's Soldiers in Trump's War on Media*, 2018, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_fHfgU8oMSo.

Or, consider Jeff Bezos. In 2013 Bezos, creator of Amazon.com and the second-richest man on earth, bought the Washington Post,[85] a hugely influential publication. It has 2.5 million paying digital subscribers and tens of millions of monthly readers. It is the paper of record for the American political class and therefore a powerful opinion-forming institution in the capital of the world's most powerful state. Bezos bought it not through Amazon like you might expect, but through his holding company Nash Holdings. It was a personal purchase, like you'd buy a new phone. In 2025, Bezos announced that his paper's opinion section would henceforth write only opinions that he found palatable. It will publish "every day in support and defense of two pillars: personal liberties and free markets." Here is Bezos giving the people he employs as conceptive ideologists their marching orders. The paper's opinion editor resigned rather than implement the shift.[86]

Finally, consider the remarkable story of Humanistic Psychology. Humanistic psychology was a psychological tradition that took spiritual and peak experience seriously as a legitimate domain of human functioning and scholarly inquiry. For the most part it's dead now, but it did not decline because its claims failed or its therapeutic models were not effective. Quite the opposite is true. Even the American Psychological Association admits, that Humanistic Psychology was making progress in understanding core aspects of human experience and psychology.[87] As David Elkins[88] documented, Humanistic Psychology was murdered. Mainstream psychology marginalised it by **dismissing it** as unscientific crystal-healing narcissism without citing a shred of evidence, **erasing it** by reframing humanistic insights while refusing to give credit, and **minimizing and trivializing its insights.**[89]

Here is Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi's iconic and arrogantly dismissive prognostication.

85 Brian Solomon, "Billionaire Jeff Bezos Buys The Washington Post For $250 Million, Less Than 1% Of His Net Worth," *Forbes*, 2013, https://www.forbes.com/sites/briansolomon/2013/08/05/jeff-bezos-buys-washington-post-for-250-million-less-than-1-of-his-net-worth/.

86 -Laurie Kellman and Associated Press, "Washington Post Owner Jeff Bezos Says Opinion Pages Will Defend Free Market and 'Personal Liberties,'" *PBS News*, February 26, 2025, https://www.pbs.org/newshour/politics/washington-post-owner-bezos-says-opinion-pages-shift-from-broad-focus-to-will-defend-free-market-and-personal-liberties.

87 Rebecca A. Clay, "A Renaissance for Humanistic Psychology," *APA Monitor on Psychology*, 2002, https://www.apa.org/monitor/sep02/renaissance.

88 "Why Humanistic Psychology Lost Its Power and Influence in American Psychology," *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* 49, no. 1 (2009): 267–91, doi:10.1177/0022167808323575.

89 Ibid., 284.

> Unfortunately, humanistic psychology did not attract much of a cumulative empirical base, and it spawned myriad therapeutic self-help movements. In some of its incarnations, it emphasized the self and encouraged a self-centeredness that played down concerns for collective well-being. Future debate will determine whether this came about because Maslow and Rogers were ahead of their time, because these flaws were inherent in their original vision, or because of overly enthusiastic followers. However, one legacy of the humanism of the 1960s is prominently displayed in any large bookstore: The "psychology" section contains at least 10 shelves on crystal healing, aromatherapy, and reaching the inner child for every shelf of books that tries to uphold some scholarly standard.[90]

This characterization was puerile at best. Greening and Bohart documented the factual problems with Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi in their published reply: the *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* had run over 100 articles on peace, the Holocaust, violence reduction, and social justice, and "no articles at all on crystals or aromatherapy."[91] Seligman's response completely dismissed the criticisms,[92] and now positive psychology is a force.

A conceptive ideologist, then, is a producer of ideas who draws the boundaries his class needs drawn and packages them as neutral scholarly description. Whether Tylor and Frazer were conscious of their service to empire is beside the point; a conceptive ideologist need not be cynical or self-conscious to be useful. What matters is that the hierarchy they inscribed, Western science on top, Western monotheism in the middle, Indigenous spirituality at the bottom, was not a well-meaning error but an ideology with specific beneficiaries.

Once you learn to spot the conceptive ideologist at work, you will find them everywhere, writing down Zoroastrian canon, editing the Christian Bible, designing the modern tarot, and even constructing the syllabi and writing the textbooks of the very courses you are taking.

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90 Martin E. P. Seligman and Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, "Positive Psychology: An Introduction," *American Psychologist* 55, no. 1 (2000): 7.

91 Arthur C. Bohart and Tom Greening, "Humanistic Psychology and Positive Psychology," *American Psychologist* 56, no. 1 (2001): 81, doi:10.1037/0003-066X.56.1.81.

92 Martin E. P. Seligman and Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, "'Positive Psychology: An Introduction': Reply," *American Psychologist* 56, no. 1 (2001): 89–90, doi:10.1037/0003-066X.56.1.89.

2. Defining Religion – Substantive Definitions

In the last chapter, we introduced you to the problems associated with defining religion. To recap, there are at least four. First, despite all the boundary work that gets done, we're still quite fuzzy about what religion actually is and what institutions should be included. Second, religion is "phenomenally complex,"[93] culturally, politically, psychologically, economically, and spiritually. It stubbornly resists the sound-bite simplification scholars keep forcing on it. Third, despite its complexity, we tend to oversimplify. We reduce it to an opiate or a transcendence machine. Finally, *we* are biased. Whether we are faithful, atheist, materialist, or Marxist, we mostly look at religion through the boundary fetish of our ontological bias. We, the white middle-class Western scholars writing the books, like to see ourselves and our institutions as superior, a tendency that has, as we shall see later, served well the interests of capital.

With all that in mind, in this chapter we are going to provide some definitions of religion. We do this not because there is a perfect single definition but because wrestling with definitions, even flawed ones, is a great intellectual exercise that sensitises us to what religion is and what it does. And who knows? We may be lucky. We may come up with a satisfactory definition. To get there we will, however, need an open mind, so keep your mind open. I will endeavour to do the same.

Substantive Definitions

For your information, social scientists distinguish between **two types of definitions** of religion, **substantive** and **functional** definitions. **Substantive definitions** focus on the content or substance of religion, its beliefs, dogma, rituals, buildings, roles, and such. **Functional definitions** focus on the functions that religion performs.[94] We will look at substantive definitions in this chapter, and functional definitions after that. Here I would just like to note that while substantive and functional definitions can be separated analytically, in practice every religion has both, and the two illuminate each other. Consider, as an instructive case, the religion of Cthulhu. Substantively, Cthulhuism has content, but that content is reduced to a single thing: an ancient,

93 Sharot, *A Comparative Sociology of World Religions*, 5.

94 Inger Furseth and Pål Repstad, *An Introduction to the Sociology of Religion: Classical and Contemporary Perspectives* (Aldershot, England: Ashgate Publishing LImited, 2006).

indifferent cosmic entity that slumbers beneath the Pacific and will eventually awaken and destroy us all. Note what this substance excludes. The god does not listen, does not judge, does not reward, and does not punish. There is no salvation on offer, no moral code to follow, and no afterlife paperwork. When Cthulhu comes, you'll be dead, and that's it.

Despite the fact that the substance of Cthulhuism is completely absent, save for the eldritch deity, Cthulhuism does have functions. It still does what religions do. It binds a community of adherents together around shared ritual and shared meaning, and it provides a framework within which its members can locate themselves in the cosmos and make sense of their existence, and its inevitable end. It gives them a sense of purpose and a direction for their lives, something which, as we shall see, all religions do. It even helps with anxiety and distress. Everybody meets the same fate. Why worry?

The point here is not to analyze Cthulhu, for they are perfect in all ways. The point is that religions have both functional and substantive aspects, and you can't understand a religion unless you understand both.

Having said that, let us now focus on the substances various theorists have proposed.

Supernatural Substance

Many analysts point to an ontological substance. Remember, ontology refers to claims about reality. Edward Burnett Tylor suggests that the substance of religion is the belief in the reality of "spiritual beings."[95] Melford Spiro says the same thing, noting that religion is a "belief in and interaction with a sacred realm of superhuman beings."[96] Wallace suggests the same, that religion is based on supernatural beliefs about the nature of the world.[97] American sociologist Roland Robertson suggested that the substance of religion, the thing that sets it apart, is to be found in its focus on a supra-empirical or

95 *Primitive Culture* (London: John Murray, 1903).

96 Melford E. Spiro, "Religion: Problems of Definition and Explanation," in *Anthropological Approaches to the Study of Religion*, ed. Michael Banton (Oxon: Routledge, 2004), 96.

97 Anthony F. C. Wallace, *Religion: An Anthropological View* (New York: Random House, 1966), vi, https://archive.org/details/religionanthropo00wall.

transcendent reality above the normal material realities of daily life.[98] Talcott Parsons suggested that hte "some kind of contact with the transcendent…is the hallmark of religion."[99] Auguste Comte, founding father of sociology, provides the classic example. For Comte, the substance of religion is its belief in supernatural agencies, gods, spirits, and divine wills whose desires and decisions explain why the world is the way it is. Comte is not impressed with this. Religion, in his view, is essentially a primitive mode of explanation, one in which, as he puts it, "free play is given to spontaneous fictions admitting of no proof."[100] Remember, he put it at the bottom of his evolutionary view of society. Note the substantive criterion at work here. If your belief system explains the world by appealing to the will of supernatural beings, it is a religion. If it does not, it is something else.

Herbert Spencer, writing at the same time as Tylor, says simply that religion is a belief in "an unseen power" behind the visible world.[101] Max Weber, though he resisted offering a single definition of his own, works within the same tradition. In his sociology of religion, he treats religious action as that oriented toward belief in "spirits" (Geister) or impersonal forces, and he explicitly excludes as non-religious the purely magical rites that manipulate such forces without any belief in a transcendent order.[102]

Earlier substantive definitions emphasised spirits and such. More recent substantive definitions move away from that. They keep the transcendent core but loosen it, dropping the requirement of gods, spirits, or supernatural beings and substituting something vaguer: an ultimate reality, a sacred dimension, or simply, as William James said, "the 'more' with which in religious experience we feel ourselves connected."[103] Religion, he says, consists of "the feelings, acts, and experiences of individual men in their solitude, so far as they apprehend themselves to stand in relation to whatever they may consider the divine." Rodney Stark, writing a century later, makes the move explicit. Religion, he argues, is a "system of general explanations of existence," including "the nature of supernatural forces," by means of which a community grapples with "the ultimate problems of human life."[104] John Hick pushes furthest of all:

98 Roland Robertson, *The Sociological Interpretation of Religion* (Blackwell, 1970).
99 Parsons, *Action Theory and the Human Condition*, 240.
100 Auguste Comte, *The Positive Philosophy of Auguste Comte* (London: George Bell & Sons, 1896); Comte, *A General View of Positivism*.
101 Herbert Spencer, *First Principles*, 6th ed. (London: Williams & Norgate, 1862).
102 Weber, *The Sociology of Religion*.
103 James, *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study of Human Nature*, 512.
104 Rodney Stark, "Micro Foundations of Religion: A Revised Theory," *Sociological Theory* 17, no. 1 (1999): 264–89, doi:10.1111/0735-2751.00078.

religion is "an awareness of, and response to, a transcendent reality.[105]"Call it God, Brahman, the Tao, the Sacred, or simply the Real. The substantive test is now minimalist. If a worldview acknowledges a reality beyond the empirical order, it counts. If it does not, it is something else.

Human Substance

The definitions above all share one assumption: that the substance of religion is supernatural. But there is a second family of substantive definitions that deny this assumption. For these theorists, the substance of religion is not supernatural at all. It is human — human nature, human need, human suffering — projected, repressed, or inverted into an imaginary object and then worshipped as something other than itself. These are still substantive definitions, because they specify a determinate content. Their content is mundane rather than spiritual.

Sigmund Freud gives the psychological version. In *The Future of an Illusion* and *Civilization and Its Discontents*, he calls religion an "illusion," by which he means not a simple error, but a belief held primarily because we *want* it to be true.[106] The content of religious ideas, on Freud's account, is infantile and psychical, the wish for a protecting father, the longing for the restoration of an infant's limitless narcissism, and, deeper still, the guilt inherited from the primal murder of the tribal father, recounted in *Totem and Taboo*.

> It is said, however, that each one of us behaves in some respect like the paranoiac, substituting a wish-fulfilment for some aspect of the world which is unbearable to him, and carrying this delusion through into reality. When a large number of people make this attempt together and try to obtain assurance of happiness and protection from suffering by a delusional transformation of reality, it acquires special significance. **The religions of humanity, too, must be classified as mass-delusions of this kind. Needless to say, no one who shares a delusion recognizes it as such.**[107]

105 John Hick, *An Interpretation of Religion: Human Responses to the Transcendent*, 1st ed. (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1989).

106 Freud, *The Future of an Illusion*; Sigmund Freud, *Civilization and Its Discontents* (New York: W.W. Norton, 1961), https://amzn.to/2STCpQT.

107 Freud, *Civilization and Its Discontents*, 81: emphasis added.

A similar projective approach is provided by Ludwig Feuerbach, whose work profoundly shaped Marx. For Feuerbach, religion is what happens when human beings project their own essential nature, their reason, will, love, compassion, capacity, etc., onto an imaginary divine being and then bow down before that projection as if it were something other than themselves. As he puts it, "God is the mirror of man [sic]."[108] Man's "own nature is in the first instance contemplated by him as that of another being."[109] The content of every religion, on this view, is alienated humanity.

> "God is the mirror in which man. That which has essential value for man, which he esteems the perfect, the excellent, in which he has true delight, – that alone is God to him. If feeling seems to thee a glorious attribute, it is then, per se, a divine attribute to thee. Therefore, the feeling, sensitive man believes only in a feeling sensitive."[110]

> ...theology is nothing else than anthropology—the knowledge of God nothing else than a knowledge of man![111]

Feuerbach did have a developmental view, but it was not Comte's ladder, on which religion climbs from fetishism through polytheism to monotheism only to be discarded at the top. For Feuerbach, religion progresses as humanity's projection progresses. The first stage is a pre-religious or "brute" stage. In this stage there is no religion, no projection, just a narcissistic focus on self. The second stage was where humanity projected itself onto a delusional world filled with spirits and natural forces. The third stage was the Western religious stage. In this "higher" stage, humanity projected all its good aspects, infinite love, wisdom, and power, onto a single, perfect God. Humanity debased itself in proportion.

> The impoverishing of the real world and the enriching of God is one act. Only the poor man has a rich God. God springs out of the feeling of a want.[112]

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108 Ludwig Feuerbach, *The Essence of Christianity* (London: Trubner & Co., 1881), 28.
109 Ibid., 13.
110 Friedrich Engels, "Ludwig Feuerbach and the End of Classical German Philosophy," in *Marx and Engels Selected Works*, Based on the edition published by Progress Publishers, Moscow, 1946 (Moscow: Progress Publishers, 1886), 28, https://www.marxists.org/archive/marx/works/1886/ludwig-feuerbach/.
111 Feuerbach, *The Essence of Christianity*, 166.
112 Ibid., 38.

> RELIGION is the disuniting of man from himself; he sets God before him as the antithesis of himself. God is not what man is — man is not what God is... God and man are extremes: God is the absolutely positive, the sum of all realities; **man the absolutely negative, comprehending all negation.**[113]

Here, projection is total. Everything that makes humanity great has been handed over to the divine being and humanity stands emptied before its own alienated essence, which is precisely what makes the final recognition possible. The final stage was where humanity recognised its delusional projections and turned towards humanism.[114] The endpoint of history, for Feuerbach, is the "open confession, that the consciousness of God is nothing else than the consciousness of the species."[115] Once humanity reclaims its projected essence, theology dissolves into anthropology and religion as we know it is over.

So what, exactly, is the "substance" in Feuerbach's substantive definition? What is the thing here that makes a religion? It is alienated human essence. This consists of human attributes, reason, will, love, moral perfection, personality, abstracted from the species and then contemplated as the predicates of a divine being. God is a catalogue of human excellences, nothing more. What makes something a religion, on this account, is that it takes the powerful potential of the human species as its object and mistakes that object for something supernatural. The supernatural content that Tylor, Spiro, and Wallace put at the centre of their definitions is, for Feuerbach, a misrecognition: the substance was human all along.

Three decades later, Engels provided a similar Marxist spin. For Engels, as for Freud and Feuerbach, religion was a projection, not of infantile desires or of internal essence, but of external forces beyond human control, like the weather, or capitalists, etc. In *Anti-Dühring* (1878) he wrote: "All religion...is nothing but the fantastic reflection in men's minds of those external forces which control their daily life, a reflection in which the terrestrial forces assume the form of supernatural forces."[116]

As with other definitions, Engels provides a genealogical lineage. He presents the lineage in four stages. The first is the stage of nature: primitive man, at a low level of knowledge and production,

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113 Ibid., 1.
114 Ibid., 270.
115 Ibid., 221.
116 Friedrich Engels, *Herr Eugen Dühring's Revolution in Science [Anti-Dühring]*, English translation of the 1894 third edition, translated and edited by Emile Burns (Moscow: Progress Publishers, 1878), https://www.marxists.org/archive/marx/works/1877/anti-duhring/.

experiences the forces of nature, storm, drought, disease, the seasons, as alien powers governing his existence. He reflects them as gods. The second stage arrives as production develops: the forces dominating daily life become increasingly *social,* the relations between producers, and the gods correspondingly "acquire social attributes, become representatives of the forces of history." Religion now reflects not only weather but commerce, war, and empire. The third stage is the passage to monotheism: the national gods of antiquity, Jupiter and Mars and their kin, had suited the republics of the city-states, but when Rome welded the Mediterranean into a single empire, the pantheon had to follow suit, hence the one god of the universal empire, and finally Christianity's single universal deity, which Engels calls "a reflection of the abstract man." The fourth stage is the modern: in bourgeois society the productive forces themselves, capital, machinery, the market, technology, confront the individual as an irresistible alien power. This *alienation* is what is still reflected in religion.

Across all four stages the mechanism never changes; only the object of reflection does. The gods are re-sculpted every time in the shape of human powerlessness. The progression terminates in a prediction: once society takes collective and planned possession of the productive forces, the last alien force reflected in religion will vanish, and the religious reflection will vanish with it, "for the simple reason that then there will be nothing left to reflect."[117]

It may not be immediately obvious that these scholarly attempts to provide substantive definitions are Eurocentric, ethnocentric, and even racist, but they are. Any staged view of the evolution of human thought that puts Western institutions (religion, science) at the top and other things (Asian systems, Indigenous systems) below is Eurocentric and ethnocentric.

Despite any theoretical pretensions that might exist, the definitions themselves are also quite simple. They all focus on a single thing to the exclusion of everything else we can observe in religion. Emile Durkheim, a major figure in the Sociology of Religion, did move beyond this simplicity, a bit. To the substance of religion he added "beliefs and practices." In his seminal work *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*, he said that "A religion is a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, that is to say, things set apart and forbidden — beliefs and practices which unite into one single moral community called a Church, all those who adhere to them."[118] For Durkheim, the substantive boundary

117 Ibid.
118 Durkheim, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*, 1995, 44.

between religion and everything else was that religion had "beliefs and practices" (the substance) that were all about mystical realms, sacred things, and spiritual beings.

There have been various criticisms of attempts to assert a boundary between religion/magic and science, based on belief in supernatural beings, supernatural forces and purported separation between the sacred and the profane. Not all religions believe in these forces. Buddha, for example, rejected the notion of supernatural forces and gods altogether,[119] yet Buddhism is clearly a religion.

Note that the distinction between sacred and profane might distinguish magic and religion from science, but it does not allow one to easily assert the advanced character of Western religious practices over the purported primitive character of Indigenous systems because both contain beliefs in supernatural beings and forces. Indigenous systems have ancestors and natural spirits, Western monotheisms have angels, devils, and God.

Durkheim "solved" this Boundary Problem[120] by suggesting religion was more social, while magic was more individualistic. Unfortunately, like other ethnocentric boundaries, Durkheim's assertions are more wishful thinking than empirical fact. Many ancient magical and ritual practices had a social aspect and a social intent. Fishermen who used magic to help with their catch were doing so with their families and communities in mind.[121] In addition, modern magical practices like Wicca and Thelema are deeply embedded in the social fabric. Witches have covens and cast spells for the good of themselves and their community.[122] Aleister Crowley, patriarch of the modern magical system known as Thelema, was embedded in esoteric and elitist social networks.

If you cannot distinguish magic from religion by its social character, how do you distinguish them? Even more to the point, can your typical white, Western scholar approach religion without attempting to assert ethnocentric or Eurocentric boundaries? It is an important question. Trying to assert ethnocentric and racist boundaries inevitably leads to inadequate, caricatured, reductionist definitions that capture neither the full complexity of the institution, or the full

119 Furseth and Repstad, *An Introduction to the Sociology of Religion: Classical and Contemporary Perspectives*.

120 The **Boundary Problem** is the persistent scholarly problem of how to draw a defensible line, substantively, functionally, ontologically, or epistemologically, between religion and other institutions and knowledge systems, like science. https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Boundary_Problem

121 Frazer, *The Golden Bough: A Study in Magic and Religion*.

122 Starhawk, *Spiral Dance, The - 20th Anniversary: A Rebirth of the Ancient Religion of the Goddess: 20th Anniversary Edition: Starhawk* (New York: Harper One, 2011).

significance of non-European belief system. Religion has been around for millennia. It is complex and embedded in human realities. Rather than trying to assert our superiority over others, perhaps we should just stop and simply observe, as Weber suggested.

The Substantive Definition of Ninian Smart

One scholar who has done a stellar job of just observing is Ninian Smart. Smart identifies the substantive content of religion without needing to draw ethnocentric boundaries by simply observing what is there.[123] His observations led him to identify seven substantive elements of religion,[124] the social, ritual/practical, experiential, doctrinal/mythic, ethical/moral, institutional, and material dimensions.[125] To these seven I would add an eighth substantive element, therapeutic/healing.

The Seven (Plus One) Substantive Elements of Religion

1. The Social Dimension. For Smart, the social dimension of religion refers to the people and the roles that make up the institution. This includes the "charismatic or sacred personages" like Jesus Christ, Buddha, Muhammad, as well as the roles provided by the institution (priest, congregation, prophet, Entered Apprentice, deacon). The social dimension is important. It is exactly where religion becomes observable: not doctrines in a book, but people doing things together. As he puts it elsewhere, a worldview, which is something a religion provides, "is an incarnated set of values which prescribes and is expressed through a way of life."[126] A religion with no people enacting it is just a text on a shelf.

Note that many of Smart's substantive categories contain functional attributions. For example, the social/institutional dimension functions to ensure a religion continues from generation to generation. In most religions, priests, gurus, prophets, etc. Help, among other functions, to mediate between the mundane and the sacred.

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123 *The Phenomenon of Religion* (New York: Macmillan, 1973); *The World's Religions* (Cambridge, MA: Cambridge University Press, 1992), https://archive.org/details/worldsreligions0000smar_v9j6.

124 Smart included only six dimensions of religion in his original formulation Smart, *The World's Religions*.. He later added the Material dimension, bringing the total to seven Ibid..

125 Glock and Stark provide an alternative categorization, suggesting five substantive elements of religion, the experiential, ritualistic, intellectual, ideological, and ritualistic Charles Glock and Rodney Stark, *Religion and Society in Tension* (Chicago: Rand McNally and Company, 1965), https://archive.org/details/religionsocietyi00gloc.. Ninian's conceptualization is, however, superior.

126 Ninian Smart, *Reflections in the Mirror of Religion* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1997), 65.

2. The Ritual and Practical Dimension. In addition to the social and institutional dimension, religions also have a practical and ritual dimension. This refers to the regular ritual practices, like "worship services, preaching, sacrifices, prayers, and so on" that constitute the behavioural repertoire of the religion.[127] Depending on your religion, this could mean going to Church and praying, living a reflective life in a monastery, practising Vedic Yoga for the purpose of achieving union, engaging in Zen meditative practices, and so on.

Smart distinguishes three types of ritual.[128] The first is *secular ritual*. These are rituals used in social situations. Saying "good morning" or "goodbye." Standing for a national anthem or visiting a Christmas parade are secular rituals that we engage in as part of social and cultural interactions. Second, we have *sacred ritual*. This is ritual "directed toward a holy being, such as God." This is worship. Kneeling in prayer, confessions, altars, and sacrifices are all sacred rituals. Finally, we have *pragmatic rituals*. These are rituals directed at attaining certain mystical experiences or states of consciousness.[129]

These ritual practices have several functions. **First**, ritual functions as a conduit of sacred power. Ritual acts as a receiver. In worship, Smart notes, "the worshipper does share in some sense in the holy power of the god."[130] **Second**, ritual functions to shape the individual into a specific form. In the esoteric religion the Golden Dawn, "the ultimate objective of magic ... was inner alchemy—the continual purification of the student's lower personality..."[131] As Regardie explains, "the object of the theurgic art, as the magical concept of initiation was then termed, was so to purify the personality that that which was there imprisoned could spring into open manifestation."[132] Whether it is the Neophyte grade of the Golden Dawn, Sunday Mass, or the jhānas of a Buddhist monk, ritual is a technology for making a new, and presumably better, person. **Finally**, ritual functions as a doorway. Religious rituals and practices function to facilitate the development of "spiritual awareness" and even *connection* and "union with God."[133] We see this in all religions. Mystical experiences, born-again experiences, shamanic connection experiences,

127 Smart, *The World's Religions*, 12.
128 Smart, *The Religious Experience*.
129 Ibid., 7.
130 Smart, *The Phenomenon of Religion*, 96.
131 Chic Cicero and Sandra Tabatha Cicero, "Preface to the Seventh Edition," in *The Golden Dawn: The Original Account of the Teachings, Rites, and Ceremonies of the Hermetic Order*, ed. Israel Regardie, 7th ed. (Woodbury, MN: Llewellyn, 2015), 15.
132 Israel Regardie, *The Golden Dawn: The Original Account of the Teachings, Rites, and Ceremonies of the Hermetic Order*, 7th ed. (Woodbury, MN: Llewellyn, 2015), 39.
133 Smart, *The World's Religions*, 13.

kensho and satori experiences (Buddhism), transcendent experiences, experiences of union with God,[134] experiences of "cosmic" consciousness,[135] etc., are all experiences facilitated by ritual. The Golden Dawn teachings are explicit about this. The point of ritual is "the realization of an elevated state of consciousness wherein the magician's psyche gradually enters into a union with the Higher Self."[136]

Speaking of conduits, inner alchemy, and states of consciousness, religion also has an...

3. Experiential Dimension. The experiential dimension, referred to repeatedly above, is religious experience, also referred to as mystical or transcendent experience because of the "mystical" and transcendent content they often contain. These experiences are not rare. In fact, they are relatively common. Many people, normal people and more than a few scholars,[137] including several prominent quantum physicists,[138] have them. Einstein himself, though he never openly admitted it, probably had more than one. In the book, *The World as I see it,* he speaks of a "religious feeling" that takes the form of "rapturous amazement" at the harmony of natural law and the superior intelligence behind it.

> His religious feeling takes the form of a rapturous amazement at the harmony of natural law, which reveals an intelligence of such superiority that, compared with it, all the systematic thinking and acting of human beings is an utterly insignificant reflection.[139]

Maslow would recognise the above as a peak experience.

Religious experiences are quite important, both for the individual and for the collective. Smart suggested that these experiences were significant factors in the "...formation and development of religious traditions." Somebody has one, two, or more, of these connection experiences, after which they go out and

134 Grace M. Jantzen, "Mysticism and Experience," *Religious Studies* 25, no. 3 (1989): 295–315.

135 R. M. Bucke, *Cosmic Consciousness: A Study in the Evolution of the Human Mind* (New York: E.P. Dutton, 2009), https://archive.org/details/cosmicconsciousn01buck; Edward Carpenter, *The Art of Creation: Essays on the Self and Its Powers* (London: George Allen and Unwin, 1912), https://archive.org/details/in.ernet.dli.2015.201671.

136 Chic Cicero and Sandra Tabatha Cicero, "Preface to the Seventh Edition," in *The Golden Dawn: The Original Account of the Teachings, Rites, and Ceremonies of the Hermetic Order*, ed. Israel Regardie, 7th ed. (Woodbury, MN: Llewellyn, 2015), 15.

137 Agehananda Bharati, *The Light at the Center: Context and Pretext of Modern Mysticism* (Ross Erikson, 1982); Bucke, *Cosmic Consciousness: A Study in the Evolution of the Human Mind*; Vine Jr. Deloria, *God Is Red: A Native View of Religion* (Colorado: Fulcrum Publishing, 2003); Michael Harner, *Cave and Cosmos: Shamanic Encounters with Another Reality* (Berkeley, California: North Atlantic Books, 2013); Oscar Ichazo, *The Human Process of Enlightenment and Freedom* (New York: Arica Institute, 1976).

138 Ken Wilber, *Quantum Questions: Mystical Writings of the World's Great Physicists* (New York: Shambhala, 2001).

139 Albert Einstein, *The World as I See It*, Kindle (Samaira Book Publishers, 2018), https://amzn.to/2NR8B6z.

start teaching. Sometimes, a religion is formed around the teachings. He lists the Buddha's "shattering mystical experience" under the Bodhi tree, the conversion of Paul on the road to Damascus, the mystical experiences of Muhammad, the visions of the prophets of the Hebrew Bible, and the direct connection experienced by Arjuna in the Bhagavad Gita, all of which led to a religion.[140] He could have also included the visions of the ancient Prophet Zoroaster.[141]

Smart was not the only one to think this. Both Rudolf Otto and psychologist William James felt that mystical experience was the very bedrock and foundation of religion itself.[142] Heriot-Maitland noted that mystical experience constitutes the very essence of religion, "such that the origin of a given tradition can often be traced to an initial transcendent encounter, moment of revelation, salvation, or enlightenment."[143] Abraham Maslow, famous for his study of secular-style peak experiences, concurs:

> The very beginning, the intrinsic core, the essence, the universal nucleus of every known high religion … has been the private, lonely, personal illumination, revelation, or ecstasy of some acutely sensitive prophet or seer. The high religions call themselves revealed religions and each of them tends to rest its validity, its function, and its right to exist on the codification and the communication of this original mystic experience or revelation from the lonely prophet to the mass of human beings in general.[144]

Religious experiences aren't just the foundation major, and probably minor, religions. They also have significance for human health and well being. William James, Abraham Maslow, William Miller,[145] and others note these barely-studied experiences can be profoundly transformative, catalysing "drastic, long-term, and often positive shifts in perception, world-view, and well-being."[146] I've had them, and I concur.

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140 James, *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study of Human Nature*, 10.

141 Mary Boyce, *Zoroastrians: Their Religious Beliefs and Practices* (Routledge, 2001).

142 James, *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study of Human Nature*, 6; Rudolf Otto, *The Idea of the Holy* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1917).

143 "Mysticism and Madness: Different Aspects of the Same Human Experience?," *Mental Health, Religion & Culture* 11, no. 3 (2008): 302, doi:10.1080/13674670701287680.

144 Maslow, "The 'Core-Religious' or 'Transcendent' Experience," in *The Highest State of Consciousness*, ed. John White (New York: Doubleday, 2012), 339.

145 William R. Miller, "The Phenomenon of Quantum Change," *Journal of Clinical Psychology* 60, no. 5 (2004): 453–60, doi:10.1002/jclp.20000; Miller and Baca, *Quantum Change: When Epiphanies and Sudden Insights Transform Ordinary Lives*.

146 Jessica Sophie Corneille and David Luke, "Spontaneous Spiritual Awakenings: Phenomenology, Altered States, Individual Differences, and Well-Being.," *Frontiers in Psychology* 12 (2021): 720579,

My life, my cognition, my emotional well-being, these are all vastly improved as a consequence of, what I would prefer to call for reasons I'll enumerate later, connection experiences I've had.

So, what is mystical/religious experience exactly? And what are its functions? These are tough questions to answer and we will address them in more detail in the last chapter of this book. For now I'll just say, along with Stark & Glock, that "The term 'religious experience' covers an exceedingly disparate array of events: from the vaguest glimmerings of something sacred to rapturous mystical unions with the divine, or even to revelations."[147] There are the "oceanic feelings " discussed by Freud,[148] the pure consciousness events, which are events of utter blankness,[149] the sexual mystical experience, physical union with Christ and God[150] and experiences of the divine world itself as sexual.[151] There are even secular "mystical" experiences, what Abraham Maslow called peak and plateau experiences.[152]

4. The Narrative or Mythic Dimension. As Smart points out, the ritual, practical, and experiential dimensions of religion are "addressed in a certain way."[153] By this he means that ritual, practice, and religious experience are interpreted, expressed, invested with depth, and passed on down the generations through the narrative stories, symbols,[154] and myths of a religion. Myths are the stories told about the other dimensions of religion, about God or the gods, angels, etc.[155] These include stories about key historical events—the Buddha's enlightenment under the Bodhi tree, the loss and rebuilding of the temple in the Jewish faith. Mythic beliefs reveal the histories of the transcendental entities, the origin of things, the history of key figures (Jesus, Buddha, Muhammad, certain saints, etc.), the eschatological denouement of humanity, and so on.[156] Sacred texts are texts taken to be provide by some higher spiritual intelligence, typically God or one of God's "special" representatives. These narratives and myths are authorised as sacred

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doi:10.3389/fpsyg.2021.720579.

147 *Religion and Society in Tension*.

148 Freud, *Civilization and Its Discontents*.

149 Robert K. C. Forman, "Pure Consciousness Events and Mysticism," *Sophia* 25, no. April (1986): 49–58.

150 Louis William Meldman, *Mystical Sex: Love, Ecstasy and the Mystical Experience* (Rockport, MA: Element Books, 1997); Melila Hellner-Eshed, *A River Flows from Eden: The Language of Mystical Experience in the Zohar* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2009).

151 Hellner-Eshed, *A River Flows from Eden: The Language of Mystical Experience in the Zohar*, 13.

152 Stanley Krippner, "The Plateau Experience: A. H. Maslow and Others," *The Journal of Transpersonal Psychology* 4, no. 2 (1972): 107–20.

153 Smart, *The Phenomenon of Religion*, 42.

154 Clifford Geertz, "Religion as a Cultural System," in *Anthropological Approaches to the Study of Religion*, ed. Michael Banton (Oxon: Routledge, 2004), 1–44.

155 Smart, *The Religious Experience*.

156 Smart, *The Phenomenon of Religion*.

texts through a process of "casting" that may be overtly political and enacted by elites—as in Constantine's imperial sponsorship of the Christian scriptures—or may emerge gradually over time through communal usage and consensus. As Smart notes, the historical veracity of these texts is beside the point and secondary to the meaning and function the myths provide for the faithful.

As for functions, religious narratives have at least three. **One**, they social work. First, Malinowski observed that a community's mythic charter of origins "obviously makes for cohesion, for local patriotism, for a feeling of union and kinship in the community."[157] The story of the Bodhi tree, the Exodus, the Hijra — these are identity documents. They tell you who "we" are, where we came from, and why we belong together. **Two**, they do pedagogical work. As Malinowski puts it, myth is "a warrant, a charter, and often even a practical guide to the activities with which it is connected."[158] Narratives carry the values and norms of the tradition, packaged as a memorable story. A child who hears the parable of the Good Samaritan has absorbed an ethical principle without ever being lectured. **Three**, they do transformative work. A worldview, Smart writes, "is an incarnated set of values which prescribes and is expressed through a way of life,"[159] and narrative is one of its main delivery systems. The become clear when we consider the intersection of ritual and narrative. Through ritual, the events of the story "can be made present to men [sic]so that they can suitably participate in it."[160] The myth of Christ's death and resurrection is not merely commemorated at Easter; it is re-presented and re-entered every year. Participant who enter into it is ar meant to come out the other side changed — the "old man" replaced by the new.[10]

5. **The Doctrinal and Philosophical Dimension**. In addition to myths, religious experience is also interpreted, expressed, and authorised through religious doctrine.[161] Doctrines themselves represent the formalised and codified cosmological, eschatological, and theological views of a particular religion. " Doctrines are an attempt to give system, clarity, and intellectual power to what is revealed through the mythological and symbolic language of religious faith and ritual."[162] Doctrine is composed of the philosophical and intellectual statements provide by a religion's intelligentsia, typically working for a religion's elite controllers. Examples include the doctrine of the Trinity of the Catholic Church, Buddhist

157 Malinowski, *Magic, Science, and Religion and Other Essays*, 94.
158 Ibid., 85.
159 Smart, *Reflections in the Mirror of Religion*, 64.
160 Smart, *The Phenomenon of Religion*, 110.
161 Smart, *The World's Religions*, 16–17.
162 Smart, *The Religious Experience*, 8.

philosophical statements on the nature of reality and enlightenment, various doctrines of salvation that are based on specific theological views of reality, and so on.

It should be noted, underlined really, with double underlines, that doctrine is almost exclusively generated by elites. This is true, for example, of Zoroastrianism where elite high priests wrote down their version of word of mouth Zoroastrian teachings[163] and it is also true of Catholicism whose doctrinal book (The Bible) was selected and compiled by Emperor Constantine and his elite bishops,[164] later to be edited by Church officials.[165] This is true of Freemasonry where official dogma is written by elites like Albert Pike,[166] and also of the New Age movement, a movement primarily rooted in the channelled teachings of a Russian noblewoman by the name of Madame Blavatsky.[167]

It is important to keep in mind the fact that doctrine and dogma are provided by elites. As Ninian notes, when most scholars study religion, most refer to elite-generated religious doctrine for their understanding and analysis. Not only does this tend to give an unbalanced view of religion and human spirituality, but it means scholars unwittingly amplify elite dogma while overlooking grassroots actions.

Speaking of imbalance, we come to the function of doctrine, which is ideological. It plays a role in formalizing and authorizing the ideas of the ruling class. Doctrine never merely describes the world, it certifies certain aspects of it, like who who gets the rewards (the "chosen" few), who gets to rule, and such and like that. The founding of the Sasanian Empire gives us the playbook. Ardashir I was a usurper, a local warlord who toppled the long-established Arsacid dynasty. He understood that conquest alone could not make him righteous. So he reached for religion, making "religious propaganda" one of the explicit tools of his statecraft.[168] His court priest Tansar duly issued the theological brief for the coup: the faith had decayed under the Arsacids, its laws and ordinances lost, and it "must needs be restored by a man of true and upright judgment," a man — who just happened to be Ardashir.[169] The priests manufactured a genealogy tracing the new dynasty back to the legendary Kayanian kings, making Ardashir's house appear

163 Boyce, *Zoroastrians: Their Religious Beliefs and Practices*.
164 Bart D. Ehrman, *Misquoting Jesus: The Story Behind Who Changed the Bible and Why* (Harper One, 2007).
165 Ibid.
166 Albert Pike, *Morals and Dogma* (London: Global Grey Books, 1871).
167 Meera Nanda, "Madame Blavatsky's Children" 2010, https://www.academia.edu/27289493/Madame_Blavatskys_children_pdf.
168 Boyce, *Zoroastrians: Their Religious Beliefs and Practices*.
169 Ibid., 102.

"as natural heirs to ... divine grace,"[170] the rightful rulers of all Zoroastrians. From the work of Tanser, a single Zoroastrian church was created under the direct, authoritarian control of Persia, a single canon of scripture was approved and authorised by Tansar's circle, and that circle claimed a monopoly of meaning. Those who didn't fit the new doctrinal dimensions, the recalictrant, where killed in order to preserve and strengthen the foundations of State and Religion.[171]

6. The Path - Aspirational/Ethical/Legal Dimension. As Smart points out, religions usually incorporate ethical codes.[172] But not just ethics. Religions also include aspirational elements and legal elements, what Glock and Stark call value orientations, as well.[173] Value orientations are just that. They orient you towards some aspirational goal Taken together these provide a kind of road map and pointer for your life. They provide *a path* that you should take if you are to make progress, even arrive, at the aspirational goals.

The logic is clear.

The aspirational element sets the orientation and goal.

The ethical element specifies the things required and the path to take to get to the goal.

The legal dimensions are the aspirational elements which can sometimes be set down and made by enforceable by law.

In Christianity, the goal is Heaven. To get there we are told to "love your neighbour as yourself" (Leviticus 19:18). The *Decalogue* (the ten commandments) species ten line-in-the-sand "thou shalt nots" that thou shalt follow else thou shalt not get into heaven. Thou shalt not kill, thou shalt not commit adultery, etc., The *Sermon on the Mount* Jesus blesses the poor, the mournful, the meek, the merciful, the peacemakers, the pure in heart, and gives them a place in heaven, but it calls out the self-satisfied rich folk, saying "woe to you who are rich" and "woe to you who are well fed" and "woe to you laugh.[174] There, Jesus calls everyone to be "perfect as your heavenly Father is perfect."

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170 Ibid., 126.
171 Boyce, *Zoroastrians: Their Religious Beliefs and Practices*.
172 Smart, *The Religious Experience*.
173 Glock and Stark, *Religion and Society in Tension*.
174 Luke 6, 24-26.

Or consider the Buddhism. It has the **Noble Eight Fold Path.**[175] This path, set out in the famous *first* discourse of Buddha, "Setting in Motion the Wheel of the Dhamma,"[176] sets the goals, which are be "released from the bonds of mara," [177] i.e., death, to acquire vision, peace, direct knowledge, enlightenment, and to attain nibbāna, which is the "blowing out" or extinguishing of greed, hatred, delusion and final freedom from suffering![178]

Yay!

In Buddhism, the path you take to get to nibbāna is the "right" path, the Noble Eight Fold Path, characterised by right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration.[179]

In Islam, the goal is submission (the literal meaning of *islam*) to Allah and entry into Paradise, with the Day of Judgment as the moment of accounting. The path is laid out in the Five Pillars, the confession of faith (shahada), prayer (salat), almsgiving (zakat), fasting during Ramadan (sawm), and pilgrimage to Mecca (hajj), plus the broader ethical demand of the Qur'an: "Allah commands justice, kindness, and generosity to kin; and forbids indecency, wickedness and oppression" (Qur'an 16:90).4 Where the aspiration and ethics get written down as enforceable law, you get the *sharia,* literally the "path to the water hole," covering everything from worship to contracts to inheritance. The ideal person is the *mu'min*, the faithful one; the ideal society is the one that "enjoins what is right and forbids what is wrong" (Qur'an 3:110).

In Hinduism, the road map is the doctrine of *dharma*. The destination is *moksha*, liberation from the cycle of rebirth. The Bhagavad Gita is characterised as Moksha Shastra, a scripture of liberation. It points in a direction (moksha), points out the path to be followed by the *sannyasin (student/devotee),* and spells out the things you need to do to get there. The Gita itself names the three routes, karma yoga (the path of

175 The path is set out in the Buddha's first sermon: "Setting in Motion the Wheel of the Dhamma" (Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta), in *Saṃyutta Nikāya* 56:11. For a concise treatment, see Damien Keown, *Buddhism: A Very Short Introduction* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1996), 39–56. Damien Keown, *Buddhism: A Very Short Introduction* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1996), 39–56.

176 "Setting in Motion the Wheel of the Dhamma," *Sutta Central*, June 21, 2021, https://suttacentral.net/sn56.11/en/bodhi?; "The Noble Eightfold Path," *Sutta Central*, June 21, 2021, https://suttacentral.net/arv19/en/anandajoti.

177 "The Path," *Sutta Central*, June 21, 2021, https://suttacentral.net/dhp273-289/en/buddharakkhita.

178 "Setting in Motion the Wheel of the Dhamma."

179 Namchak, "Noble Eightfold Path | Namchak Community," *Namchak*, June 21, 2021, https://www.namchak.org/community/blog/the-noble-eightfold-path/.

action, ch. 3), jnana yoga (the path of knowledge, ch. 4), and bhakti yoga (the path of devotion, 9:22, 18:65). The legal element is the *Dharmashastra* literature, above all the Laws of Manu, which harden dharma into actual caste law, dictating what each varna may eat, marry, and do.

In Zoroastrian, the end goal is crystal clear, a paradise renewed. The soul's store of good thoughts, good words, and good deeds determines whether it may *follow the path* across the Chinvat Bridge into the House of Song or fall from its narrowing razor edge. In the Zoroastrian faith, history itself moves toward a final renovation of the world in which evil is destroyed and creation perfected.[180]

Finally, Judaism. It gives us the same three-layer structure in compact form. The aspiration is captured in one line from the Holiness Code: "You shall be holy, for I the Lord your God am holy" (Leviticus 19:2), the ideal person, set right after, is the one who leaves the gleanings of the field for the poor and loves the stranger as oneself (Leviticus 19:9-10, 19:34). The ethics are the9 613 *mitzvot*; and the legal dimension is *halakha*, literally meaning "to go" or "to walk," translated as "the way of walking" or "the path." The halakha is he vast body of enforceable religious law derived from Torah and rabbinic interpretation that governs diet, Sabbath, and civil life.

Functionally speaking, the "path" that religions provide serve at least two functions.

The Social Function. First, ethical codes and prescribed practices, such as the Ten Commandments shared by Judaism and Christianity, the Torah's mitzvot, the Five Pillars of Islam,[181] and the Buddha's Eightfold Path, function to bind a community together, facilitating social cohesion and group solidarity through ethical alignment. This has been obvious to social scientists for a while. Durkheim saw this as religion's defining social role. According to him, religion is "a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things… which unite into one single moral community called a Church, all those who adhere to them."[182] To uphold the tradition's values is simultaneously to affirm membership in the group, rules of social cohesion, and successful attainment of the ultimate goal, however expressed. Even the stipulation attributed to Christ, to "love one another," functions this way: a command that appears purely

180 Boyce, *Zoroastrians: Their Religious Beliefs and Practices*.
181 John L. Esposito, *Islam: The Straight Path*, 4th ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 2011); F. E. Peters, *The Hajj: The Muslim Pilgrimage to Mecca and the Holy Places* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1994).
182 Durkheim, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*, 1995, 44.

personal simultaneously constitutes a community ideally defined by that love and the path one must follow if one is to arrive in heaven.[183]

In addition to the social function, the aspirational, ethical, and legal aspects that constitute the path" also provide a soteriological function, which we have already seen. **The Soteriological Function**[184] is basically providing "the path" to "liberation," "salvation," and even emancipation. Jesus informs his followers that he is here to proclaim good news to the poor and to the prisoners, to help the blind people see, and to set the oppressed free (Luke 4, 18). It is freedom from greed, suffering, abuse, and all the other toxicities of this world. [185]

Interestingly, according to Smart, the path, the aspirational/ethical/legal dimension of religion one of the most recognizable dimensions of religion, since (I would argue) every tradition has teachings about conduct, character, social justice, and the consequences of improper alignment.

7. **The Material Dimension**. The final substantive dimension of religion identified by Smart is the material dimension. This is straight forward. The material dimension of religion includes the material expressions of religious belief, like buildings, works of art, artifacts, statues, rosaries, pipes, medicine bags, and any other physical components of religion. Note that the material aspects of religion are not always physical creations of humanity. Natural features of the world, like the river Ganges in India, the Jordan in the Middle East, sacred mountains in China, the Mount of Olives, Mount Sinai, Eagle feathers, and so forth, can function as material components of a religion.[186]

Functionally speaking, the material dimension does more than just decorate spaces. **First**, the perceptual work: physical objects are how the invisible gets handles. Smart himself treated religious art and symbolism as "material adjuncts of or expressions of ritual at the one end, myth and doctrine at the other."[187] These are the accoutrements of myth, ritual, and doctrine. They material tips of the mythical, ritual, and social iceberg. As Durkheim said, "The god of the clan, the totemic principle, can therefore be

183 John 13:34. See also Matt. 22:39, where Jesus joins the command to love one's neighbor (Lev. 19:18) to the love of God as the sum of the law.
184 Ninian Smart, *Worldviews: Crosscultural Explorations of Human Beliefs*, 3rd ed. (Upper Saddle River, NJ: Prentice Hall, 2000); Smart, *The Religious Experience*.
185 Smart, *Worldviews: Crosscultural Explorations of Human Beliefs*, 102.
186 Smart, *The World's Religions*.
187 Smart, *The Phenomenon of Religion*, 43.

nothing else than the clan itself, personified and represented to the imagination under the visible form of the animal or vegetable which serves as totem."[cite].

Second, material things assemble the community. They do "gathering" work. Temples and churches function as gathering places and even sacred geography. The Ganges, Mount Sinai, the lotus flower, the mediating Buddha, etc. All help stich communal identity directly onto territory. **Third**, the material dimension is where the institution parks its wealth. Boyce describes how the establishing of the temple cult required buildings, priests, and endowments, giving "new scope for the wealth of imperial Persia to be lavished on the faith," with magnificent temples "embellished with gold and silver, and endowed with great estates."[188] Finally, fourth, the material dimension is where the institution parks its authority [vestments, templates, alters, holy relics that only the authority figures (priest) can touch.

It is important not to underestimate the importance of the material dimension

8. **The Therapeutic/Healing Dimension.** As noted above, in addition to Smart's seven substantive elements, I would add an eighth substantive element, and that is healing. Many, though not all, religious and spiritual systems contain a therapeutic/healing element. Catholicism, for example, is rooted in the healing practice of Jesus Christ, who went around healing the sick and blind. The Gospels are practically a catalogue of healing interventions, he heals lepers, paralytics, the blind, the deaf, and the demon-possessed, and "the whole town gathered at the door, and Jesus healed many who had various diseases" (Mark 1:33-34). Crucially, he commissions his followers to do the same: "Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse those who have leprosy, drive out demons. Freely you have received; freely give" (Matthew 10:8).2 The Catholic tradition followed through: one of the seven sacraments is literally the Anointing of the Sick, prescribed in the Epistle of James — "Is anyone among you sick? Let them call the elders of the church to pray over them and anoint them with oil in the name of the Lord. The prayer offered in faith will make the sick person well" (James 5:14-15). Add to that two thousand years of shrines (Lourdes alone has documented over 70 cures the Church calls "miraculous"), [189] relics, exorcisms, and hospitals. The word "hospital" itself comes from the Christian hospitium. Here you have a tradition where healing is not a side hustle; it is a a core practice handed down with detailed guidance.

188 Boyce, *Zoroastrians: Their Religious Beliefs and Practices*, 64.

189 "Miraculous Healings," *Vivre Le Pèlerinage de Lourdes*, accessed September 17, 2026, https://www.lourdes-france.com/en/miraculous-healings/.

The Buddha, likewise, was therapeutically oriented, and in a remarkably modern way. In the Simsapa (Indiant rosewood tree) Sutta, he boils the entire edifice of his substantial teachings down to the elimination of dukkha, which is the Pali word for discomfort, suffering, unpleasantness, and *stress*.

> And what have I taught? 'This is stress... This is the origination of stress... This is the cessation of stress... This is the path of practice leading to the cessation of stress': This is what I have taught. And why have I taught these things? Because they are connected with the goal, relate to the rudiments of the holy life, and lead to disenchantment, to dispassion, to cessation, to calm, to direct knowledge, to self-This is the path of practice leading to the cessation of stress. awakening, to Unbinding. This is why I have taught them.[190]

Buddha's statements here would find a comfortable place in a modern medical office. Strees is bad, you should redude it. Here, the Four Noble Truths map onto a medical diagnosis one-for-one. The disease is dukkha, stress from all the unpleasantness of life, like disease, pain, discomfort, suffering, affliction, etc.[191] The cause (tanha, craving), the prognosis (it can end), and the prescription (the Eightfold Path).[192] The Pali canon makes the metaphor explicit, addressing him as "the unsurpassed physician and surgeon." His guidance is intensely practical: meditation (samatha for calming the mind, vipassana for seeing things as they are), mindfulness of the body, loving-kindness (metta) practice to dissolve the hatred that worsens suffering, and the precepts as preventive medicine, don't do the things that make you sick in the first place. Where Catholicism heals by invoking a personal God who answers prayer, Buddhism heals by training you to see that the self you keep injuring was never really there.

Then there are the Indigenous traditions, where the boundary between healing and religion hardly exists at all. Many (if not all) Indigenous systems have a therepeutic element. The shaman is a healer, one who "can contact the supernatural world.... His or her ability to contact spirits and his capacity to come back from the realm of death give him the power, it is thought, not only to tell where game can be found but also to cure disease" [193] In *The Religious Experience,* Smart writes of African healers that they are "not, by and large, evil sorcerers, but practitioners of a sort of traditional and often **psychologically effective**

190 Thanissaro Bhikkhu, trans., "Simsapa Sutta: The Simsapa Leaves," *Access to Insight*, 2026, https://accesstoinsight.org/tipitaka/sn/sn56/sn56.031.than.html.
191 https://gandhari.org/dictionary?section=ptsd
192 Smart, *Worldviews: Crosscultural Explorations of Human Beliefs*.
193 Ibid., 61.

medicine." [194] Indigenous North Americans have the Sweat Lodge. The guidance they offer is not a text but a technique: drumming and chanting to enter trance, sweat lodges to purge, smudging to clear, vision quests to find one's guardian spirit. In the Americas, the sacramental ingestion of plant teachers, peyote in the Native American Church, ayahuasca in Amazonian traditions, psilocybin among Mesoamerican peoples is aimed at healing.[195] Iroquois False Face societies prescribe actual herbal pharmacology alongside their masked rituals; the guidance is practical (here is the medicine, here is the ceremony) and the cosmology behind it is seamless: sickness is disharmony with the spirits, the animals, and the land, and healing is restoring that harmony.

Consider the medicine bag.[196] The medicine bag is pan–North American.[197] It is of the most widespread Indigenous religious objects on the continent. Here are the main carriers: It is Found across the Plains and Woodlands: the Lakota/Dakota, Cheyenne, Blackfoot, Cree, Comanche, and Arapaho on the Plains; the Ojibwe (Chippewa), Cherokee, and Iroquois/Haudenosaunee in the eastern Woodlands. The bag is a small pouch, traditionally worn on the person or kept in a safe place, holding items of spiritual power, sacred herbs, stones, animal teeth or claws, feathers, tobacco, and tokens received during a vision quest. It's usually made or gifted by an elder or medicine person, and it's personal in a strong sense: you don't open someone else's bag, and showing its contents casually drains its power. **The Ojibwe Midewiwin,** the "Grand Medicine Society,"[198] deserves special mention because "medicine" is right in the name. Mide practitioners carry medicine pouches containing, among other things, the sacred shell (*migis*), and the society's initiations and healing ceremonies revolve around them.

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194 Smart, *The Religious Experience*, 37.

195 Alvaro Estrada, *Maria Sabina: Her Life and Chants*, trans. Henry Munn (Santa Barbara, California: Ross-Erikson, 1981); Barbara G. Myerhoff, *Peyote Hunt: The Sacred Journey of the Huichol Indians* (London: Cornell University Press, 1974), https://archive.org/details/peyotehuntsacred0000myer/page/n5/mode/2up; Sonia Lucana and John Elfers, "Sacred Medicine: Indigenous Healing and Mental Health," *The Qualitative Report* 25, no. 12 (December 1, 2020): 4482; David Cumes, "South African Indigenous Healing: How It Works," *EXPLORE* 9, no. 1 (January 1, 2013): 58–65, doi:https://doi.org/10.1016/j.explore.2012.11.007.

196 In Lakota terms, medicine translates to *wakan,* sacred power. The bag is less a portable pharmacy and more a portable altar: it carries healing power, protection, and a relationship with a guardian spirit. The guidance offered is carry your relationship with the spirit world on your body, not "take two of these and call me in the morning.

197 Sam D. Gill, *Native American Religions: An Introduction* (Belmont, CA: Wadsworth Publishing, 1982); Royal B. Hassrick, *The Sioux: Life and Customs of a Warrior Society* (Norman: University of Oklahoma Press, 1964).

198 Walter James Hoffman, "The Midéwiwin or 'Grand Medicine Society' of the Ojibwa," in *Seventh Annual Report of the Bureau of American Ethnology to the Secretary of the Smithsonian Institution, 1885-'86* (Washington, DC: Government Printing Office, 1891), 143–300, https://archive.org/details/annualreportofbu7198586smit.

Hinduism gave the world Ayurveda, the "science of life," codified in the Charaka Samhita, which ties bodily health directly to dharma: you are sick because you are out of alignment, so real healing is spiritual realignment, with yoga as the therapeutic technology.[199] Islam frames the Qur'an itself as medicine: "We send down in the Qur'an that which is a healing and a mercy to those who believe" (Qur'an 17:82), and the tradition of ruqyah prescribes reciting specific verses over the sick. Even the Greeks had Asclepius, whose temples were basically ancient sanatoria where the sick slept in the sanctuary hoping for a healing dream. The point for Smart's framework is this: healing sits naturally alongside his ritual and experiential dimensions — it is where worldview stops being theory and puts its hands on the patient. Some traditions pray, some meditate, some journey to the spirit world, some recite — but they all recognise the human predicament is felt most acutely in the sick body, and they all show up there.

Conclusion

To review, Smart identifies seven substantive elements of religion, the social, ritual/practical, experiential, doctrinal/mythic, ethical/moral, institutional, and material dimensions. We add an eighth, healing.

199 on yoga as therapeutic path, see Smart, *Worldviews: Crosscultural Explorations of Human Beliefs* and in particular the discussion of yoga.

3. What is Religion Redux?

We started this book asking a simple question: what is religion? As we noted at the outset, social scientists struggle with this. We gave three reasons for this embarrassing state of affairs. First, religion is "phenomenally complex"[200] and complexity resists tidy definition. Second, we have this Occam-driven desire to simplify, to compress the whole sprawling phenomenon into a single sound bite we can deploy at dinner parties. Marx reduced it to an opiate, Freud to an infantile delusion, Durkheim to a projection of society. Useful slogans, all of them, but all of them caricatures. Third, the people doing the defining are biased — predominantly white, European, ethnocentric, Eurocentric, and on their worst days, racist. Given all this, we decided to follow Max Weber's advice. Stop arguing about boundaries. Stop legislating. Just look, and see what is there.

When we looked, we found Ninian Smart's seven substantive elements — social, ritual/practical, experiential, narrative/mythic, doctrinal/philosophical, ethical/legal, and material — to which we added an eighth, the therapeutic (healing) element. Seven plus one.

Recall the problem we started with. The definitional space out there is "bewilderingly fuzzy." New Age movements, flying saucer cults, radical environmentalism, eco-feminism, human potential groups, holistic therapies, even sport, fitness, and dietary practices have been claimed as essentially religious. So the question now is obvious: does Smart's descriptive work actually help us with this fuzz, or have we just traded one muddle for another?

To answer that, we need to ask two further questions.

200 Sharot, *A Comparative Sociology of World Religions*.

Question One: Do All Eight Elements Have to Be Present?

Our first question is, do all eight elements have to be present for something to count as a religion? That is a good question. If all eight elements must be present, then if we find an institution with all of them, then we have a religion. Unfortunately, the answer to this question is no. Smart was not legislating what a religion must contain. He was describing what he found when he looked. His dimensions work less like a checklist at the border — passport? check. Plane ticket? check. Proof of onward travel? check — and more like a family resemblance, a bunch of traits that function as overlapping bundles of similarities.

The real traditions bear this out. Consider early Buddhism. The Buddha refused to waste so much as a single breath on metaphysical speculation. In the Simsapa Sutta he scoops up a handful of leaves from the forest floor and tells his monks that what he has *not* explained vastly outweighs what he has, and what he has explained amounts to exactly four things: suffering, its origin, its cessation, and the path towards that cessation.[201] No creator god, no divine pantheon, no cosmological dogma required, and yet nobody denies Buddhism is a religion.

The Quakers strip away even more. What Quakers call Silent Worship has no clergy, no sacraments, no liturgy, no creeds, no icons; the congregation simply sits in silence and waits for divine inspiration, for the "gentle whisper" (1 Kings 19:12, NIV), the "still small voice" of God (1 Kings 19: 12, KJ). As Robert Barclay put it in 1678, true worship "is offered in the inward and immediate moving and drawing of his own Spirit, which is neither limited to places, times, or persons."[202] Almost no ritual apparatus, no material apparatus, and no fixed doctrine. The entire emphasis is to sit quietly in a room and wait for mystical insight.[203]

Zen goes further still and makes its suspicious of scripture a defining slogan. The verse attributed to founder, Bodhidharma defines the essence of Zen which is "a special transmission outside the scriptures, not founded upon words and letters."[204] Zen literature and teachings are filled with warnings against mistaking scriptures for the living truth provided by direct experience. Bodhidharma's famous encounter

201 Bhikkhu, "Simsapa Sutta: The Simsapa Leaves."
202 Robert Barclay, *An Apology for the True Christian Divinity*, 1678, https://www.qhpress.org/texts/barclay/apology/.
203 Marsha D. Holliday, "Silent Worship and Quaker Values," *FCG Friends*, June 1, 2000, https://www.fgcquaker.org/2000/06/01/silent-worship-and-quaker-values/.
204 Heinrich Dumoulin, *Zen Buddhism: A History. Volume 1: India and China*, ed. Paul F. Knitter (New York: Macmillan, 1988).

with Emperor Wu, where he declared that building temples and copying sutras accrued "no merit," exemplifies this iconoclastic attitude. A religion that is officially wary of doctrines and texts is still, somehow, a religion.

Confucianism centres ethics and ritual propriety while keeping the transcendent politely at arm's length. Asked how one ought to serve the spirits, the Master replies, "You do not yet understand life — how could you understand death?" Ethics and ritual propriety, almost nothing about transcendent beings or mystical experience, yet Confucianism is recognised as a religion.

If not all the elements are required, then Smart's framework does not discriminate as well as we might hope. Sports has several of the dimensions, ritual, mythic, social, and you could argue the point, but under Smart its status would always be ambiguous. Is a playoff game a religious rite? Under a family resemblance model, maybe. The checklist alone cannot settle it.

So Smart's seven-plus-one, taken as a checklist, is not very helpful for policing the boundary. But there is still a possibility it might help, which brings us to the second question.

Question Two: Are Some Elements Required?

If not all of Smart's substantive elements are required, perhaps some of them are. Are there specific elements that, when present, allow us to distinguish religion from, say, a sports event or a musical concert? Elements that pull religion into focus amidst the fuzzy blur?

Maybe. I can personally see four candidates.

Candidate One: The Social Element

All religions contain a social element. Every single one. Wherever you find a religion you find people, and wherever you find people you find organization, in-groups and out-groups, hierarchies, and potlucks. The problem is that this candidate carries no discriminatory power whatsoever. Religion is, by definition, an institution All human institutions are social in some way. Banks have social elements, staff parties, inner circles, the branch manager's Christmas speech. Google has social elements. The Boy Scouts have social elements, and so does the lodge, the temple, the Church, the Ashram, the Coven gathering, etc.. If "social" is the criterion, then everything humans build together qualifies as religion, and we have defined nothing. What distinguishes the social dimension of a religion from the social dimension of a

corporation? It is not shared belief in the supernatural, because, as we have seen, the Buddhist tradition does not require that. The social element is necessary for religion, but it is not sufficient, and it is not distinctive. We need to keep looking.

Candidate Two: The Experiential Dimension

Candidate two is the experiential dimension, the mystical or religious experience. And the theorists all agree this one comes close to universal. Smart, Otto, James, Maslow, all of them argue that traditions begin with somebody's experience. Somebody sees something, feels something, connects with something, and a tradition grows up around the retelling. The visions of Muhammad, the conversion of Paul, the enlightenment of the Buddha under the Bodhi tree. Strip the experience out of the origin stories and there is not much left.

But not all traditions get behind this candidate. Certain branches of Satanism, for example the LaVeyan Church of Satan, is atheist. Their rituals are psychodrama and their "magic" is directed at transforming the psyche. They claim to be a religion and they act like the religion, but they dismiss the religious experience. But, they have enough of the other elements to place them in the category, so my assessment is that they are religion.

Satanism is only the most obvious case. Religions traditions have historically had an uneasy relationship with religious experience. Some are actively wary of private experience, and for intelligible reasons. Doctrinal orthopraxies, the Catholic Church in certain periods, doctrinal Buddhism in others, Confucian state ritual, treat private experience as something to be managed, controlled, tested against authority, or politely ignored. The Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Letter to the Bishops of the Catholic Church on Some Aspects of Christian Meditation* (1989), offers a modern instance of this managerial instinct, warning that meditation techniques imported from Eastern traditions can "degenerate" into a "cult of the self" if not subordinated, framed, judged, and guided [read controlled by] Church doctrine.[205] And that is just a recent example. The Church has always reserved to itself the judgment of whether a vision is divine or demonic, and it has not been shy about exercising that judgment against living mystics:

205 Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Letter to the Bishops of the Catholic Church on Some Aspects of Christian Meditation (Orationis Formas)*, Acta Apostolicae Sedis 82 (1990): 362-379 (Vatican City: Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, October 15, 1989), https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_con_cfaith_doc_19891015_meditazione-cristiana_en.html.

Marguerite Porete was burned at the stake in 1310 for refusing to recant the theology of her *Mirror of Simple Souls*, while Meister Eckhart's propositions were condemned posthumously in 1329.[206] Even John of the Cross was imprisoned by his own order before being vindicated by history.

Doctrinal Buddhism supplies its own cautions: the Buddha, in the *Kevattā Sutta*, expressly declines to authorise displays of supernormal power as a basis of conviction, and scholars have traced how the rhetoric of meditative experience is policed and constructed by monastic elites.[207] Confucian state ritual completes the pattern: in Xunzi's theory, ritual is an instrument of social discipline and cosmic ordering, not a channel for private communion, so the officiant's interior state is, strictly speaking, beside the point.[208] An unregulated vision is a threat to a regulated hierarchy. As Jantzen has demonstrated, the very category of "mysticism" was constructed by male-dominated religious institutions that decide, after the fact and on their own terms, whose experiences count as authentic.[209] Mystics get canonised after they die; while they live, they get investigated.[210]

And there is a second problem: institutions other than the religious can deal in the experiential side too. Rock concerts can provide an religion experienc. Modern psychedelic therapies go straight there by chemical elevator. But is that a religion? I don't know. You tell me.

Even science crosses this border sometimes. Recently, MAPS has been accused of being a “therapy cult” for teaching about one’s “inner healing intelligence,” a concept introduce by Stanislav Grof in his work on psychedelics, and having “mystical and utopian goals.” I mean, that’s not a bad thing in an off itself, but religious experience and utopian aspiration does check two of the 7+1 boxes and it does push MAPS therapy towards a religious categorization. And so what. As we’ll see in a few short moments, science checks all of the 7+1 boxes and we don’t get all verkpempt about that.

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206 Bernard McGinn, *The Flowering of Mysticism: Men and Women in the New Mysticism, 1200-1350*, vol. 3, The Presence of God: A History of Western Christian Mysticism (New York: Crossroad, 1998), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Flowering+of+Mysticism+McGinn.

207 Maurice Walshe trans., *The Long Discourses of the Buddha: A Translation of the Dīgha Nikāya* (Boston: Wisdom Publications, 1995), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Long+Discourses+of+the+Buddha+Walshe.

208 John Knoblock, *Xunzi: A Translation and Study of the Complete Works*, vol. 3 (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1994), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Knoblock+Xunzi+Complete+Works.

209 Grace M. Jantzen, *Power, Gender, and Christian Mysticism* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1995), https://amzn.to/2U490E9.

210 Ibid.

So the experiential dimension is close to the core of religion, and I would even call it a marker of an **Authentic Religion**, which I define as a religion focused on needs satisfaction, particularly our human needs for alignment, and connection, [211] but it fails as a boundary marker in both directions: some religions manage it down, and some non-religions traffic in it freely. Not distinctive enough.

Candidate Three: The Ritual/Practical Dimension

Candidate three is ritual and practice. Every tradition on the list, from the loftiest Vedanta to the simplest gathering at a sacred spring, prescribes repeatable things to do, prayers, offerings, purifications, meditations, feasts, fasts. Robert Bellah's entire evolutionary account argues that ritual even precedes myth and doctrine historically: practice came before belief, and in many traditions it remains the core that doctrine merely ornaments. Primal religions are almost nothing but ritual. Confucianism is a ritual system with ethics attached. Even iconoclastic Protestantism, having stripped the images, promptly invented new rituals, the sermon, the altar call, Sunday service itself. Humans in groups do ritual. It may be the oldest thing we do.

But once again, religion is not the only institution that has these. Sports have rituals and practices, and lots of them. In addition, superstitious beliefs in unseen forces are rampant in sports and tied closely to those rituals and practices: lucky socks, pregame rituals, the curse of the Bambino. [references and examples here]

Science has its rituals and practices too, methodologies, methods, ceremonies like the Nobel Prize, the donning of the robe, the choreography of the conference keynote. If ritual is the marker, then science, sports, the military, and the Masons all sail through the gate. What distinguishes religious ritual from these? The presence of the sacred? That is the answer we are still building toward, but we are not quite there yet. Ritual is necessary but not distinctive. On to candidate four.

211 "Authentic Religion," *The SpiritWiki* (Avatar.GLOBAL, 2026), spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/Authentic_Religion.

Candidate Four: The Path

The final candidate is Smart's number six, the aspirational, ethical, and legal dimensions which, when combined, provide a "path" toward a specific goal. Aspirations set the destination. Ethics chart the route. Laws pave and police it. Does this thing alone constitute religion?

I would argue yes, but with one caveat. The aspiration needs to be sacred, and by that I simply mean "holy," or, in a more secular vein, something worthy of, and provided with, deep respect, even awe, by the vast majority of people. An institution that aims its people at something sacred, and lays out the prescriptions and proscriptions required to get there, is doing religion. An institution that merely has habits, hierarchies, and halftime shows is not.ww.facebook.com

Let's run the test cases.

Sports

Professional sports provide the first example, and a rich one. Superstitious beliefs in unseen forces are rampant, lucky socks, pregame rituals, the curse of the Bambino,[212] alongside symbols, philosophies, and dogmas. Sports have a social and institutional dimension complete with teams, leagues, and governing bodies that behave very much like churches. They have "consecrating" ritual and practice: the anthem, the coin toss, the seventh-inning stretch, the pregame meal eaten at exactly the same time.[213] They have an experiential dimension that even Durkheim would recognise, the collective effervescence of fifty thousand people moving as one body is his term.[214] They have narrative and myth: the comeback, the Cinderella run, the championship as redemption.[215] They have doctrine, the philosophy of how the game is "meant to be played."[216] They have an aspirational, ethical, and legal dimension in the rules of the game themselves, the only human institution whose moral code is enforced in real time by officials, plus codes of sportsmanship

212 Dan Shaughnessy, *The Curse of the Bambino* (New York: Dutton, 1990), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Curse+of+the+Bambino+Shaughnessy.

213 Michael Novak, *The Joy of Sports: End Zones, Bases, Baskets, Balls, and the Consecration of the American Spirit* (New York: Basic Books, 1976), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Joy+of+Sports+Novak.

214 Emile Durkheim, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (New York: Free Press, 1995), https://monoskop.org/images/a/a2/Durkheim_Emile_The_Elementary_Forms_of_Religious_life_1995.pdf.

215 Joseph L. Price, *From Season to Season: Sports as American Religion* (Macon, GA: Mercer University Press, 2001), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=From+Season+to+Season+Price+sports+American+religion.

216 Robert J. Higgs, *God in the Stadium: Sports and Religion in America* (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 1995), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=God+in+the+Stadium+Higgs.

and banned-substance commandments.[217] They have a material dimension: stadiums built like cathedrals, jerseys worn like relics, trophies kissed like icons. [218]They even have a therapeutic dimension: the injured athlete's rehab as a ritualised death-and-restoration, and the well-documented salve sport provides to communities in grief. And they have sacred and charismatic figures — Billie Jean King, Danica Patrick, Tom Brady, Wayne Gretzky, Babe Ruth — whom the American media machine happily turned into representatives of American exceptionalism and Christian myth.[219]

But do they have a sacred aspiration? No. Sports aspire to win, and winning, whatever else it is, is not sacred. It is not holy, it is not treated with awe by the vast majority of people, and nobody, not even the most devout season-ticket holder, thinks that winning is the sort of thing a human life should be organised around in the way a religion organises a life around the sacred. So sports is not a religion. Easy.

Musical Concerts

What about musical concerts? Are they religions? Maybe. Going to a concert to worship a particular band, say Black Sabbath or Taylor Swift, checks many of the boxes, and I do not use the word "worship" loosely. One scholar of music and religion has argued precisely this: that as traditional churches emptied out, young people did not stop worshipping; they relocated, setting up their own sanctuaries in clubs, at festivals, and inside music culture generally.[220] Run the checklist and see.

Social dimension? Fandoms are among the most cohesive identity communities available to young people today; the academic literature on the Swift fandom now reads like a field study of a devotional movement, complete with chants, symbolic attributes, sacred personages, and pilgrimage, like worship of the alters of Swifty and pilgrimage journeys to the Eras Tour. [221] Ritual and practical dimension? Same sources: friendship bracelets exchanged like communion tokens, the number thirteen painted on hands,

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217 World Anti-Doping Agency, *World Anti-Doping Code (2021)* (Montreal: World Anti-Doping Agency, January 1, 2021), https://www.wada-ama.org/sites/default/files/resources/files/2021_wada_code.pdf.

218 Higgs, *God in the Stadium: Sports and Religion in America*.

219 Michael Oriard, *King Football: Sport and Spectacle in the Golden Age of Radio and Newsreels, Movies and Magazines, the Weekly and the Daily Press* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2001), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=King+Football+Oriard.

220 Rupert Till, *Pop Cult: Religion and Popular Music* (New York: Continuum, 2010), https://www.bloomsbury.com/us/pop-cult-9781441197245/.

221 Ahdi Sakha Hamidan, "American Popular Music as Ritual: Exploring the Meaning of Religion in Interactions between Taylor Swift and Swifties," *International Journal of Humanities Education and Social Sciences* 5, no. 2 (2025), doi:10.55227/ijhess.v5i2.1815.

lyrics screamed in unison at appointed moments. Experiential dimension? Here the case is strongest, arguably stronger than in sport. In one recent series of studies, live music events emerged as among the most reliable elicitors of collective effervescence psychologists have measured, uniquely predicting feelings of meaning in life both during the event and a week after it ended.[222] And people do not merely feel effervescent at concerts. Decades of first-person accounts document intense, transcendent, occasionally mystical experiences of music, experiences of merging, floating, leaving one's body, and encounters with what experiencers can only call the sacred.[223] Attendees describe concerts, in so many words, as church. One journalist, *converted* mid-show while in a psychedelic like trance. A friend comment "Welcome to church" on her Instagram post from the floor.[224]

The other boxes fill in easily. Narrative and mythic dimension? Every fandom has its lore, the band's origin story, the Easter eggs in the liner notes, the exegesis of lyrics that fans treat less like poetry than like scripture. Doctrinal and philosophical dimension? The lyrics function as a codified worldview, and metal in particular developed something close to a counter-doctrine: Weinstein's classic analysis divides the genre into a Dionysian strand (ecstasy, sex, intoxication, transgression) and a chaotic strand (war, alienation, madness, evil), both of which function as explicit rejoinders to Christian moral teaching.[225] Material dimension? Merchandise, lightsticks, stadiums, the sequined silhouette on stage. Therapeutic dimension? Music-as-therapy is literally a chapter in the research literature, and the mosh pit has served as a pressure valve for adolescent frustration for half a century. Sports checks every box; concerts, remarkably, check most of them too.

But now we come to the decisive question, the same one that undid sport: do concerts have aspirational elements? Is Taylor Swift a feminine Jesus. Heavy metal uses Christian symbols and references, and is sharply critical of religion and its hypocrisies,[226] but there is little evidence it aspires

222 Nicole Koefler et al., "Let the Music Play: Live Music Fosters Collective Effervescence and Leads to Lasting Positive Outcomes," *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin* 52, no. 3 (2026): 546–58, doi:10.1177/01461672241288027.

223 Alf Gabrielsson, *Strong Experiences with Music: Music Is Much More Than Just Music* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Strong+Experiences+with+Music+Gabrielsson.

224 Hannah Summerhill, "The Summer I Turned Swiftie," *Vogue*, 2023, https://www.vogue.com/article/the-summer-i-turned-swiftie.

225 Deena Weinstein, *Heavy Metal: The Music and Its Culture*, Revised edition (New York: Da Capo Press, 2000), https://archive.org/details/heavymetalmusici0000wein.

226 Robert Walser, *Running with the Devil: Power, Gender, and Madness in Heavy Metal Music* (Middletown, CT: Wesleyan University Press, 1993), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Running+with+the+Devil+Walser.

anywhere. Transgression is not a destination. The mosh pit locates adolescents in a concert venue and gives them an outlet where they can bang their heads against their frustration. Catharsis, yes. Path, no.[227]

And Taylor Swift? She may come closest. Her fandom certainly behaves like a movement — the religious-studies literature has begun to take it seriously on exactly those grounds.[228] A call for papers was issued in 2025 for a collection entitled "Theology, Religion, and Taylor Swift" [229] examining. But examine the content. Taylor sings about relationships, love, loss, betrayal, recovery, and other aspects of the human condition, but that is mundane. It is neither aspirational nor sacred. It does not aim its people at anything holy. So, not a religion.

Hollywood

What about Hollywood? This one is a genuine gray area. Most of the time, film and television have no aspiration beyond entertainment and profit. But not always. Consider the *Star Wars* franchise, which definitely has sacred aspirational elements: Jedi knights, discipline, control of the Force, the seduction and redemption arc. And Lucas has admitted openly that he tried to incorporate religious beliefs into his *Star Wars* universe. He had religious intention. Asked in a Lucasfilm interview whether he consciously set out to "make this a force for the good," Lucas answered: "Yes."[230] On the Force itself, he was explicit:

> It is basically just like an amalgamation of all religions… ever since the very beginning it always comes down to this mysterious thing that we can't see that has some kind of power over us and/or we have power over it or that we go to it for help.[231]

Asked to confirm that he "wanted to bring spiritual traditions together in a positive force," Lucas said yes, and added the doctrine in his own words: "God is love, not God is hate." The people who make these

227 Weinstein, *Heavy Metal: The Music and Its Culture*.
228 Hamidan, "American Popular Music as Ritual: Exploring the Meaning of Religion in Interactions between Taylor Swift and Swifties."
229 MATTHEWBRAKE84, "Call for Papers: Theology, Religion, and Taylor Swift," *Pop Culture and Theology*, March 18, 2025, https://popularcultureandtheology.com/2025/03/18/call-for-papers-theology-religion-and-taylor-swift/.
230 "George Lucas," *The SpiritWiki*, 2025, https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/George_Lucas.
231 "George Lucas," *The SpiritWiki*, 2025, https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/George_Lucas.

films know exactly what they are building. When J.J. Abrams offered Daisy Ridley the role of Rey, he told her: "Understand the scale. This is not a role in a movie. This is a religion for people."[232]

Run the checklist. Social dimension? Check. *Star Wars* has one of the largest, most formally organised fandoms on earth, complete with hierarchies, titles, and gatherings that function like pilgrimages — the fandom-as-religion pattern that sociologists have documented in media fan communities for three decades now.

Ritual dimension? Check. Opening-night pilgrimages in costume, the rote recitation of lines, "May the Fourth" as a feast day, candlelight vigils for fallen characters.

Experiential dimension? Check. Ask anyone who sat in a dark theatre in 1977 when that Star Destroyer rumbled overhead. In fact, you can ask me. I'll tell you. I still remember it. I remember the line I was standing in. I remember somebody was trying to get into the theater free by crawling up in the vents. I remember watching the opening titles, destroyer's rumble, and the awesome feels that attended. The whole thing was an awe experience, full stop.

Narrative/mythic dimension? Check. That was the entire design. Joseph Campbell's monomythm the hero's journey, call to adventure, ordeal, apotheosis, return, is the franchise's skeleton.[233]

Lucas's own account matches Campbell's schema almost page for page. He even admits to intentional incorporation of mythic elements: "I really tried to take these psychological motifs from mythology all over the world… and bring them down and put them into a razzle-dazzle, Saturday matinee serial, action-adventure film."[234] Asked where *Star Wars* sits among the mythic traditions, Lucas did not hesitate: "Well, it's the hero's myth, really."[235]

Doctrinal dimension? Check The Jedi Code reads like catechism: "There is no emotion, there is peace. There is no ignorance, there is knowledge. There is no passion, there is serenity." And Lucas supplied the eschatology himself, glossing the Living Force as "basically… however you want to call it heaven or born

232 Isaac Feldberg, "Daisy Ridley Reveals the Terrifying Advice J.J. Abrams Gave Her for Star Wars," *Inverse*, 2024, https://www.inverse.com/entertainment/daisy-ridley-interview-star-wars-sometimes-i-think-about-dying.
233 Joseph Campbell, *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (Oxford: Princeton University Press, 2004); Joseph Campbell, *Myths to Live By* (New York: Bantam Books, 1972).
234 "George Lucas."
235 "George Lucas."

again" — a continuum in which "you join the Force when you die and you lose your personality but you become one with this bigger living entity."[236] That is an afterlife doctrine, stated plainly by the author.

Aspirational, ethical, and legal dimensions? Check The light side and the dark side are a complete moral map, with the Jedi as the ideal persons and the fallen Jedi as cautionary doctrine about improper alignment. Lucas again: "All of my movies are about one thing, which is the fact that the only prison you're in is the prison of your minds, and if you decide to open the door, get out, you can."[237] And, in a line that functions as prophecy: "I only hope that those who have seen *Star Wars* recognise the Emperor when they see him."[238]

Material dimension? Check. Including massive product lines. Lightsabers, helmets, robes, and a theme park that functions as a pilgrimage site.

Therapeutic dimension? Fans routinely describe the saga as something that got them through grief, illness, and depression, and the narrative itself is a redemption story. Even Vader is healed and restored at the end. And then there is the founder's own testimony. Lucas described receiving requests from hospitals where a child was dying and would not last the week:

> So we'd show him the movie and he would live for another six or nine months. And it wasn't once that this happened — it happened hundreds of times… whatever inspiration we give them allows them to take the struggle further.[239]

Remember the key thing about "the path" is that it is sacred. On the sacred aspiration criterion, *Star Wars* does not flirt with the line. It crosses it, and it crosses it inside the text itself, in statements the saga sets down without irony as its core teachings. The Jedi Code is written in the grammar of Zen scripture: "There is no emotion, there is peace. There is no ignorance, there is knowledge. There is no passion, there is serenity. There is no chaos, there is harmony. There is no death, there is the Force."[240] That is an apophatic catechism, every line names a profane state to be overcome and a sacred state to be attained, and the final line states the soteriology outright: there is no death, there is the Force. The path in what we might call

236 "George Lucas."
237 "George Lucas."
238 "George Lucas."
239 "George Lucas."
240 Jedi Code, as stated in *Star Wars: Episode I — The Phantom Menace* (1999) and elaborated throughout the saga's canonical materials.

Yoda's Doctrine of Improper Alignment, which reads like a verse from the Dhammapada: "Fear is the path to the dark side. Fear leads to anger. Anger leads to hate. Hate leads to suffering."[241] The aspirational object? The thing worthy of awe that the faithful orient their lives toward? That is stated plainly by Obi-Wan Kenobi: "The Force is what gives a Jedi his power. It's an energy field created by all living things. It surrounds us and penetrates us. It binds the galaxy together."[242] And the eschatology is not left implied. Yoda delivers it as comfort and as doctrine: "Death is a natural part of life. Rejoice for those around you who transform into the Force."[243] These are not incidental lines of dialogue. They are teachings — a path, an ideal person, a sacred object, a doctrine of death — whispered, passed from master to apprentice, invoked at moments of crisis. They are treated by the text with reverence, and the founder confirms the intent behind them: "God is love, not God is hate." The Jedi themselves are defenders of these aspirations,. They are there to save the universe from the dark side. That is a sacred goal.

Some may argue that *Star Wars* is not a religion, but I don't think that position is defensible. It is a religion. I would call it a religion. In fact, I have, in an article entitled "Star Wars Is a Religion That Primes Us All for War."[244]

Is that a bad thing? I don't know. I had my second religious experience in the *Star Wars* theatre. It didn't harm me. If anything, it set my on a path of good path. I never aspired to be a Jedi warrior, but I did aspire to be a good person, based on those early experiences in the theatre.

Science

Which brings us to the hard case. What about science? Does the path criterion allow us to eliminate science as a religion?

Science definitely checks all the boxes. It has a social and institutional dimension complete with charismatic and sacred personages like Darwin and Galileo. Try publishing a paper that contradicts either

241 Jedi Code, as stated in *Star Wars: Episode I — The Phantom Menace* (1999) and elaborated throughout the saga's canonical materials.

242 Obi-Wan Kenobi, *Star Wars: Episode IV — A New Hope* (1977).

243 oda, *Star Wars: Episode III — Revenge of the Sith* (2005). Compare Lucas's gloss in the transcript: "you join the Force when you die and you lose your personality but you become one with this bigger living entity" (SpiritWiki, above).

244 Mike Sosteric, "Star Wars Is a Religion That Primes Us for War and Violence," *The Conversation*, January 4, 2018, https://theconversation.com/star-wars-is-a-religion-that-primes-us-for-war-and-violence-89443.

in the wrong department and see how far you get.[245] It has a ritual and practical dimension, found in its graduation and award ceremonies, the donning of the robe, the conferral of degrees, the choreography of the peer-reviewed publication itself. It has a narrative dimension that situates the whole enterprise in a Wiggish Enlightenment story, science as linear advancement over previous ontological and epistemic systems, a salvation history with a before (darkness, superstition) and an after (light, progress) that maps almost perfectly onto Comte's three stages.[246] And here the social studies of science let us be more precise than we could be on our own, because this narrative is not merely a story science tells; it is a story science *enforces*. Kuhn showed that "normal science" is not open-ended inquiry but "a strenuous and devoted attempt to force nature into the conceptual boxes supplied by professional education" and that novelties are suppressed precisely because they are "subversive of its basic commitments."[247] The Edinburgh school went further: if Bloor's Strong Programme is right, scientific knowledge is as sociologically explicable as any other belief systems, facts are made in laboratories, not found in nature.[248] The conformity mechanisms are well documented: peer review is not a neutral filter but a gatekeeping institution that allocates credibility, career, and money, with real sanctions — rejection, retraction, defunding, and in extreme cases criminal prosecution for fraud.[249] A code of conduct, enforced by an authorised priesthood, backed by sanctions, and insulated from subversive reinterpretation is dogma.

Science also has a philosophical dimension, expressed in codified cosmological, philosophical, and intellectual statements by scientific intelligentsia. It has ethical and legal dimensions and value orientations towards truth. It has a material dimension found in university buildings, laboratories, and the humble overhead projector. It even has an experiential dimension, found in the mystical musings of physicists. Heisenberg, Schrödinger, Eddington, and Jeans wrote contemplative reflections that read like apophatic theology, and they have been collected for exactly that reason[250] — in the awestruck wonder of Einstein, and in the fact that scientists sometimes make their discoveries through intuitive

245 On the sacred-personage effect and the cost of contradicting a paradigm, see Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*.
246 Comte, *A General View of Positivism*.
247 Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, 5.
248 David Bloor, *Knowledge and Social Imagery* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1976), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Knowledge+and+Social+Imagery+Bloor.
249 Daryl E. Chubin and Edward J. Hackett, *Peerless Science: Peer Review and U.S. Science Policy* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1990), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Peerless+Science+Chubin+Hackett.
250 Wilber, *Quantum Questions: Mystical Writings of the World's Great Physicists*.

"enlightenment" experiences: Kekulé's dream of the benzene ring, a serpent seizing its own tail,[251] Darwin's innumerable illuminations — "I can remember the very spot in the road, whilst in my carriage, when to my joy the solution occurred to me."[252] I myself have documented my own visionary mystical experiences.[253] It is a lot more common than you might think.

And the aspiration? Science definitely has that, and a sacred one, the highest one we have, in my opinion. Science aspires to the truth. The entire edificem theories, methodology, methods, peer review, is arranged to aim people at the truth. Scientists say so themselves, repeatedly, in the grammar of devotion. Einstein: "I want to know how God created this world. I am not interested in this or that phenomenon, in the spectrum of this or that element. I want to know His thoughts; the rest are details."[254] Hawking ends his bestselling cosmology with the aspiration that one day "we would know the mind of God."[255] Sagan: "We are a way for the cosmos to know itself."[256] Feynman's one commandment is an ethical rule aimed at exactly one thing: "The first principle is that you must not fool yourself — and you are the easiest person to fool."[257] And Einstein again, in the essay where he calls science and religion lame and blind without each other: "The most beautiful experience we can have is the mysterious. It is the fundamental emotion that stands at the cradle of true art and true science."[258] The experiential, the awe, the aspiration — the founder figures state them openly, the way Lucas stated his.

I think the vast majority of people, from every culture, gender, and political background, would agree that truth is sacred. Truth is something holy, something worthy of deep respect, something we should all aspire to and organise ourselves around. If a tradition aims its people at truth, disciplines them for truth, sanctions those who betray truth, and treats the pursuit of truth as the highest activity a human being can

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251 Arthur Koestler, *The Sleepwalkers: A History of Man's Changing Vision of the Universe* (London: Hutchinson, 1959), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Sleepwalkers+Koestler.

252 Charles Darwin, *The Autobiography of Charles Darwin 1809-1882* (London: Collins, 1958), https://darwin-online.org.uk/EditorialIntroductions/Freeman_Autobiography.html.

253 Mike Sosteric, "Connection 100 – An Auto-Ethnography of My (Mystical) Connection Experiences," *Religions* 13, no. 10 (2022), doi:https://doi.org/10.3390/rel13100993.

254 Esther Salaman, "A Talk with Einstein," *The Listener* 54 (1955): 370–71.

255 Stephen Hawking, *A Brief History of Time: From the Big Bang to Black Holes* (New York: Bantam, 1988), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Brief+History+of+Time+Hawking.

256 Carl Sagan, *Cosmos* (New York: Random House, 1980), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Cosmos+Sagan.

257 Richard P. Feynman, "Cargo Cult Science (California Institute of Technology Commencement Address)," *Engineering and Science (Caltech), Vol. 37, No. 7*, 1974, https://calteches.library.caltech.edu/51/.

258 Albert Einstein, *Ideas and Opinions* (New York: Crown, 1954), https://search.worldcat.org/search?q=Ideas+and+Opinions+Einstein.

undertake, then on the path criterion, a goal, a prescribed way, and something at the end worthy of awe, science is a religion.

Certainly, a strong case can certainly be made. Unlike *Star Wars* I'm going to reserve judgment on that until we look at functional definitions of religion in the next chapter.

Conclusion

So where does this leave us? The seven-plus-one does help clear things up quite a bit. It lets us reject certain things with confidence, rock concerts, sports franchises, because they lack a sacred aspiration. Hollywood or science, but it brings them into much clearer focus, which, regardless of where they eventually land, helps us sort the question honestly instead of resorting to the boundary fetish.

Based on the 7+1 substantive elements and our analysis thus far, I am prepared to add my own definition of religion to the already overcrowded pot.

Religion is an institution that provides an aspirational Path, along with the associated prescriptions and proscriptions required to get there.

Everything else, the social aspects, the dogma, the ritual, the material elements, etc., are all built up from this central, authentic core.

Finally, to restate the obvious, this definition makes science a religion, an institution aimed at a sacred aspiration (truth), complete with the rituals, hierarchies, narratives, and codes that get you there. That might make some people uncomfortable. But oh well. The definition says what the evidence says, and the evidence says that humans build religions whenever they decide something is sacred enough to organise a life around. The more interesting question is not whether science is a religion at this point, it probably is, but whether it is a good one. We'll get a chance to answer that last question in the remainder of this book.

4. Defining Religion - Functional Definitions

"We all know that our science, as is the case with every science treating the institutions and events of human culture ... first arose in connection with *practical considerations*.... All serious reflection about the ulbmate elements of meaningful human conduct is oriented primarily in tenns of the categories "end" and "means." We desire something concrete either "for its own sake" or as a means of achieving something else which is more highly desired."[259]

"Thus, Weber emphasized two goals of religious action, what I call the "transformative" and the "thaumaturgical." The transformative refers to a pervasive or radical change in nature, society, and the individual. The thaumaturgical refers to special dispensation and release from personal, familial, or other specific ills."[260]

"All world religions have been said to have transcendental aims or soteriologies, and it is this dimension, rather than conceptions of transcendental beings or divine sphere, that may be considered as common, if notrestricted, to the world religions"[261]

Defining religion using Smart's substantive approach does seem like a way forward. Applying it allows us to adequately categorize several problematic institutions, thereby reducing both fuzz and bewilderment. The only problem at this point is that definition does not exclude science. Science checks all the boxes.

The framework of religious action employed here is extended to include two additional goals, which I call the "nomic" and the "extrinsic." **The nomic**, a category drawn from Durkheimian analysis, refers to the maintenance of the existing order and religious foundations of nature, society, and individual being. The extrinsic, a notion drawn from utilitarian as well as Marxist analysis, refers to religious action that is performed for ends conceived by the actors to be mundane in nature, such as individual status and the strengthening of a status quo. Thus, Weber's typology of ideal types of religious action is extended by "Weberizing" the Durkheimian and Marxist traditions."[262]

Smart's Substantive Elements — Science Edition

- [x] **Social/Institutional** — Universities, departments, labs, professional societies, journals, tenure hierarchies, in-groups and out-groups. Complete with charismatic and sacred personages (Darwin, Galileo, Hawkings).

259 Max Weber, *The Methodology of the Social Sciences*, ed. Edward A. Shils and Henry A. Finch (Glencoe, Illinois: The Free Press, 1949), 51–52.
260 Sharot, *A Comparative Sociology of World Religions*, 4.
261 Ibid., 8.Sharot, *A Comparative Sociology of World Religions*, 4.
262 Ibid., 4.

- [x] **Ritual/Practical** — Repeatable, prescribed procedures: methodologies, protocols, controlled experiments done "the right way." Plus ceremonies: graduations, the donning of the robe, degree conferral, the Nobel banquet.
- [x] **Experiential** — Einstein's awe before "the old one," the cosmic-religious feeling, Kekulé's benzene-ring dream, Darwin's "little illuminations." Discovery arrives as mystical insight as often as as grinding calculation. The many mystical musings of quantum physicists.
- [x] **Narrative/Mythic** — A salvation history: darkness and superstition before, light and progress after. Maps almost perfectly onto Comte's three stages, minus the candour. Hero tales included (Newton's apple, Galileo before the Inquisition).
- [x] **Doctrinal/Philosophical** — Codified commitments from the scientific intelligentsia: methodological naturalism, physicalism, the canon enshrined in textbooks that function like scripture.
- [x] **Aspirational/Ethical/Legal** — The path to truth. Truth as aspiration. Peer review as a code of conduct with real sanctions, research ethics, fraud commandments. .
- [x] **Material** — University buildings, laboratories, the white coat as vestment, the overhead projector, lectern, semi-circular lecture theatres as liturgical furnishing.
- [x] **Therapeutic/Healing** — The easiest box of all. Medicine, vaccination, public health — science's entire applied wing is oriented toward healing bodies and minds.

You have to admit this poses a bit of a problem for people needing to draw a boundary. Still, there may be hope. Recall that modern scholars provide two types of definitions, substantive and functional. Substantive definitions of religion define religion by its various elements. Functional definitions of religion define religion by what it does, like providing social solidarity or meeting certain needs. Does science function in a way different than religion? Can we find the key critical boundary component in functional definitions?

Maybe. Let's ask the question, "What are the functions performed by religion?"

Malinowski suggested magic and religion have practical, cathartic, psychological, emotional, and social functions. One of magic's functions was to help its practitioners achieve ends or *meet needs*. If people needed food, magical rituals could help them gain a successful catch on the open ocean. Religion

itself could also meet certain emotional needs and mental needs,[263] by helping people deal with the "stresses and strains of life, and the necessity of facing heavy odds"[264] by providing solace against the "centrifugal forces of fear, dismay, demoralization" caused by death,[265] or by providing for security, safety, and the necessary "practical co-operation" of a cohesive group.[266]

Psychologist Sigmund Freud weighed in on the functional characteristics of religion, associating religion with psychological needs and processes. For Freud, religion was all about wish fulfillment, the need for meaning, and infantile regression. Linking his conceptualization of religion to Tylor,[267] Freud provided a substantive demarcation by suggesting the primary substantive characteristic of all religions is the "doctrine of souls" or the "doctrine of spiritual beings."[268] Noting the irrationality of these beliefs, Freud goes on to suggest that humans believe in souls and spiritual beings for emotional reasons, because these beliefs help resolve the "problem of death,"[269] because they help humans alleviate the anxieties, uncertainties, and vagaries of their existence,[270] and because spiritual beliefs help them deal with the pains and injustices of human society. According to Freud, "it can clearly be seen that the possession of these ideas protects him in two directions-against the dangers of nature and Fate, and against the injuries that threaten him from human society itself."[271]

There is nothing particularly horrible about the functional definitions provided by Malinowski or Freud. Indigenous spirituality like modern religion, likely does have these functions and magic and religion likely do fulfill emotional, psychological needs, and practical needs. The problem comes when we cast these functions in a evolutionary light. Freud cast human society as passing from an inferior, immature, narcissistic animistic religious stages, where the function of religion is primitive and narcissistic, through a more adolescent religious stage (Western Patriarchies), finally ending in a mature scientific stage, where religion is replaced by science, which is of course, not a religion, despite being in that line.[272]

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263 Malinowski, *Magic, Science, and Religion and Other Essays*, 5.
264 Bronislaw Malinowski, *The Foundations of Faith and Morals* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1936), 59–60.
265 Malinowski, *Magic, Science, and Religion and Other Essays*, 35.
266 Ibid., 5.
267 Tylor, *Primitive Culture*.
268 Sigmund Freud, *Totem and Taboo* (New York: Routledge, 1913), 88.
269 Ibid., 89.
270 Freud, *The Future of an Illusion*.
271 Ibid., 18.
272 Or it is?

We see the assertion of ethnocentric boundaries clearly when Freud compares Indigenous populations to narcissistic children who are stuck believing in the "power of wishes," who mistakenly give causal primacy to thought over material reality,[273] whose thought is "still to a great extent sexualized,"[274] and who then appear to suffer from a primitive over-reliance on associations,[275] and whose actions he likens to something akin to "children's play. [276] Medieval Christians were better off. They were like small children in need of parental attention. For Freud, the modern, atheist, European middle classes were the mature group of the bunch.

> The animistic phase would correspond to narcissism both chronologically and in its content; the religious phase would correspond to the stage of object-choice of which the characteristic is a child's attachment to his parents; while the scientific phase would have an exact counterpart in the stage at which an individual has reached maturity, has renounced the pleasure principle, adjusted himself to reality and turned to the external world for the object of his desires.[277]

When exposed to the light of day, it is easy to reject Freud's theoretical musings as a by-now dated outgrowth of Eurocentric racism; however, his views and the boundaries he provided continue to be influential, though in slightly toned-down form. Spiro, for example, argued that childhood experiences and their navigation of the psychosexual stages disposed them to certain beliefs, like the belief in powerful benevolent or malevolent beings. Spiro thought that the roots of "compulsive ritual" were to be found in the degree to which the "oral drive" had been satisfied. The ethnocentric boundaries also appear in his stipulation that the source of religion is "infantile and primitive fears"[278] which overwhelm children and drive Indigenous religions, particularly when no better alternatives, like science and technology, exist.[279] As Spiro notes, "...if substantive desires are satisfied by technology; or if expressive desires are

273 Freud, *Totem and Taboo*, 99.
274 Ibid., 105.
275 Ibid., 96.
276 Ibid., 1913.
277 Ibid., 104.
278 Spiro, "Religion: Problems of Definition and Explanation," 115.
279 Melford E. Spiro and Roy G. D'Andrade, "A Cross-Cultural Study of Some Supernatural Beliefs," *American Anthropologist* 60, no. 3 (June 1, 1958): 456.

satisfied by politics or art or magic, religion should, by that extent, be less important for their satisfaction."[280]

Religion does function to meet needs, that is for certain, but not just cognitive or emotional needs for security, as suggested by Freud. Religion services existential needs as well. Yinger suggests 'religion is a system of beliefs and practices by means of which a group of people struggles with the ultimate problems of human life. It expresses their refusal to capitulate to death, to give up in the face of frustration, to allow hostility to tear apart their human associations...Thus religions are built to carry the 'peak load' of human emotional *need*.'[281] In other words, religions function to meet emotional needs. Wallace says the same thing. He argues supernatural beliefs in God persist because they are an "important part of one or more processes by which major human wants are gratified."[282] Religion is an institution which functions to meet wants and needs including, according to Durkheim, our social needs. "A religion is a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things ...[which unites people *into one single moral community called a Church*." Religion has a social function. It acts as a social and moral glue.

Functional definitions are typically not too popular amongst scholars. Why? Because they are even worse than substantive definitions at facilitating clear boundaries. As Scharf [283] notes, they are simply too broad and inclusive. "If religion is defined as that which promotes unity or social cohesion, then anything which does this is religion,"[284] That's a good point. If you are not careful, everything from communism through fascism through nationalism, capitalism, sports, and rock concerts become religious events. Because functional definitions do not provide for strong boundaries, Hamilton suggests we avoid functional definitions altogether.[285] This rejection seems unwise, however. Religion, like all human institutions, is functional. It wasn't built up by random. It is there for a reason; otherwise, it would not exist. If we ignore the functions of religion, the reasons for its existence, why bother studying it at all. And besides, the boundary problem is only a problem for some people. Personally, I don't feel we need to draw big boundaries around these institutions. All human institutions are the same, really. All human

280 Spiro, "Religion: Problems of Definition and Explanation," 116.
281 J. Milton Yinger, *The Scientific Study of Religion* (London: Macmillan Company, 1970), 7, https://archive.org/details/scientificstudyo1970ying.
282 Wallace, *Religion: An Anthropological View*, vi.
283 *The Sociological Study of Religion* (London: Hutchinson, 1970).
284 Hamilton, *The Sociology of Religion: Theoretical and Comparative Perspectives*, 19.
285 *The Sociology of Religion: Theoretical and Comparative Perspectives*.

institutions are created by people, including religion,[286] and they all perform the same function, which is that they meet human needs. As Spiro states, institutions are *always* set up to meet some kind of human need: "...all institutions ... are instrumental means for the satisfaction of needs."[287]

Banks? They meet the financial needs of people.

Schools? They meet society's need for an educated population, and our personal needs for truth and understanding. They also also meet social needs and the needs of the accumulating class for a complaint and disciplined workforce.

Families? They meet a wide variety of needs, physical, social, emotional, and (ideally) safety, to name a few.

Religions? They meet a variety of needs as well, for individuals, society, and the accumulating glass. The same with science. It meets a whole host of human needs.

Retail institutions meet the retail needs of producers.

Agricultural institutions meet agricultural needs of farmers, and so on and so forth.

I suppose the question now becomes, "What needs do various human institutions meet?"

The Circle of Seven Essential Needs

To answer that question, we need to first know what sorts of needs humans have. To do that, we turn to the *Circle of Seven Essential Needs*.[288] This circle, which is inspired by the work of Abraham Maslow as well as the philosophical and spiritual beliefs of Indigenous peoples,[289] proposes that humans have seven essential needs categories, within which there are a set of essential needs. In this scheme there is an an outer layer of basic needs categories, and two inner needs categories. These outer needs needs include

286 Abby Day, *Sociology of Religion: Overview and Analysis of Contemporary Religion* (New York: Routledge, 2020), 3.
287 "Religion: Problems of Definition and Explanation," 96.
288 Mike Sosteric and Gina Ratkovic, "It Takes a Village: Advancing Attachment Theoryand Recovering the Roots of Human Health with the Seven Essential Needs," Aotearoa New Zealand Social Work, 2022, https://www.academia.edu/61410417/.
289 Ibid.

Physiological Needs, which are your physiological needs for food, water, air, clothing, exercise, and sleep..

Emotional Needs, which are your needs for unconditional support, acceptance, and inclusion. We all have a need to feel we are wanted and connected to something. We all need to feel that we belong.

Cognitive Needs, which are our needs to know and understand the world, the need to be in touch with reality. These cognitive needs were identified by Abraham Maslow in his 1943 article on the "hierarchy" of human needs.[290] In that article, Maslow defined our cognitive needs as comprising two sub-needs, the need to know and the need to understand. Maslow defined the *need to know* as the need to "be aware of reality, to get the facts, to satisfy curiosity…to see rather than to be blind."[291] Maslow defined the *need to understand* as the need to understand the reality that we came to know. According to Maslow, it was not enough just to know things, to accumulate mere facts. As he said, "…the facts that we acquire, if they are isolated or atomistic, *inevitably* get theorized about, and either analyzed or organized or both."[292] As he said, "even after we know, we are impelled to know more and more minutely and microscopically on the one hand, and on the other, more and more extensively in the direction of a world philosophy, religion, etc."[293] Maslow felt the need to know and understand were driving needs, and that thwarting them was the foundation of mental illness!

Psychological Needs, which are your needs to feel good about yourself, to feel *powerful* and efficacious, to have high self-esteem, to have faith in yourself, to have power over the world—to successfully manifest your will in creation—to create the world you want to create. want.

Environmental Needs, which are our needs for safe, secure, serene, nurturing, and aesthetically pleasing environments. Environmental needs also include the need for safe environments, safe spaces, and stable and secure finances. Safety includes the absence of assault of any kind, including physical assault (e.g., spanking), emotional assault, and psychological assault. Stability includes the emotional consistency

290 Abraham H. Maslow, "Preface to Motivation Theory.," *Psychosomatic Medicine* 5, no. 1 (1943): 85–92, doi:10.1097/00006842-194301000-00012.
291 Abraham H. Maslow, "A Theory of Human Motivation," *Psychological Review* 50, no. 4 (1943): 385, doi:10.1037/h0054346.
292 Maslow, "A Theory of Human Motivation."
293 Ibid., 385.

of stable parental/guardian relationships as well as financial stability. Financial stability includes resources sufficient to remove the anxieties and uncertainties of survival.

In addition to the five outer needs, we also have two sets of inner needs.

First we have the inner need for alignment,. include

Alignment needs are the extent to which all aspects of our life are aligned with your true nature and purpose—being "real," as psychologist Carl Rogers says, referencing the 1960s popular dialect. Distancing himself from the hippie word, he calls this **Congruence**. By this he means being "integrated or whole, I am completely in one piece."

Alignment needs include a need for *inner alignment* and a need for *outer alignment*.

Inner alignment is our need for alignment with our inner self or being, self-actualization in Maslow's terms.[294] Alignment with our inner self means we are in-sync with our inner self, our "essential biologically based inner nature...."[295] It is "...the desire for self-fulfillment, namely, to the tendency for him [sic] to become actualized in what he is potentially. This tendency might be phrased as the desire to become more and more what one is, to become everything that one is capable of becoming."[296] Self-actualization means actualizing your talents and inner being. If we have a talent and desire to be a musician, then we practice and play. If we have a drive to be a healer of some sort, then we honour that and work towards manifesting this desire. If we are drawn to STEM sciences, or a particular gender, then align with these inner drives.

> *Outer alignment* is our need for ethical, behavioural, conceptual alignment with groups (outside our self), like our family, community, work, and national organisations. To be aligned with a group means you adopt the norms, values, folkways, and worldviews of this

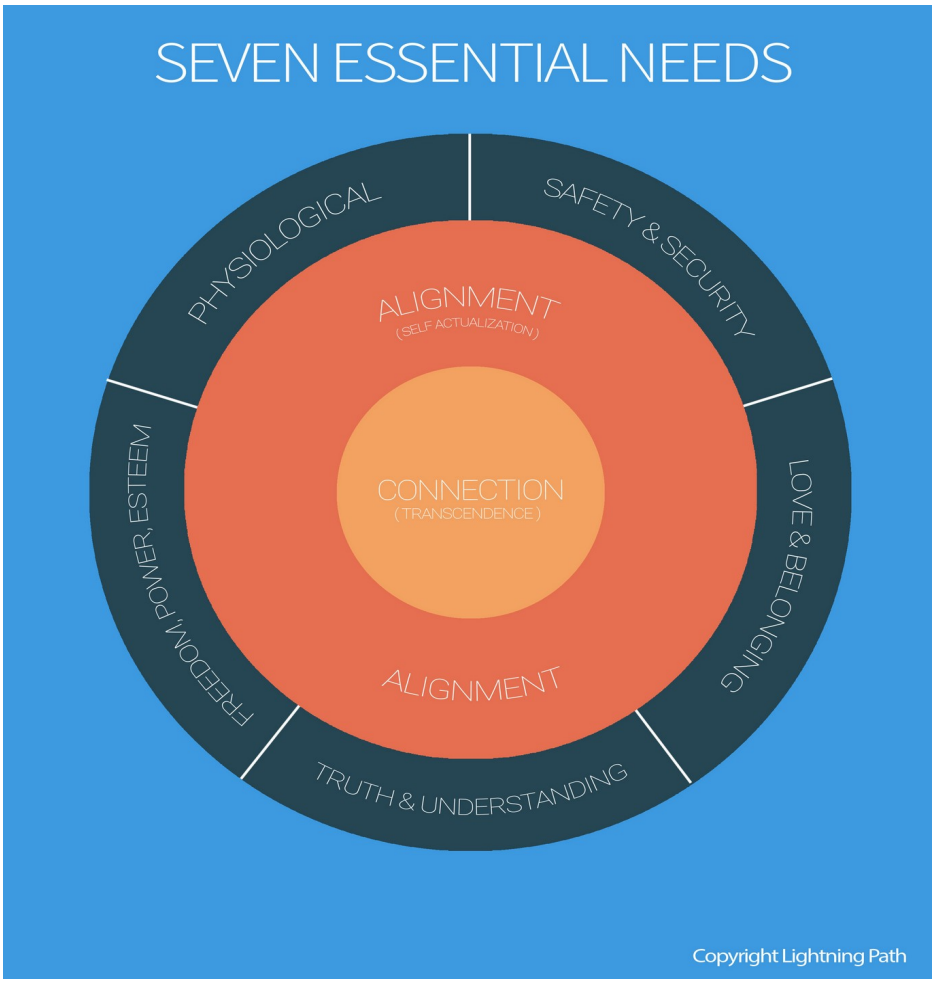
294 Abraham. H. Maslow, *Towards a Psychology of Being (2nd Edition)* (New York: Van Nostrand Reinhold Company, 1968).
295 Ibid., 3.
296 Maslow, "A Theory of Human Motivation," 382.

group. You can be aligned with the worldviews and traditions of your family. Outer alignment can also mean alignment with our traditions and our ancestors, the natural world, and our land base.

1. **Connection Needs**. Alignment is a functional need of humans not only because alignment facilitates biological survival (humans need groups to survive) but also because alignment facilitates outer and inner connection. **Outer connection** is connection with family, friends, community, our nation, and so on. There is an obvious survival advantage to connection even in modern societies. As the adage says, "It is not what you know, it is who you know." Connections with family and groups facilitate survival in modern life. Being aligned with your community obviously facilitates this connection. It is easier to be included in and connected with groups when you align yourself with that group.

Outer connection is only one-half of the need for connection. Inner connection is a need for connection to our inner Self, our Higher Self, our ancestors, and the Divine inside us. Inner connection translates into Ninian Smart's experiential category and is to be understood as mystical, shamanic experience, transcendent, or peak and nature experiences. These mystical or transcendent experiences of connection, which are something accepted as simple fact in Indigenous spiritual systems,[297] include experiences of connection to God, to nature, to our inner selves, to the spirits, to the ancestors, and even the entire cosmos. Evelyn Underhill points directly to this need when she says that we have an "innate tendency…towards complete harmony with the transcendental order, whatever the theological formula under which that order is understood."[298] As we shall see below, inner connection is a common desideratum and goal of spiritual systems most of which provide guidance and instruction intended on helping individuals to achieve inner and outer connection.

297 Lucana and Elfers, "Sacred Medicine: Indigenous Healing and Mental Health."
298 Evelyn Underhill, *Mysticism: A Study in the Nature and Development of Spiritual Consciousness*, Kindle (New York: Dover Publications, 2002).



So which of these essential needs does religion meet? Potentially all of them. Take the cognitive needs to know and understand. Religion is definitely an institution that meets the human need to know and understand. Several sociologists have taken this view directly. August Comte, as we saw earlier, believed that religion was a human attempt to understand the nature of reality that went through three stages, a theological, metaphysical, and positive. Clifford Geertz [299] provided a more general view when he noted that religion provides sacred symbols and ethos that *function* to "synthesize a people's ethos—the tone, character, and quality of their life...and their world-view..." and their "moods and motivations." Spiro says that religious systems help humanity meet the need to know and

299 "Religion as a Cultural System," 3.

understand by providing meaning and explanation.[300] Similarly, Sociologist Peter Berger pointed out the existence of **existential imperatives**[301] or what we might like to call "Big Questions," which religion is set to answer. Big questions are the ultimate questions of existence and cosmology. Berger said these imperatives include questions like "who am I?" and "Why am I here" and "What happens when I die?" We can include other questions here as well, like "Is there a God?" or "How was the universe formed?" Any of the "big" questions of life can be included here.

That religion meets our need to know and understand seems obvious. Whether the religion is Buddhism, Mormonism, or Catholicism, religious institutions do provide answers to life's big questions. Consider Catholicism. I was raised Catholic and though I left the religion as an adolescent, I know the Catholic answers to life's big questions.

Is there a God?

Yes, there is God.

Who am I?

You are a child of God

Where did I come from?

God created you.

What's the purpose of life?

To serve God, avoid sin, and redeem yourself.

How was the universe formed?

God said, let there be light, and the universe emerged in a puff of light.

If you were raised Christian, Buddhist, Muslim, Wiccan, Pagan, or whatever, you will know your religion's answers to the big questions above. All religions everywhere no matter how big or small, mainstream or emergent, provide answers to life's big questions, thereby satisfying our cognitive need to know and understand. *We might even say that a particular focus, and essential feature, of religion is the*

300 Spiro, "Religion: Problems of Definition and Explanation."
301 Berger, *The Sacred Canopy: Elements of a Sociological Theory of Religion*.

provision of answers to our big questions. A religion is an institution that provides answers to your big questions.

This seems sensible and logical, and there is a certain biographical truth to it. Unless you were born into a religion and are subsequently forced to stay there, most people choose their religion based on its ability to answer these big questions in what they feel is a satisfactory manner. If you are an adult member of a church, you are likely there because you believe and are satisfied with the answers your religion provides to your big questions. If at any time you become dissatisfied with the answers your religion provides, you may either go off on some kind of vision quest to try to figure out some things yourself, or you may find a new religion whose answers are more to your liking. People pass in and out of religions and institutions searching for answers that satisfy them. If they don't find answers that satisfy, they move on. You read this a lot in the literature on emergent religions and cults. Pagans, for example, are often "refugees" from traditional Western religions. Pagans become pagans, Wiccans become Wiccans, and so on because they were not satisfied with their traditional religious institutions, and went on a search to find something more real and authentic.[302] This is exactly why some guy by the name of "Joel" chose to become a member of the Church of Satan. Joel chose Satanism as his religion not because of some dark, ancient, cosmic, evil, but because, "having found more questions than answers in the more traditional religious values his family subscribed to," he felt that Satanism was a "better fit."[303]

We look for our answers to big questions and we fish around until we find something that is comfortable and "fits," that satisfies our cognitive needs for truth and understanding and answers our big existential questions. When we find something that satisfies our cognitive needs, we stop and settle in. We stay either until we die or until something happens that unsettles us and provokes us to renew the search for existential peace.

Religion is clearly an institution set up to meet our cognitive need to know and understand the world, but what about our other needs? Religion can meet these as well. Consider our environmental needs for safe, secure, nurturing, and aesthetically pleasing environments. Does religion meet these needs? Yes, and

302 Starhawk, *Spiral Dance, The - 20th Anniversary: A Rebirth of the Ancient Religion of the Goddess: 20th Anniversary Edition: Starhawk*.

303 Oliver Pelling, "The Joy of Excess: Why a New Generation Is Turning to Satanism," *Huck Magazine*, June 24, 2019, https://www.huckmag.com/art-and-culture/new-generation-church-of-satan/.

in a couple of ways. As Frazer notes,[304] and as we saw earlier, early humanity used magic and ritual, coupled with beliefs in life forces, to control the environment so that they could obtain better harvests, or safety from the elements. Spiro noted that the Hopi rain ceremonies, and similar spiritual rituals, are designed to get control over reality.[305] Sigmund Freud in his book *Future of an Illusion* suggested religion was about humanity confronting powerful natural forces (tornadoes, winters, floods) and instinctual forces over which had no control. Religion thus provides a sense of security and protection.[306] The same use of religion to control the environment is present in modern Western Monotheisms which advocate supplication and prayers to influence God's actions in the world. Religion can also meet our need for safe, secure, and nurturing environments by providing ethical guidance (and even legal restrictions) on how we should treat each other. The "Golden Rule" (do unto others), stipulations about karma (if you treat others badly, you will be punished), "Love thy neighbour," Sharia law, and all that jazz encourages humans, not always successfully of course, to create safe environments.

So, religion can meet cognitive and safety needs. What about our other needs, like our emotional needs for acceptance, inclusion, and belongingness, or our psychological need to feel good about ourselves. Religion, like other institutions, can provide for these needs as well. As we have already seen, sociologist Emile Durkheim's saw religion as just this. According to Durkheim, religion was an "eminently social thing" that provided emotional and psychological supports for individuals and that met our need for belonging, safety, and security.[307]

Religion also provides for our alignment needs, our need to be in alignment with our inner selves and inner divinity, and our outer groups. Durkheim pointed out that religion provided a "moral community" that provided guidance and direction and that facilitated solidarity (alignment and connection) with groups.[308] Sociologist Joachim Wach points outs that religions of all stripes, ancient and modern, East, Middle, and West, generally have an idea of a cosmic order which usually includes a normative element towards which humans are expected to aspire and through which one realizes alignment and connection with the divine order.

304 Frazer, *The Golden Bough: A Study in Magic and Religion*.
305 Spiro, "Religion: Problems of Definition and Explanation."
306 Freud, *The Future of an Illusion*.
307 Durkheim, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*, 1995, 9.
308 Ibid., 42.

> Rules of conduct and morals, though they may appear incoherent to the systematic modern mind, are the expressions of an urge to "realize" the divine order, to adapt reality to it, and thereby to secure the functioning of an order upon which depends the existence and well-being of mankind or of a particular group of men.[309]

Speaking of inner and outer alignment, almost all religions have what we might call **alignment rule sets** which are rules which purport to guide you on how to behave and act in an aligned fashion towards others, and towards your own inner realities. In Judaism and Christianity, we have the various "commandments;" in Buddhism, we have the Noble Eight Fold Path; in Islam the Qur'an provides alignment rules in general ethical statements like "Worship none but Allah, treat with kindness your parents and kindred, and orphans and those in need; speak fair to the people; be steadfast in prayer; and practise regular charity." (Qur,an 2: 83-84). There is also Sharia law which is the Islamic code of ethics and behaviour. Sufism, the "mystical" branch of Islam, refers to alignment (and how alignment facilitates connection to the Divine) in the context of an individual becoming a reflection of the qualities of God. As one commentator notes of Sufism, "...when a human becomes a perfect slave of God, then God becomes the eye and ear of that person, who becomes all light and a perfect reflection of God's qualities."[310] Psychologist William James pointed out the entire purpose of religion was to help us identify with, align, and harmoniously "adjust" to an "unseen order." "Were one asked to characterize the life of religion in the broadest and most general terms possible, one might say that it consists of the belief that there is an unseen order, and that our supreme good lies in harmoniously adjusting ourselves thereto." We also find the concept of alignment in Indigenous spiritualities. The Huichol of Mexico, for example, work alignment into the very fabric of their lives. As one researcher notes, "The Huichol notion of the sacred is elusive and in many ways difficult for a Westerner to grasp. It seems to embrace above all the concept of attaining wholeness and harmony. To be in accord

309 Joachim Wach, *Sociology of Religion*, Routledge Library Editions, Volume 16 (New York: Routledge, 1947), 51, https://archive.org/details/in.ernet.dli.2015.188887.
310 Carl W Ernst, *The Shambhala Guide to Sufism* (Boston: Shambhala Publications, 1997), 155.

with one another, with oneself, with one's customs—this is the state of being a proper Huichol and it is sacred."[311]

Finally, as many commentators have pointed out, religion definitely purports to meet our need for connection. It meets our need for outer connection by giving alignment advice on how to get along with people and exist in healthy communities (don't steal, don't sleep with your neighbour's wife). This alignment advice facilitates connection with others. As for inner connection, as we have seen, alignment guidance (which can be found under Ninian Smart's "Ritual and Practical dimension, is designed to facilitate inner connection. More than that, William James, Abraham Maslow, sociologist Joachim Wach, and others have pointed out, religion itself originates in experiences of inner connection to our ancestors, our "angels," and even to the Divine itself. William James in particular saw the core of religion as an individual connection with the divine. As he said...

> ...the *founders* of every church owed their power originally to the fact of their direct personal communion with the divine. Not only the superhuman founders, the Christ, the Buddha, Mahomet, but all the originators of Christian sects have been in this case.[312]

Abraham Maslow echoed these sentiments when he said

> The very beginning, the intrinsic core, the essence, the universal nucleus of every known high religion … has been the private, lonely, personal illumination, revelation, or ecstasy of some acutely sensitive prophet or seer. The high religions call themselves revealed religions and each of them tends to rest its validity, its function, and its right to exist on the codification and the communication of this original mystic experience or revelation from the lonely prophet to the mass of human beings in general.[313]

311 Myerhoff, *Peyote Hunt: The Sacred Journey of the Huichol Indians*, 73–74.
312 James, *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study of Human Nature*, 30: emphasis in original.
313 Maslow, "The 'Core-Religious' or 'Transcendent' Experience," 339.

We do not have to rely on the thoughts of James and Maslow to see that religious experience is a core aspect of religion and that religion serves this inner need. Even a cursory glance at global spiritual traditions reveals the significance of religious connection. It is a core of Aboriginal dream times,[314] dreaming practices,[315] and shamanic vision questions.[316] The main Western monotheisms, Islam, Christianity, and Judaism, all have mystical traditions.[317]

Let us pause for a moment and review. It seems clear at this point that religion, just like all institutions, is an institution set up to meet a complex array of human needs. Substantively, religious institutions themselves consist of several components all geared, more or less, to meeting more than one of humanity's complex array of needs. These components include a social dimension, a ritual/practical dimension, an experiential dimension, a narrative/mythic dimension, a doctrinal dimension, an ethical/legal dimension, and a material dimension.

If we were to stop and define religion at this point, we might provide the following definition.

> *Religion is an institution set up to meet one or more of humanity's seven essential needs, with an essential focus on providing answers to existential imperatives and with supporting and facilitating the satisfaction of alignment and connection needs. A religious institution itself consists variously of social, ritual/practical, experiential, narrative/mythic,*

314 Robert Lawlor, *Voices of the First Day: Awakening in the Aboriginal Dreamtime* (Rochester, Vermont: Inner Traditions, 1991); Steven Strong and Evan Strong, *Out of Australia: Aborigines, Dreamtime, and the Dawn of the Human Race* (Charlottesville, VA: Hampton Roads Publishing, 2017).

315 Ignatia Broker, *Night Flying Woman: An Ojibway Narrative* (Minnesota: Minnesota Historical Society Press, 1983).

316 Harner, *Cave and Cosmos: Shamanic Encounters with Another Reality*; Carmen Blacker, *The Catalpa Bow: A Study of Shamanistic Practices in Japan* (Taylor & Francis, 1999); Mircea Eliade, *Shamanism: Archaic Techniques of Ecstasy* (New York: Penguin Books, 1989).

317 Ernst, *The Shambhala Guide to Sufism*; Isidor Kalisch, *Sepher Yezirah: A Book on Creation* (San Diego: The Book Tree, 2006), https://ia800707.us.archive.org/16/items/Holy-Books/SeferYetzirah.pdf; St. Teresa of Avila, *Interior Castle*, Kindle (New York: Dover Publications, 2007); Ewert H Cousins, "Francis of Assisi: Christian Mysticism at the Crossroads," in *Mysticism and Religious Traditions*, ed. Steven T Katz (Toronto: Oxford University Press, 1983), 163–90, https://amzn.to/2MlagUS; J. Abelson, *Jewish Mysticism* (London: G. Bell and Sons, 1913), https://archive.org/details/jewishmysticism00abel/page/n7.

doctrinal, ethical/legal, and material dimensions all geared towards the satisfaction of various human needs.

This definition, which blends substantive and functional definitions of religion, makes a great deal of intuitive and scholarly sense. Intuitively, if you are a faithful person, if you interact with an organized faith, if you examine that interaction, you will probably see that your interaction with your religion revolves around the satisfaction of one or more of your seven essential needs. You go to Church because you think it does something for you, that it meets some of your needs, or that it provides you with the truth of things. You hang out at Church events because doing so meets some of your psychological or emotional needs. When these things stop meeting your various needs, you stop going to them, perhaps searching around and finding an alternative religion.

On a scholarly level, this definition is highly *productive*, meaning it is a great jumping-off place for research. Rather than focusing you narrowly on the elite/ecclesiastical components of religion, as the Sociology of Religion typically does, and rather the engaging in complicated gyrations to try and assert racist boundaries, this definition points you at the multiple substantive and functional components of what is clearly a complex and nuanced human institution. From the dogmatic impositions of elites, through spiritual experiences at the grassroots, through the way religions meet our needs for community and collective support, this definition frames the field of research in a clear and precise way and provides lots of inspiration for research and investigation.

The First Problem—Boundaries do not Exist

As intuitively sound and productive as this definition of religion might be, there are some problems. The first problem, which is not really a problem in my view, is that this definition does not solve the boundary problem. In fact, it exacerbates it. Consider the substantive side of our definition. All institutions have social, doctrinal, legal, ethical, moral, experiential, and material dimensions. The institution of science, for example, has a social dimension, a ritual dimension (graduation and awards ceremonies), an experiential dimension (including spiritual experiences

and enlightenment experience of eureka and "aha"), a narrative/mythic dimension (we all tell ourselves stories about Darwin, evolution, the Big Bang, an empty universe, etc.), a philosophical dimension, an ethical and legal dimension, and a material dimension. The substantive side of the equation is thus not very helpful. If science has all these things, then how do you distinguish it from religion?

Perhaps we can distinguish science from religion based on its functions. Unfortunately, the situation is not any better here. Religions meet basic needs, that is true, but so do secular institutions like education, family, banking, the Boy Scouts, and so on. Still, we do have those inner needs for alignment and connection. Perhaps we can distinguish religion from science or other institutions by its additional focus on these more spiritual inner needs of alignment and connection. Consider a Boy Scout group, for example. It has all the substantive components of an institution and it arguably meets a subset of the basic essential needs, but it does not meet inner needs for alignment and connection, therefore it is not a religion. Or does it? Even a cursory glance at the Boy Scouts reveals they provide alignment guidance and encourage faithful "connection" to the Divine. Their "Scout Oath" requires them, number one, to affirm their belief and submission to God.[318] They do this because they believe that inner alignment makes them a better, more civically minded person (outer alignment).

So is Boy Scouts a religion?

Or, what about the New Age movement? There are lots of people out there who like to think the New Age movement is somehow different than religion. The New Age movement is all about spirituality and finding your own path while religion is all about authority and tradition. But is it different? Functionally, there is nothing to distinguish religion from the New Age movement. The New Age movement provides for some of the basic needs, like our emotional, psychological, and cognitive needs. It also provides for our inner alignment and connection needs by, for example, providing

318 Bryan Wendell, "About the 'belief in God' Requirement in Scouting," *Bryan on Scouting*, October 3, 2014, https://blog.scoutingmagazine.org/2014/10/03/belief-in-god-scouting/.

advice and guidance on how to "connect" with spiritual guides and "channel higher consciousness.[319]

So if the New Age movement is not different in functional terms, what about on the substantive side? Those attempting to distinguish New Age spirituality from religion will typically point to its lack of a consistent institutional structure and lack of central authority figures.[320] According to advocates, the New Age movement is all about individual spirituality. It is all about choosing your own path and expressing your truths.[321] Because it is all about the individual, it does not have a significant institutional structure; therefore, it must be different than religion. But is that true? When you examine the New Age movement, you clearly see an institutional framework that exists over and above the individual. The New Age movement has its spokespeople and authoritative figures, who will identify themselves as such, its own publishers and bookstores, its material places of worship (trade shows, conferences, workshops), its narrative and mythical dimension (Atlantis, Star Seeds, shape-changing Lizard people, the eschatological denouement of a grand human experiment), and an experiential dimension (New Agers venture of to Machu Pichu, practice mindfulness, channel the spirits). You even see formal institutional structures, like the Theosophical Society, which preserves and propagates the teachings of the matriarch of the New Age Madame Blavatsky and other Theosophical luminaries.

So is the New Age movement a religion or not?

Or what about science? What distinguishes science from religion? Where do we draw the boundaries? Science has all the structural/substantive elements of any human institution *and* it is an institution set up to meet human needs, specifically the cognitive needs to know and understand; but like all human institutions, it meets other basic needs as well, including our physiological needs (scientific advances increase human productivity, provide tools for survival), our emotional needs (conferences, scholarly communities), our psychological needs (graduation and award ceremonies), our need to be powerful and in control over the world, and even our environmental needs for a safe environment

319 Jennifer McVey Cht, "How to Channel," *wikiHow*, 2022, https://www.wikihow.com/Channel.

320 Wade Clark Roof and Lyn Gesch, "Boomers and the Culture of Choice: Changing Patterns of Work, Family and Religion in Contemporary America," in *Work, Family and Religion in Contemporary America*, ed. N Ammerman and Wade Clark Roof (London: Routledge, 1995).

321 Jeremy Carrette and Richard King, *Selling Spirituality: The Silent Takeover of Religion* (New York: Routledge, 2008).

because it helps us with the tools and technology that help us create a safe environment. Science also provides answers to existential imperatives, to big questions. You can see this clearly if you lay out the big questions listed earlier and provide the scientific answers to them.

Is there a higher power?

No, a higher power is not needed to explain the world.

Who am I?

You are a naked ape.

Where did I come from?

You evolved from single-cell organisms.

What is the purpose of life?

To struggle, survive and reproduce.

How was the universe formed?

The universe emerged from the Big Bang.

Science even meets needs for alignment and connection. Two schools of psychology, Humanistic and Transpersonal psychology, are both focused on understanding the spiritual side of things. Scholars in the area even provide guidance on alignment and connection.[322] Stanislav Grof, one of the key founders of Transpersonal Psychology, provides techniques like holotropic breathwork[323] designed to facilitate spiritual connection. More recently, positive psychology has embraced mindfulness, which is a stripped-down version of yoga techniques originally designed to facilitate union with God. In case you did not know, yoga is the Sanskrit for union, meaning union (i.e. connection) with the divine. The opening line of the highly respected and still hugely influential *Yoga Sutras of Patanjali* indicates the work is all about "instruction in Union."[324] The work itself provides opening guidance on mindfulness and control of the "thought-streams," the goal of which is is to move us towards connection to God.

322 Laszlo, Grof, and Russell, *The Consciousness Revolution*.

323 Stanislav Grof, "Technologies of the Sacred - Part Two," *The International Journal of Humanities and Peace* 15, no. 1 (1999): 93–96, doi:https://www.lightningpath.org/readings/Technologies_of_the_sacred_II.pdf.

324 Patanjali, *The Yoga Sutras of Patanjali: Threads of Union*, trans. A. K. BonGiovanni (Palm Desert, CA: Sacred-texts.com, 2013), https://www.sacred-texts.com/hin/yogasutr.htm.

Of course, this original yogic intent is completely lost in positive psychology's appropriation and castration of Eastern spirituality, but that's a story for another time.

As you can see, using comprehensive functional and substantive definitions of religion make it extremely difficult to distinguish science from religion So what's an arrogant westerner going to do? The last line of defense is ontological and epistemic. If you cannot distinguish science from religion based on its substantive or functional components, maybe you can distinguish science on ontological and epistemological grounds.

Ontology refers, basically, to the nature of reality. Two basic ontological perspectives exist, materialism and idealism. Materialism is the position that the only thing real is the material world whereas idealism posits other things, like thought or Consciousness, as a-prior, which means before experience. A materialist would never believe in supernatural beings or a consciousness that exists independent of the physical body, but an idealist, somebody who does not limit reality to atoms, molecules, and their emergent properties, would. **Epistemology** concerns what constitutes truth and how we apprehend it; specifically what methods we use to separate truth from falsehood and opinion.

On the ontological front, scientists *generally* take a materialist and empirical stance. Scientists generally reject supernatural forces and beings to focus their attention on on what you can "see,"in the sense of being measurable in some way. But only generally. Not all scientists, you see, assume a materialist position. We have already mentioned Transpersonal and Humanistic psychology which are branches of psychology that bend away from a strict materialism. Indeed, many scholars cross the materialist boundaries.[325] Some (perhaps many) scientists even have "enlightenment" experiences,[326] forms of connection experience that lead to instant insight and instant solutions to problems. Kekule dreamed the benzine ring, Darwin had innumerable little

325 Elaine Howard Ecklund and Elizabeth Long, "Scientists and Spirituality," *Sociology of Religion* 72, no. 3 (2011): 253–74; Elaine Howard Ecklund, *What Scientists Really Think* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012), https://corpwatch.org/article/what-neoliberalism.

326 Peter Caws, "The Structure of Discovery," *Science* 166, no. 3911 (1969): 1375–80.

illuminations,[327] and not a few hard-nosed physical scientists report mystical experiences.[328] Dossey, a medical doctor, speaks about non-local mind.[329] Some scientists, like psychologist Richard Alpert (popularly known as Ram Dass), have had mystical experiences so powerful they gave up academics and move on to do spiritual work. Even Einstein was not a strict materialist. In fact, Einstein thought mystical experiences were a key part of humanity's evolutionary path *and* he referred to something he called the "old one" which was not a bearded white patriarch (an image of God he famously rejected),[330] but a vast, superior, and inhuman intelligence behind all of creation.[331]

If we cannot draw a clear ontological boundary between religion and science, maybe the difference is methodological. Maybe it is that science has superior training and methods, like the scientific method and peer review, for vetting the truth of things. The general line of argument here is well-rehearsed. Religion derives its knowledge through authority and tradition, while an advanced science is more focused on "positive" empirical testing. In religion, you believe the Bible, the Vedas, or the Koran because at some point somebody (your mom, your dad, a priest, a publisher, etc.) told you that you should. Science, on the other hand, does not kowtow to authority for truth and understanding. Scientists make observations. Scientists do experiments.

There is some merit to this notion. There is definitely a difference between science and religion in their methods. There is no expectation that priests provide proof that God exists, or that they explain God's "mysterious ways." Religious followers are generally advised not to question church doctrine and to use faith (in God, the special avatar who brought "the message") to allay their doubts and questions. Scientists, on the other hand, do the opposite of this. They do not expect you to believe their truths based on their authority. They look for and provide evidence so that you can

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327 Howard E. Gruber, "On the Relation between AHA Experiences' and the Construction of Ideas," *History of Science* 19, no. 1 (March 1, 1981): 41–59, doi:10.1177/007327538101900104.

328 Wilber, *Quantum Questions: Mystical Writings of the World's Great Physicists*.

329 Larry Dossey, *Recovering the Soul: A Scientific and Spiritual Search* (Toronto: Bantam Books, 1989); Dossey, "Nonlocal Mind: A (Fairly) Brief History of the Term."

330 Albert Einstein, "Letter to Erik Gutkind," 1954, https://lettersofnote.com/2009/10/07/the-word-god-is-the-product-of-human-weakness/.

331 Einstein, *The World as I See It*.

decide. Scientists also put a lot of effort into refining and putting into practice their methods for acquiring truth and understanding. They also spend a lot of time going over each other's work to try and eliminate bias and error. When scientists publish papers, other scientists (their peers) examine, evaluate and review their papers before publication to try and remove as any errors.

Because scientists are focused on evidence and not authority, because scientists are continually struggling to improve experimental methods, because scientists place evidence at the centre of their world, because scientists are constantly checking each other's work, scientists are a lot quicker to admit when they have made mistakes. Consequently, *science is self-correcting.* By way of contrast with religion, Catholic doctrine, for example, hasn't changed much in 2,000 years; however, science changes all the time. Witness David Mech, the man who coined the term "alpha male." Mech originally said that wolves organized themselves naturally into dominance hierarchies with an Alpha male on the top. Unfortunately, as he later admitted, he made a huge observational error. He generalized from the behaviour of male wolves held in captivity to wolves in their natural environment.[332] Male wolves respond to the stress of captivity by organizing themselves into dominance hierarchies. However, as he later learned, in their natural environment, wolves function as family units with no single alpha male and with adult male and female wolves acting as responsible parental units. When Mech realized his error, he recanted his mistake and withdrew the term.[333] You don't find the same sort of responsiveness to correct errors in religion. Despite the advancement of human methods and knowledge, religion does not focus on methods and does not change that much.

So, is it this focus on methods and "error correction" which makes science different than religion? Perhaps. But once again, the boundaries are not strict. As we saw earlier, magic and religion are not solely based in authority and tradition. There *is* empirical testing. On the other side, despite the emphasis on empirical methods, scientists are not perfect. Their empirical focus and methodological rigour does not prevent them from making mistakes, nor does it make them necessarily more open-minded and willing to change than the average priest or pastor. In fact

332 David Mech, "Whatever Happened to the Term Alpha Wolf," *International Wolf*, Winter 2008; David Mech, "Outmoded Notion of the Alpha Wolf," 2015, http://www.davemech.org/news.html; David L. Mech, "Leadership in Wolf, *Canus Lupus,* Packs," *Canadian Field-Naturalist* 11, no. 2 (2000): 259–63.

333 Mike Sosteric, "Are Bullies Alpha Males or Sick Puppies," *The Conversation*, 2018, https://theconversation.com/are-bullies-alpha-males-or-sick--93524.

Thomas Kuhn suggested that science was one of the most conservative institutions around. He argued that scientists were rarely prepared to change their fundamental beliefs on the basis of new evidence and that fundamental paradigmatic change required the older generation to die off, because the older gatekeepers were too stubborn to change their thinking.[334] There seems to be some truth in this. Scientists can sometimes be just as closed-minded, autocratic, and absolutist when it comes to its answers to the big questions as any priest or guru. In fact, sometimes, they even act like priests. Yinger notes many scientists sanctify science just like priests sanctify religion, by presenting it as a superior path towards truth. "Sanctity is the quality of unquestioned truthfulness imputed by the faithful to unverifiable propositions...."[335] This is no different than when Copernicus and Galileo were challenging the ontological foundations of the authoritative Church world view. At the time, priests sanctified their religion by claiming an exclusive path to God's truth. They also sputtered and puffed that it was their way or the highway (excommunication), even going so far as to torture and kill heretics who stood outside the Catholic faith. Torture and murder are off the table these days, but two of the staples of priestly authority, public shaming and excommunication, are not. Consider the example of biochemist Rupert Sheldrake who, after publishing a book called *A New Science of Life: The Hypothesis of Formative Causation,* [336] was publicly shamed and summarily excommunicated by a "hysterical" John Maddox, senior editor of the journal *Nature.* The establishment stopped short of burning his book, though they did say it was the "best candidate for burning there has been for many years...."[337] The hostility directed towards Sheldrake when he stepped outside the boundaries of the accepted scholarly canon was severe, the consequences harsh and punitive. Sheldrake was ejected from the academy, thus ending his academic career.[338]

So, is science a religion?

Probably not, although sometimes it functions as such. Whatever personal judgment you make, you can see that the functional and substantive definitions provided in this commentary do not solve the boundary problem, and may actually exacerbate the problem by highlighting all the ways science bleeds

334 Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*.
335 Rappaport quoted in Yinger, *The Scientific Study of Religion*, 12.
336 *A New Science of Life: The Hypothesis of Formative Causation* (London: Paladin, 1987).
337 Freeman, "The Sense of Being Glared At: What Is It Like to Be a Heretic?," 20 Maddox quoted in.
338 Freeman, "The Sense of Being Glared At: What Is It Like to Be a Heretic?"

into religion. As complicated as this makes the situation, the tension between the two poles is probably a good thing. Trying to impose boundaries when they do not in fact exist is an ethnocentric exercise, not a scholarly one. More to the point, humans are complex and creative. They do not honour the boundaries scholars attempt to impose. They can make their institutions serve whatever needs they want and it would be empirically wise if we would admit this. Even a thing like professional sports can be bent to serve certain spiritual needs. As students of human behaviour looking at human religion, we should embrace the messy nature. I can assure you, it won't be wasted effort and we will understand things better in the end.

The Second Problem—Where's the Sociology?

Insert distinction between elite religion and authentic religion. Pick in up in unit two, sociology of religion

Speaking of the messy nature of our institutions, a second problem with the definition of religion provided herein is that it is not quite comprehensive enough. Recall the definition

> *Religion is an institution set up to meet one or more of humanity's seven essential needs, with an essential focus on providing answers to existential imperatives and with supporting and facilitating the satisfaction of alignment and connection needs. A religious institution itself consists variously of social, ritual/practical, experiential, narrative/mythic, doctrinal, ethical/legal, and material dimensions all geared towards the satisfaction of various human needs.*

This definition might look complete, but it is not. This definition provides no awareness of the significance of gender, ethnicity, or social class in the formation and operation of religious institutions. As a sociologist, I can tell you that these are significant factors. We might say this definition is sociologically naive, meaning it does not include any sociological analysis; therefore, we need to expand this definition to include awareness of the sociological aspects of religion. Perhaps the easiest and most lucid way of moving this forward is to use the functional definition of religion as an institution that meets human needs as a starting point. From there, we can say that religion is an institution setup to

address the seven essential needs, but not just the seven essential needs. Religion can be bent to meet other needs that have nothing to do with human growth, human development, and human happiness. Karl Marx for example, saw religion as an institution meeting humanity's need for an anaesthetic to deal with the suffering caused by Capitalism. Capitalism harmed people by depriving them of the full value of their labour, emiserating workers and enriching those who stole the added value produced by their labour. Marx regarded religion as an opiate that numbed workers sense of righteous outrage at the capitalist structures that were the source of the physical, moral and mental harms done to them Karl Marx, *A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1970).. Religion as the "opium of the people" was a narcotic form of pain relief that caused further harm under the Capitalist system. Influenced by Marx, members of the Frankfurt School saw religion as a device used to "enslave and tame" the individual by using higher motivations and higher values to tying its congregation into the capitalist regime of accumulation Roberta Cipriani, *Sociology of Religion: A Historical Introduction* (London: Transaction Publishers, 2000), 147..

We might call needs that do not have anything to do with human growth, human development, and human happiness **non-essential needs**. Non-essential needs are needs that emerge as a consequence of the things that happen around us. If you crash your car and are bleeding, you have a need for immediate medical assistance. This need is, of course, essential in the moment, but it has nothing to do with your biological needs for growth and development. Therefore, it is non-essential.

The need for pain relief in relation to the Capitalist system is a non-essential need. It emerges as a consequence of the suffering caused by the Capitalist Regime of Accumulation. Our need for pain-relief is not the only non-essential need that religion meets. Indeed, religions can be bent to serve many non-essential needs, like an Emperor's need for power a supportive ideology, the needs a patriarch for indoctrination and control of women, a government's need for citizen compliance, a corporations need for profit, etc.

We do not have to go very far to find examples. The Persian autocrat Aradashir took control of the Zoroastrian faith, created his own version, and then mercilessly destroyed popular

alternatives.[339] Zoroastrianism was rooted in the mystical utterances of Zoroaster who lived around 1,000 BCE, but these beliefs were subsequently co-opted, modified in currently unclear ways, and turned into colonial tools by the autocrat Ardashir and his high priest Tanser. Tanser was primarily responsible for writing down Zoroaster's teachings, which existed primarily as word of mouth teachings prior. Tanser began the process of writing down the word of mouth teachings when he declared Ardashir the final arbiter of the Zoroastrian doctrine, suggesting that Ardashir was "more richly endowed with virtues than the ancients...." Tanser further suggested that Ardashir was uniquely qualified to revive a faith that had "decayed" because he was a man of "true and upright judgment…."[340] Once the authority of Ardashir had been proclaimed, Tanser then selected a single Zoroastrian tradition among several that were available in the region, after which he brutally and with "excessive bloodshed"[341] sterilized the Zoroastrian field by suppressing all other word of mouth traditions that existed at the time.

> "...in place of the former fraternity of regional communities, a single Zoroastrian church was created under the direct and authoritarian control of Persia; and together with this went the establishment of a single canon of Avestan text, approved and authorized by Tanser... Tanser set about his business and selected one tradition and left the rest out of the canon. And he issued this decree: The interpretation of all the teachings of the Mazda-worshipping religion is our responsibility." [342]

Why would the autocrat Ardashir claim interpretive superiority, reduce the Zoroastrian faith to a single cannon, and violently subdue competing understandings? The answer to these questions is simple. Ardashir re-created the Zoroastrian faith as an elite master narrative and subsequently used the Zoroastrian religion as propaganda. He used it to consolidate power and gain domination over his enemies. He and his high priest created a master narrative which provided the "sacred" beliefs and values which influenced how people think about themselves and the world and how they act in the world. He used the religion not for the good of humanity and not because he thought it reflected truth, but to

339 Boyce, *Zoroastrians: Their Religious Beliefs and Practices*.
340 Ibid., 103.
341 Ibid.
342 Ibid.

control behaviour. That Ardashir used Zoroastrian word-of-mouth teachings to create a discourse is made clear by Boyce when she says,

> Ardashir was not only a military genius, but a man of great shrewdness and administrative talents, who was prepared to use bloodless means as well as warlike ones to establish his rule and create a new Persian empire; and one of the tools which he chose for this was religious propaganda. There can be little doubt that the priests of Persia, whose forefather had led to Zoroastrian community under the Achaemenians, felt themselves well fitted to do so again; and they plainly undertook with zeal the task of persuading their fellow Iranians that they, together with the new dynasty to which they lent their support, were more devout and orthodox, and would be truer upholders of the faith, than their Parthian predecessors had been.[343]

Aradashir is not the only example of the .001 percent messing around with the spiritual and religious beliefs of this planet. Centuries later.[344] As with Zoroastrian beliefs, which were anti-elite to begin with, Christ was anti-elite with a remarkably progressive mission and message.[345] "The Spirit of the Lord is on me," he said, "because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim freedom for the prisoners and recovery of sight for the blind, to set the oppressed free." (Luke 4:18). Unfortunately, Christ's progressive messaging was a threat to elite prerogative and they had him assassinated.[346] When that did not work to stop the spread of his progressive messaging, Roman Emperor Constantine "converted" to (really, the proper term is co-opted) Christianity and subsequently set about to control and modify (read colonize) the grass-roots Christian narrative.[347] Unlike the case with the Zoroastrian faith, we do have some idea of what the elites did once they captured the cannon and that is, they manipulated it. They did this first by determining what constituted Christian canon and then by

343 Ibid., 101–2.
344 Mike Sosteric, "Rethinking the Origins and Purpose of Religion: Jesus, Constantine, and the Containment of Global Revolution," *Athens Journal of Social Sciences* 9, no. 1 (2020): 69–88, doi:10.30958/ajss.9-1-4.
345 Ibid.
346 Mike Sosteric, "From Zoroaster to Star Wars, Jesus to Marx: The Art, Science, and Technology of Mass Human Manipulation," *Athens Journal of Philosophy*, 2024, doi:10.30958/ajphil.3-4-1.
347 Sosteric, "Rethinking the Origins and Purpose of Religion: Jesus, Constantine, and the Containment of Global Revolution."

hiding the texts away from mass eyes for centuries while elite scribes edited the texts in privacy.[348] What did the scribes add and subtract? It is a question that needs research but we know for sure that they *added* patriarchy to the texts. Edits in the Bible changed how Christians viewed the role of women. Conservatives generally assume the New Testament has a conservative and sexist view of women, and it is certainly a product of its time. However, there is evidence to suggest that Jesus and his apostles had a more progressive view of women's status than most patriarchs would like to admit. For example, in Mathew 22: 24–30, Jesus criticizes the notion that women should be considered property. Here Christians are told the story of a woman who is passed off between seven brothers as if she is property of the family. One by one the brothers die and the wife is forced to marry the next one in line. Finally, she dies and the question is, who will she *belong* to in heaven. Jesus's answer is simple; she will belong to no one.

> 'Teacher," they said, "Moses told us that if a man dies without having children, his brother must marry the widow and raise up offspring for him. Now there were seven brothers among us. The first one married and died, and since he had no children, he left his wife to his brother. The same thing happened to the second and third brother, right on down to the seventh. Finally, the woman died. Now then, at the resurrection, whose wife will she be of the seven, since all of them were married to her?" Jesus replied, "You are in error because you do not know the Scriptures or the power of God. At the resurrection people will neither marry nor be given in marriage; they will be like the angels in heaven.

In other words, when the Kingdom comes, women will not be treated as property. The Bible records that the people listening were "astonished" by this teaching, presumably because it was so out of line with the patriarchy of the day that it elicited audible gasps.

The apparent rejection of women as property is not the only astonishing teaching you find in the Bible. Some early Christians, in particular the apostle Paul, had a very progressive, even non-binary, notion of gender. In Paul's letter to the Galatians, he admonishes them for straying from the truth path. He also dismisses the notion of gender entirely, pointing out the basic spiritual truth that, in Spirit, in Christ,

348 Ehrman, *Misquoting Jesus: The Story Behind Who Changed the Bible and Why*; Mike Sosteric, "Editing the Bible for Patriarchy," *Academia.Edu*, 2020, https://www.academia.edu/43721896.

we are all united as one. “There is neither Jew nor Gentile, neither slave nor free, nor is there male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus.” (3: 28–29)

Women are not property. Male and female are irrelevant. These are remarkably progressive messages that resonate down to this day. And these are not the only ones. We also find in the Bible that women played prominent and active roles in the early Church. Jesus was accompanied by women on his travels, women provided financial support for him and his disciples, he engaged in public dialogue with women and, as Ehrman points out, it was women who were “present at his crucifixion” and who “alone remained faithful to him at the end, when the male disciples had fled” (Matt. 27:55; Mark 15:40–41).[349]

So what happened? Why were women excluded from positions of authority in the emerging Catholic Church even though they clearly were prominent in the beginning? Why do conservative Christian communities often use the Bible to justify the suppression of the female sex, or the persecution of non-binary people? The reality is, the Bible is not the verbatim world of God, it is the result of a struggle, a *contest* between those, like Jesus Christ, representing a more progressive view of human nature and human spirituality, and those propounding a more conservative view where men of power dominate the field. Thus, a certain group of scribes, working for a Church created by Roman Emperor Constantine altered the text with the explicit intent of diminishing the role of women. According to Bart D. Erhman, there is overwhelming evidence that scribes altered original texts “to make them coincide more closely with [their] own sense of the (limited) role of women in the church.”[350] In fact, scribes that edited the Bible literally told women to submit, shut up, and bear children. In 1 Timothy 2, we read

> A woman should learn in quietness and full submission. I do not permit a woman to teach or to assume authority over a man; she must be quiet. For Adam was formed first, then Eve. And Adam was not the one deceived; it was the woman who was deceived and became a sinner. But women will be saved through childbearing — if they continue in faith, love and holiness with propriety.

And in 1 Corinthians 14: 33–36 we find

349 Ehrman, *Misquoting Jesus: The Story Behind Who Changed the Bible and Why*, 178–79.
350 Ibid., 178–79.

> Women should remain silent in the churches. They are not allowed to speak, but must be in submission, as the law says. If they want to inquire about something, they should ask their own husbands at home; for it is disgraceful for a woman to speak in the church.

These two passages provide a very conservative view of women as inferior and submissive breeders. The problem with these passages, as Ehrman points out, is that the entirely of 1 Timothy was not written by the apostle Paul but by somebody who came along later. Similarly, the passage in 1 Corinthians 14 was added later as well. Both justify the extreme suppression of women and both were inserted later as part of a political effort to "suppress the role of women in the churches…."[351] These were not the only changes. "In almost every instance in which a change of this sort occurs, the text is changed in order to limit the role of women and to minimize their importance to the Christian movement."[352] As a consequence of this suppression, the existence of female apostles was erased as was the fact that women played prominent roles in the early Christian church as deacons, preachers, and such.

So what are we to make of this? For one, it calls into question the notion that everything having to do with human spirituality and religion is reactionary and oppressive, as polemicists like Richard Dawkins[353] suggest. In addition, and as a sociologist, I have some questions, most important of which is what exactly was going on? Ehrman limits interference in the sacred scriptures to individual scribes, saying that "scribes sometimes changed their texts in order to make them coincide more closely with the scribes' own sense of the (limited) role of women in the church," but it is unlikely, given the authoritarian hierarchies that characterize the Catholic Church, that scribes worked without direction from their superiors. What is more likely is that elites edited the teachings to serve their own non-essential needs for power and control.

A Zoroastrian faith hijacked by a Persian emperor and a Bible edited in the interests of European patriarchs demonstrates how a human spirituality focused on satisfying essential needs can be hijacked by special interest groups to serve their special-interest needs. These are not the only examples by far. There are lots of examples where elites might have messed around with religion and human spirituality, mucking about and modifying the social, ritual, experiential,

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351 Ehrman, *Misquoting Jesus: The Story Behind Who Changed the Bible and Why*, 181.
352 Ibid., 182.
353 *The God Delusion*.

mythic/narrative, philosophical, ethical/legal, and material dimensions to suit their particular agendas—to meet their needs for power, control, and profit. In fact, when you look, you find their fingerprints everywhere. The patriarch of Protestantism, Martin Luther, came from an established capitalist family. The primogeniture of the modern Tarot system A.E. Waite, a system which the world's foremost tarot scholars called the "...most successful propaganda campaign ever launched"[354] because of how the elite so skilfully imposed their hegemonic frames, was a member of elite Freemason lodges.[355] Helena Blavatsky, matriarch of the modern new age movement and founder of the still-influential Theosophical society was, a member of Russian Dolgorouky dynasty. It is an eyes-wide-open secret, really, and one that is so well hidden in plain sight that even sociologists, a group of scholars who should be the first to identify, analyze, and understand the nature of elite interference in the religious fabric of this planet, have largely missed this point entirely. The closest anybody got was Marx and his buddy Engels, but even their definition and understandings are wholly inadequate, and ultimately dismissive.[356]

If we accept the fact that spirituality is a flexible institution that can meet the essential growth needs of humans and also the non-essential needs of special interest groups, such as patriarchal elites and neo-liberal, multinational corporations, then we need to expand our definition, like so.

> *Religion is a complicated and flexible human institution set up to meet essential* ***and non-essential*** *human needs. Religions are organized around a core emphasis on providing answers to our big questions, with a usual emphasis on the satisfaction of alignment and connection needs as the institutional core. A religious institution itself consists of social, ritual/practical, experiential, narrative/mythic, doctrinal, ethical/legal, material dimensions, and healing dimensions all geared towards the satisfaction of various human needs.*

354 {Citation}
355 Mike Sosteric, "A Sociology of Tarot," *Canadian Journal of Sociology* 39, no. 3 (2014), doi:0.29173/cjs20000.
356 Sosteric, "Rethinking the Origins and Purpose of Religion: Jesus, Constantine, and the Containment of Global Revolution."

This definition is complete and productive, meaning that it gives us a lot of opportunity for study and research. Unfortunately, this definition does not solve the boundary problem. In fact, it completely removes any hope that we might be able to establish such a boundary because there is simply no boundary there, which is fine. Unless our concern is to demonstrate our European/scientific/patriarchal superiority over other institutions and systems of knowledge, we do not need to assert a boundary to study and understand religion. And in fact, we should not. We can productively and meaningfully live with the overlap in institutional substance and function. In fact, I think this is the only way forward. If we continue to insist on drawing strict boundaries, we will be forever stymied in our approach to and understanding of religion. It is only when we put aside our cultural arrogance in favour of respect and reciprocity that we will enable our individual and collective progress forward.

Conclusion

This brings us to an end of this little booklet and our short journey. We started our journey by asking the question, "what is religion?" As we saw, scholars have had a hard time figuring out what religion is. This is because they have been stymied by an Occam-led desire to oversimplify, coupled with ethnocentric,. Eurocentric, and even racist bias. This has resulted in simplistic, caricatured, and frankly embarrassing views and definitions of religion. As we have seen, the way forward is straightforward. We observe what's actually there with an open mind and embrace the complexity. When we do that, religion as an institution that meets several of our essential human needs, as well as some not so essential needs, comes into focus. Of course, if we do this, we forever abandon the possibility of asserting clear boundaries between Indigenous spirituality, Western religion, and other human institutions because these boundaries do not exist—there is simply too much overlap.

5. Serving the Interests of Capital

6. What is Religion Redux II – Is Science a Religion

7. Mystical Peak Experiences

How do you draw all that together in a meaningful fashion?

Well, religious experience is, first of all, an interior experience.[357] You don't have to go to a dumb mall or a lame concert to have one. It happens entirely inside you. Beyond that, Rodney Stark suggests that the "essential element characterizing religious experience, and distinguishing it from all other human experience, is some sense of contact with a supernatural agency....a divine essence, i.e., with God, with ultimate reality, with transcendental authority."[358] Others, in a similar vein, suggest it is a "direct experience of ultimate reality," (Carmody) a oneness with the "Absolute,"[359] Sure, but as we have seen, not all notable interior experiences involve connection with the supernatural. Some are peak experiences, connections and feelings of oneness with nature. Extending the net, R. C. Zaehner says that mysticism is "a unitive experience with someone or something other than oneself." That gets Maslow's peak experience in, but it still leaves questions about what Forman called the "pure consciousness event."[360]

Myself, I would prefer to replace religious/mystical experience/transcendent experience with the term **Connection Experience,** because it's neutral and clear**.** I would then define this experience as a *felt connection* (whether the connection is real or not is a question for later) to something more than the individual ego. This connection could be to anything, to God, to the Gods, to demons, the devil, natural spirits, guides, ancestors, the cosmos, Para Brahma, unmapped neurological functions of the brain, or whatever. The point is connection to something that feels "more" than the individual self. We'll explore this definition more in our chapter on connection experience.

Peak experiences are the types of mystical experiences that atheists have.

> There were the same feelings of limitless horizons opening up to the vision, the feeling of being simultaneously more powerful and also more helpless than one ever was before, the feeling of great ecstasy and wonder and awe, the loss of placing in time and space with, finally, the conviction that something extremely important and valuable had happened, so

357 Philip C. Almond, *Mystical Experience and Religious Doctrine: An Investigation of the Study of Mysticism in World Religions*, Religion and Reason, Vol. 26 (Berlin: Mouton Publishers, 1982).
358 Rodney Stark, *Sociology of Religion: A Rodney Stark Reader*, n.d., 11–13.
359 James, *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study of Human Nature*.
360 Forman, "Pure Consciousness Events and Mysticism."

> that the subject is to some extent transformed and strengthened even in his daily life by such experiences. [361]

Although Maslow takes care to "dissociate this experience from any theological or supernatural reference," anybody who spends anytime studying these experiences will tell you he is describing mystical here. The difference between a peak experience and a religious experience is the conceptual framing.

361 Abraham H. Maslow, *Motivation and Personality (2nd Ed.)* (New York: Harper & Row, 1970), 164.

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